The Sleepover

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25755718.

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Explicit

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by MxSinshine

Summary

Two weeks have passed since Prime's defeat; peace bestowed upon the land by true love's kiss. All is well.

Or it would be if Adora and Catra were at least talking to one another. Catra is trying to relax after a long, exhausting war and keep on bettering herself. Adora is mapping out recovery efforts as the heroine for all. They'll make time for one another to figure out their relationship in the new world- eventually.

At least if Glimmer has any say on the matter, they sure will; a mission together and a vacation away from Bright Moon Castle ought to do the trick. Catra did tell her they used to have sleepovers…

Notes

Hey all! I'm jumping on the never written any fanfiction/post-season 5 craving bandwagon (with a smattering of what else is there to do in quarantine?).

Will happily take any and all constructive feedback; hope you enjoy!

PS- Nothing mature now, just prepping for the future!

The Plan

"Hey, Adora." Catra murmured lazily, sidling up behind Adora. That voice, that phrase… Hearing it caused Adora to tense up instantly. But unlike so many times in their recent past, the tension was not based in fear for her very life (or unbridled irritation). No, nothing like fear. Breathless, exhilarating excitement, causing her to turn into an absolute bumbling fool? Yeah, that was closer.

"Oh! Um, hey, Catra… I was just…" She glanced around at the papers strewn across her desk. Who knew that the aftermath of overthrowing a galactic evil empire would amount to so much paperwork? It hadn't even been a full two weeks since Prime's defeat! But there were displaced civilians everywhere, storehouses that needed filled, and tons of infrastructure to rebuild. While the princesses had stronger ties to one another more than ever, each one had her own territory at the forefront of her mind. Which meant discussion after discussion about why Thaymor deserved more help than Erelandia or why this princess or that kingdom couldn't possibly help *right* now... It was exhausting and more than a bit petty, if Adora could be truthful about her friends. She had healed the land, she had returned its magic, and not to mention taken down an interstellar tyrant. Yet the princesses were letting things like borders and territories get in the way of helping to finish the job. Perhaps Prime's scars of discord ran deeper through Etheria than any one cared to admit.

Catra peeked over Adora's shoulder, barely registering the mass of pages. "Yeah, yeah, you brought peace to the land, but now need to maintain it…," Her eyes narrowed, obviously trying her best to repress an eye roll, as she turned away. "Heroine of the galaxy, savior of the universe…"

Seeing her turn away sparked fear; Adora quickly rose from the desk, spilling half the papers to the floor. *Dammit, that was all in order... No, focus, Adora. Catra is here!*

"No! I mean, yes, I suppose so… But, um, you could stay with me while I…" Adora didn't need to see her face to know that wasn't exactly Catra's idea of a rollicking good time. She was able to picture the deep eye roll the suggestion had inevitably garnered just fine. Adora paused and sighed inwardly, thoughts racing to try and gain some traction over the situation. She was here, Catra had sought her out. Thinking about it, when was the last time they had talked- more than a quick good morning or a simple have a good night? Anxiety and guilt gripped her as Adora realized she wasn't entirely positive of the answer. Where was a universe-ending threat when you needed one, that did the trick last time.

The hours directly after the Heart were utter bliss, like the sweetest dream. The two of them together, linked arm in arm, completely unwilling to be apart for the briefest moment as the world just carried on around them. Adora smiled warmly at the memory of Catra in her arms that night, purring contentedly against her chest as they slept out under the stars. It felt so right and so *good*.

But the next morning came too quickly, real life barreling in to wake them from their idyllic bliss. Too soon Adora was ripped away into duty and responsibility, every person needing yet another piece of her time. Discussion after discussion, plans to address what was the most critical and pressing at the time... If Adora was being honest with herself, maybe she had allowed the work to consume her again on purpose. What came next for the world wasn't necessarily *easy*, but it was familiar territory. Rebuild a crumbled building, restock supplies and goods, and maybe even get to use the boundless strength of her warrior avatar for some back-breaking task. Adora was all there for that.

But figure out next steps with the woman she had loved even before she knew what love was? That was far more daunting, a bigger challenge than the blonde had ever faced. Sure, the two had shared a moment (and what a moment it was!), had finally confessed their love for one another, and of course, Adora's attention couldn't help but drift towards the memory of their one and only kiss. (*So far… maybe?*) But there hadn't exactly been a

lot of time for relationships when a world needed to be put back together. At least that's what the blonde had asserted to herself. So, Adora had gently put that to the side, vowing to return to the subject of her and Catra as soon as she could, a few days at the most… then ran head first into trying to fix the world again.

Catra watched it happen placidly the first couple days, shaking her head warmly at the woman who just couldn't relax. This is what she does and what she'll always do… *Catch up on your sleep for now and let the heroine of Etheria do her job. Being jealous of her is what got you into all that mess before; she'll come back and be yours after the work's done.* Catra felt especially proud of that moment, still feeling fortified by their moment at the Heart, as well as the thrill at the thought of Adora being hers. She could wait- she'd been waiting her whole life at this point; what was another few days?

However, as the days turned into a week, the resolve around her proud moment dissipated. Irritation at the situation (she purposefully did not allow herself to say abandonment- growth, growth, growth) expanded more and more. Not wanting to lash out, Catra had taken to seeking out sunny places to nap about the castle in the afternoons and breezy elevated perches at night, taking solace in solitude. When she grew restless, she stalked the surrounding grounds, avoiding other citizens but taking in as much of her new territory as she could. A few times even, Flower Girl had cornered her, inviting Catra to join her in a mid-afternoon meditation session. Not her favorite way to spend a day but eh, it also passed the time. This wasn't the life she wanted to be having, but after so many hours of lost sleep running the Horde and that ever-burning desire to see the world fully still in her gut, it was the one she'd take. For now.

But if there was a chance she could instead get life how she wanted it, she had to try. Catra called over her shoulder, her tail swishing back and forth. "A sleepover."

"Huh?"

She glanced back at Adora, her blue eye softening with barely concealed amusement as Adora struggled through the conversation whiplash. It was so very easy to confuse her. And Catra had spent too long pretending to hate that stupid, goofy face of Adora's to not savor every wave of unconcealed emotion that broadcasted across. She felt the annoyance she'd been cradling this week fade. Adora had a one-track mind. It was time to get that track back on her. "You heard me. We're having a sleepover."

Adora nearly planted her face into the floor at the statement. A… sleepover? Here, in Bright Moon? Having not had much time to figure out where they stood- proclamations of love aside, the pair's sleeping arrangements thus far had been distant. Back at the Fright Zone, almost every night Catra curled up at the foot of her bed, but now (when it could definitely mean more than just sleeping) the pair wordlessly agreed that a hurried good night and their separate ways was just fine, thank you very much. Or so Adora had figured.

Discomfort streaked across Adora's face and she sought to reconcile the multitude of emotions cascading over her. Fear, sure; guilt, check, but also something deep in her rumbled in delight at the prospect of a sleepover with Catra. *Catra… Alone with Catra. Sleeping wit- NEXT TO CATRA!* Adora could feel discomfort turn to panic as her thoughts threatened to roil out of control, especially with the quick correction of prepositions. 'With' definitely had a different meaning than 'next' in this situation. All from this strange feeling that she didn't have a full grasp of. It wasn't that it was completely foreign to her- especially when it came to situations involving the feline woman. She wasn't completely naive; people talk, Adora listens, and she'd definitely committed a thing or two to memory. But talk was different than action… That was the source of the panic so apparent on her face.

Eyes narrowing for real this time, Catra's tail flicked a back and forth, its rhythm a little more stacco. An arm raised up across her chest, as she took in the blonde's near-horrified reaction. No longer cute; definitely annoying, if not downright hurtful. Was the

prospect of spending time together really that bad in Adora's eyes? *Is that why she's been throwing herself into her work-again?* Catra gripped herself tighter, trying to shut out the thoughts as they coiled around her mind tighter, panic growing, manifesting in anger. It seemed like all her progress was slipping down the drain and just after one conversation. *Does she not want me after all…?*

The sudden drop in mood was acute enough to bring even Adora out of her own head. *Focus now, freak out later.* Adora shook her head rapidly, physically clearing her mind as her blue, googly eyes practically rattled around in her skull. "Okay! A sleepover… Um, just like before, when we were kids…" Her stomach dropped instantly as Catra's eyes became near slits and the feline turned away fully again, preparing to leave. Done, she was done. Why had Catra agreed to this stupid plan… Oh, yeah. Out of hope. Dumb.

No, nope, wrong. Let's not equate this to childhood trauma coping methods, you moron. Adora took a deep, fortifying breath, steeling herself to face what (who) she'd been avoiding and looking to thaw the freeze in the tempestuous winter of a woman before her before it was too late. *Not gonna lose her again!*

Adora stepped forward, first step almost faltering, but then each one after growing more determined as she sought to close the distance between them and quickly. She was in control. She was an adult. She could do this. "No, not like that. What I mean is, yes, I would love that. We haven't gotten any time together, really, since... everything." Adora gently laid her hand on Catra's shoulder, hoping feverently that the damage wasn't permanent. *I know I'm an idiot, but please, please let me fix this.* Adora hoped that was what her grip said.

"Glad you finally noticed," Catra muttered, lip pulling up slightly, though she stopped walking away and let her arm drop down to her side, tail lowered. Catra turned to appraise the woman right in front of her, noticing the hand on her shoulder with more than a

slight flicker of warmth. Oh that touch, how she missed and craved it.

Catra dared to look into the blue eyed visage before her, silently exalting as she noticed the blonde's shift from dopey, anxious twit to resolved and *interested* twit. It was a start, a start worth building on. She pushed away her doubts, deciding to capitalize on this momentum. "Courtyard in two hours and then we're leaving."

Relief showered through Adora instantly. Excellent, she avoided the storm and was getting a break! She didn't even care what Catra might be up to, where they might be going, or what work might not be completed while she was gone. That simply didn't matter any more- shouldn't have been the focus before. Adora's priorities were absolutes and she was finally ready to make them the top priority. Her fear be damned.

"How about one hour instead?" She challenged, a smirk drawing up the corners of her mouth, growing more pronounced as Catra's eyes softened at her suggestion. "I'll leave a note for Glimmer and Bow to handle this mess, pack a bag and then be ready. You're more important." The challenge faded off her lips and her face grew earnest, concerned even.Yes. Catra was more important; why hadn't that occurred to her before now? Adora was willing to accept that all this could be someone else's problem for a few days. *It doesn't always have to be you…* Projected in the back of her mind, a haunting and too recent memory.

Catra had to turn away at that last sentence to keep from melting into a giant puddle on the floor. Okay, so this had been the right call. Focused on making the world's problems her own, Adora needed a little push in the right direction. Or as Catra was prepared, a giant shove. Well, after getting a slight nudge from an outside source herself.

Glimmer was the one who came up with the idea of a getaway for the pair, privately tired of these *utterly useless lesbians*. She was queen and she was not going to stand for complete stupidity

under her own roof. Not sleeping in the same room, barely even talking to one another? No way that was going to stand. Even Bow, definitely the less meddlesome of the pair, agreed something had to give.

Which is what led the young queen to seek out her feline guest. "You know, my family has a number of properties about the kingdom, private, secluded properties where people can… talk." Glimmer had coyly announced to Catra as she lay about bathing in the sun of the castle courtyard. Eyes not even bothering to flick open in greeting, mildly annoyed at her nap being interrupted, Catra had to bite back the immediate comment of, *Private properties that could be, y'know, housing the displaced civilians currently struggling if you were doing your job right there, Sparkles...* But she did not bring voice to the thought; Catra was trying to keep the biting sarcasm to a minimum- externally, at least. Personal growth and all.

"And, purely for measures to protect the land and its people, I do need a small team to check and see if they could provide suitable accommodations for my citizens- did they sustain any major damage, are the surrounding land's recovering as expected, y'know, routine stuff." Glimmer looked like she could just burst with excitement at her own cleverness. A private mission for the two avoidant lesbians? If this didn't work, she'd already resolved to have a large bed set up in the Bright Moon prison and toss the pair in for a week or two. They'd fight it out or find some "other" way to spend their forced quarantine… But Bow called that one plan Z.

Ah, there we go Queen Sparkles, so you do have the people in mind. Catra was now extra glad she had kept her mouth shut. She made a mental note to tell Perfuma during their next meditation session, when that ever perky pest asked her for her "two successes and one even more effective". The peace meditation could bring didn't bother her, at least for those fleeting moments so far she was able to get there, but sometimes it just felt like Flower Girl was overdoing it a bit sometimes.

"Perhaps you and Adora could…" Catra's ears perked up at that, slowly raising herself to regard her royal Sparkliness.

It didn't take Catra long to agree. An opportunity to finally be alone, talk about the things that needed to be discussed… Though Catra could also hurl at the prospect. But maybe it wouldn't be so bad and if anything, she could take solace that Adora and her abs would finally be hers for a couple days, her pulse quickening at the prospect, a mischievous grin at the thought sneaking onto her lips. Abs and muscles, that body and… She would brave talk for a chance at that body.

Tension

Chapter Summary

> Before that could merit further investigation on Catra's part, she chose to roughly shove a bag into Adora's arms. Adora hadn't even noticed Catra had anything on her person. In fact, she was only dimly aware there were things in the world other than Catra in this moment. "Carry my things?" Eyelashes battered at Adora innocently, causing the pool of heat in her low belly from earlier to return. What defense did she have against touch and fluttering lashes?

Chapter Notes

> I want to thank everyone for taking the time to read this piece, not to mention those who have commented/left kudos! It means so much to me to join such a supportive community.
>
> As always, I will happily accept any constructive feedback and the chance to improve my work! Enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora could admit, she was excited. Not that excitement was a rare feeling for her, but she was just so delighted at the chance to slip away from work for a few days and even more enthralled with the company she would be keeping. *Catra, days away with just Catra.* A dopey grin spread across her face as she reflected. Their interaction earlier hadn't been perfect; she groaned and smacked her palm against her own forehead at the memory of the "...like when we were kids" comment. It really was a wonder that Catra hadn't completed her exodus from the room over that particular morsel of idiocy.

Still, when all was said and done, it had worked out okay. And that was enough for Adora; only the end results mattered.

She could also admit that her focus had very much shifted. Planning, infrastructure renovation, and mediation between the leaders were so laughably distant from the focal point of her mind now. Instead of shying away from Catra, Adora could not move quick enough to pack a bag for their trip. She even momentarily questioned the need for clean clothes and toiletries, just so they could leave faster, before ultimately deciding that was a bad idea all around. *Her nose is so sensitive, probably best to not be stinky.*

But it was unmitigated agony being away from her even for this short amount of time. Adora's thoughts grew more frenzied as she stuffed things into a knapsack haphazardly. What had she been thinking these past two weeks? Two weeks of time with Catra just *wasted* . Who knows what they could have been up to during that time- there might have even been kisses! While the memory of Catra's lips on hers at the Heart would forever be engraved onto her soul, Adora also really, really wanted to know what it would feel like when she wasn't on the brink of death. And yet, as she remembered their kiss, a twinge of fear crawled up her spine and her brain jerked away in discomfort.

Hmm, where had that come from? Really, what had she been avoiding so decidedly during this time? Adora's brow furrowed as she pondered her own question, and packing was momentarily forgotten. She had never avoided Catra before, even when they were fighting. *Especially when we were fighting.* She half-smiled at the memories of how quickly the cat could lead her away, separating her from everyone else to play a game of chase where

the only possibility was for Catra to come out on top. Oftentimes literally.

Maybe it was that they had vocalized their romantic feelings for one another. Adora had always thought of herself as pretty self-aware, maybe not forthright about it to others, but at least usually knew what was going on in her own head. There had been a time in her life where without question a concept like love would have been completely incomprehensible to her. But she had also spent enough time in the real world, and away from the Horde, to see examples of love in all its forms. Platonic but so tender (Best Friend Squad- at least from her perspective; Bow and Glimmer were anything but platonic). Romantic and enduring through hardship (Netossa and Spinnerella affectionately came to mind). Not to mention love between neighbors and family, and a kind of love that came from strangers uniting together under a single goal. Adora felt suddenly so incredibly grateful to have witnessed these things in her life. It was the healing balm on the wounds of her formative years that she didn't even know she had needed.

But, she privately had to admit to herself she had had a Catra-shaped blind spot for most of her life, especially when it came to love. Was she really shying away from her romantic feelings after they had faced the end of the world together? It was an unnerving thought. Everything had been so resolute at the Heart; an unerring and permanent *fact of the universe* that she was, and always had been, in love with Catra. And she supposed it still was fact even if apparently, it was so frightening to her that she ignored Catra for nearly two weeks. *All I can do now is face what's bothering me and try to fix it on my own. For her. For us.*

Still something left her feeling not entirely settled on the matter. It was like the pieces fit together, but there were still a few gaps

around the edges. Even though she could see the openings, Adora was also aware her hour was ticking away steadily so she closed up her thoughts for now and came back to the present. Looking down into her own hand, Adora couldn't help but chuckle at her own expense. Only she would have a moment of introspection while clutching a pair of underwear.

Speaking of underwear, how many pairs should I bring? Catra hadn't exactly been very forthcoming with details… I wonder how many she's bringing with her?

...Oh. Catra and underwear in the same thought. *Catra in her underwear… Catra NOT wearing any underwear...*

A warm heat spread low across her abdomen, as Adora was instantly lost to the pictures in her head. She imagined the vixen, clad only in a skin tight panty set, crooking a finger towards her, rasping out a soft and slow "Hey Adora…" And when she obeyed that sultry command, Adora was treated to the vision of Catra placing Adora's hands on her hips, drawing their bodies closer and closer together until they were completely flush. She reveled in the thought of how Catra's body would feel against her own, tighter than they ever had before and with decidedly less clothing to interfere on Catra's side. The image continued, with Adora leaning down towards Catra's hot, ready mouth the feline's fangs slightly beared in delicious anticipation of the contact. Though it was just a fantasy, Adora could almost feel Catra's breath against her skin. Her own body responded to her thoughts; the heat was growing and reaching ever downwards, her pulse was quickening, face flushing, and then- panic, fear, and mental anguish.

She gasped out loud in surprise at her own jump in emotions; talk about conflicting feelings! That was the longest daydream she'd ever allowed herself to have about Catra *like that* . Adora had definitely wanted to see where that was going... Except she also was beginning to feel physically sickened with trepidation at letting the scene continue to play out.

With perfect clarity born only from the state of reflection she had been in mere minutes ago, Adora realized that had to be it. That was the piece that didn't fit quite right: she wasn't afraid of being in *love* with Catra, she was afraid of being in lust with her!

Adora normally cringed away from those kinds of thoughts. Sure, she listened to her friends talk and crack dirty jokes, but it was always with a quiet detachment from the conversation. Adora could compartmentalize with the best of them. But to be struck with thoughts that she barely kept down as a teenager, when she was forced to see the object of her affection in a whole variety of situations- sweat covered and panting hard as they trained, wrapped in just a towel after the showers, and of course (her favorite and most hated), Catra's face just inches above her, straddling her hips after a pounce. She learned quickly to press down every urge, strangle every stray thought along those lines that dared to enter her mind *in case someone was watching* . And someone was always watching in the Horde: the other cadets, ready to turn you in for the slightest infraction, the Imp recording your every move for Hordak's review, or worst of all, even Shadow Weaver herself could be lurking around any given corner.

So, as a defense mechanism, Adora began to just turn it off. Stop the thoughts and start the work. She used work (or training or planning or...) to completely avoid having any sort of conscious sexual thought. Laughing out loud at something that was so

profoundly unfunny to her, Adora realized *that* was her true weakness; sorry Netossa. Though the hair envy might also be a thing.

Turning off her sexual impulses had been the only way to stay safe, the only way to keep what little intimacy she was allowed to have with Catra intact. Be the best in the squad by pushing herself to her absolute physical limit and maybe seniority would overlook the questionable camaraderie between the two girls. That one also came with the added bonus that she would be too physically exhausted to process seeing the sweat dripping down Catra's supple body. Turn it off, work harder. If she followed Shadow Weaver's commands with unfaltering dedication and without question, there was the possibility that she would ignore Catra for a while. Adora would then get to hear Catra's beautiful laughter instead of watching her endure undeserved misery. If things really lined up for the pair, they could escape to the balcony together to watch the sunset and just be present with one another for a few fleeting minutes. She couldn't stop the emotional draw she felt towards Catra, but she could clamp down on her physical response. It was what had been best for them at the time.

And after she had left the Horde… Well, the catalyst wasn't always there with her, but sometimes Catra definitely was. The dance at the Princess Prom was an exception to her verboten desires; Adora was fully aware of where her leg had ended up during the dip in their dance. But also, her mental facilities had been fully focused on figuring out the feline woman's scheme at the time rather than dictating where her body had decided to put itself. It had been a slip-up; one she nearly paid for with Glimmer's life.

Even as her emotional intelligence grew and she acclimated into the new world of the Rebellion, Adora still pressed down those thoughts and urges. Mostly out of habit, but also no one else had really sparked it within her, at least enough to want to pursue it in any way. There was only Catra for her in that department.

Adora was breathing shallowly and quickly, heart beginning to hammer. She was afraid. She was afraid of *sex* . How completely embarrassing was that! Great, just great. Already half-convinced she would never be a fully functional adult, this pretty much just sealed the deal. It all made perfect, sickening sense. While she was devoted to others and felt her best when she was giving her all away, such behaviors also allowed her to work out this coping mechanism as she developed this crippling fear. Distraction through duty and drudgery. And now when she had the chance to build the relationship of her dreams, she leaned right into her favorite defense mechanism instead.

It was amazing we even had one kiss... Adora thought bitterly, lowering her head in shame and defeat at this unforgivable weakness in her.

… But you did. A small voice murmured far back behind the voices that were berating for her spinelessness. The voice was barely audible over the cacophony but still perceptible. *You did. You let her kiss you and it was so nice. Because you felt safe with her.*

The quake of fear began to lessen as she gave consideration to this new suggestion. Safe with her, yes, she had felt safe; inexplicably considering they had literally been facing down the end of the universe at the time. But it was true, she had always felt secure with Catra even when things were so decidedly dire

and strained. Adora gave a shuddering exhale as the weight of this discovered facet of her being settled in. To realize a deep fear, and hopefully discover its cure, all in the span of about ten minutes was jarring to say the least. This self-realization was likely a good thing. Perhaps there could be a middle ground where she allowed herself to think some dirty thoughts without wanting to throw up or shut down in terror. Adora wasn't great with moderation, but maybe she could with this.

If nothing else, she was certain of one thing. She may have lost that time with Catra, but Adora vowed to make up for it on their vacation. And when Adora set her mind to something, nothing would stop her.

Laying across a stone ledge in the courtyard on her side, Adora found Catra waiting. Adora halted several feet away, utterly mesmerized. Catra looked like a sculpted work of art; one Adora could gaze at for hours. Her long, graceful limbs were tucked pleasingly around her, left arm supporting her head. Catra's eyes were closed as she dozed, face tilted to languish in the sunlight. Said sunlight dappled against her skin, enhancing the obvious strength of the muscles that rippled beneath… Adora's breath hitched as she drank Catra in. Her eyes poured over each tantalizing, leatherbound curve before finally stopping to linger on the small window of exposed flesh near her cleavage. Despite the balmy air, Adora shivered.

Okay, moderation. You're looking at Catra, examining her, and allowing yourself to enjoy her beauty. This isn't scary at all- well, not mortal peril levels of terror at least. You're doing good, champ. Every fiber of Adora's being began to scream at her to

close the distance between them. She needed to be nearer the beautiful masterpiece laid out like a banquet in front of her. But Adora's brain was rooted to the spot. The longer she quenched herself with Catra's beauty, the more the door to her terror found purchase. It was the feeling from earlier, the feeling of panic that caused Catra to turn away, so obviously done with Adora's shit. She closed her eyes, allowing the clashing emotions to battle for dominance in her brain and trying to settle herself.

You're not in the Fright Zone anymore. You're in Bright Moon's castle courtyard. Shadow Weaver is gone, Hordak is… Changed? Reformed? At least too busy with Entrapta to notice or care about anything going on in your life. The Horde is gone. You're safe; you're with her. That managed to calm most of her fear and Adora was resolved to approach the living goddess before her.

Before she could move completely into her orbit, Catra opened her eyes, appraising the blonde. "Fifty eight minutes and twelve seconds… Any pressing concerns for your remaining one minute, forty eight seconds of Hero Duty?" Mirth twinkled in Catra's eyes, a smirk pulling at her lips. Though she had appeared to be in a doze, Catra had noticed that Adora had been noticing her. A purr resounded deep in her throat at the absolute pleasure of it. This was far more like it. She loved being the center of Adora's attention. *Mine.*

"N-Nope! Get me out of here. They can dock the time from my pay." Adora chuckled at her own joke, thankful for the playful banter. That was safe and it reinforced that Adora was secure with Catra. She chose to close the distance even further. However, the closer she got, the quicker her breathing became. *Would you calm down for two seconds? You're walking up to her, not getting ready to bend her over.* A tiny noise of distress eked out of her mouth,

as of course, she was now picturing Catra bent over in front of her. *Should have seen that one coming…*

Catra shook her head at the blonde's "wit" as lept from the ledge, lithly landing and stepping right in front of her. She lightly placed a hand on Adora's upper arm, shuddering internally at the feel of her smooth, warm skin and steel muscle beneath. She had so much affection for this big idiot, despite herself. As Catra ran her fingers over the blonde's arm, she couldn't help but notice a reciprocal twitch in the arm she was caressing. *Interesting…*

Before that could merit further investigation on Catra's part, she chose to roughly shove a bag into Adora's arms. Adora hadn't even noticed Catra had anything on her person. In fact, she was only dimly aware there were things in the world other than Catra in this moment. "Carry my things?" Eyelashes battered at Adora innocently, causing the pool of heat in her low belly from earlier to return. What defense did she have against touch and fluttering lashes?

*She *just* touched* your arm; *would you get a handle on your big, gay self for two seconds? Even if it makes you want to get all up on *her* big, gay self.*

Moderation. Moderation. Reel it in. This was just Catra being Catra; she loved trying to get a rise out of Adora, everyone knew that.

"Yeah! Yup, you got it. Sure will!" Catra couldn't help but smile at the overenthusiastic display. She was so pure and wholesome.

"And I'm ready when you are. Got a bag packed and everything!" Adora turned slightly to show her own rucksack slung across her back, obviously proud that she had the mental capacity to pack supplies, all on her own.

"Let's go then." Catra's voice came out soft and breathy as she turned away, hips sashaying of their own accord. She could feel Adora's eyes on her backside, watching intently. *Very interesting indeed...*

Adora's thoughts ricocheted around her skull, slamming into one another. Only one managed to stay firmly lodged in the part of her brain that was still functioning and while it was complete gibberish, it was definitely centered around that ass. *That curvy, curvy ass on such a slender frame, nestled so perfectly against hips she knew would fit so nicely in her hands. An ass that was just begging to be…*

It was too much. Instantly, she crumbled and drew up her shields. Maybe it wasn't too late to say she had a ton of work to do, actually, and perhaps they could leave in a couple hours? She felt jerked about in a nauseating and swaying pendulum- *sex is terrifying, sex is all I think about now, sex is terrifying…* And she just wanted it to stop for five minutes, just to have some respite.

"Adora, now." Right, right. They were walking now, that's what was happening. Adora played follow the leader to the beat of the swaying hips before her, even as her heart pounded to its own horrified beat.

Several hours had passed since leaving the castle grounds, the pair traveling the paved and known highway. The weather was mild with a slight twinge of magic permeating the air around them. Adora could feel weeks of tension slide from her shoulders as they walked further and further from the castle. In the peaceful surroundings, her inner turmoil had also dispersed; no longer was she feeling pulled from urge to dread. Instead she was enjoying herself, content to just *be.*

Catra was still a bit ahead of her, hips no longer swaying so provocatively (much to Adora's relief and chagrin). Still, she could not peel her eyes off the woman ahead of her. Adora was thinking about closing the gap and walking side by side with her. Maybe even daring to grab her hand. A little touching had never really bothered her; that was apparent from all the hand holding in space. It was the prospect of touching certain areas that completely unhinged Adora. But hand holding should be okay and she *really* wanted to be closer to Catra right now.

Just as her gait picked up with the goal of reaching her in mind, Catra quickly turned off the main road, scouting ahead a tad in the somewhat overgrown thicket. *Mmm, well, not the plan.*

"Catra? Where-"

"Right here, just keep walking straight ahead. You saw where I went, I know you were looking right at me…" The tone was more than a little suggestive.

Adora turned faintly pink as Catra completely unraveled her calm. It certainly couldn't be denied, but was it that apparent that she had been watching? *Yes, Adora; you obvious lesbian.* Glimmer's exasperated voice echoed in her head at her own silent question. Well, could anyone blame her for enjoying the view when Catra went around the world looking like that? Looking so tight and sensual, like a damn sex-demon sent to drive Adora crazy. *Uh-oh, you're starting to spiral again. Just keep moving forward and bring it back in.*

She trampled on ahead, not as dexterous through the brush as the cat had been. There was a small trail beaten into the ground once the thicket cleared a bit. It looked to be an animal trail of some sort or maybe an old path that had grown over from lack of use. Still it was way better than having to forge their own way through Adora reasoned as she finally came to stand near Catra.

"We'll stay on this path for a while." Catra said simply, giving no outward indication that she registered Adora coming to stand by her side. Internally, Catra preened at the company. It felt good to be around her... though it also reminded Catra of how much she had missed the other girl's presence recently. The feeling of missing Adora so intensely itched at Catra's heart, though she attempted to bat it away. *You're together now and heading somewhere new; this is a good thing!*

Nothing good ever stays, Catra. You know this. It sounded way too similar to Shadow Weaver; anxiety began gnawing at her stomach.

The pair was alone in the woods, only a few miles from the destination Sparkles had ordered them to. At least Catra hoped;

being able to teleport somewhere instantly didn't give one the best sense of direction. She was putting an awful lot of trust into the queen's ability to give directions and with this whole plan overall. If the stupid plan did work, Catra might even say thank you to the meddling, sparkling menance. She was beginning to question the part where Glimmer assured her that a "romantic journey" through the countryside would be far better than just teleporting them there. As much as Catra hated the feeling of teleportation, she couldn't argue with the end result of getting somewhere immediately. She was anxious to be done with this part of the adventure, even if she knew that once they were there they would need to talk. And talk with a capital T.

Talking was not exactly Catra's favorite pastime. She was always down for a flippant comment or definitely sign her up for a sarcastic remark. But Catra knew that wouldn't fly in this situation. Or at least, if she wanted to not repeat the patterns of her past again, they shouldn't fly. This needed to be faced head on, like a battle… Her fists tightened, claws involuntarily slipping out, at the notion of battle. Memories of more difficult times began crushing her. *No wonder she's been avoiding you; think of all the damage you've done! You are a source of bloodshed and pain, not love and comfort.*

Recently Catra hadn't allowed herself to let these destructive thoughts take any root. But her resolve was just gone, the world too much for her right now. She had been ostracized for weeks by the woman she loved so desperately, now she was hearing her life's tormentor resound in her skull. Not to mention she was so utterly scared to discuss her feelings with Adora. The torrent of her own thoughts threatened to overwhelm her.

Being near Catra was starting to freak Adora out. Not that walking together was anything suggestive; no that wasn't what was bothering her. Things currently didn't feel *right* between them. Adora didn't understand; things were starting to get *better* back at the castle. At least once Adora got her priorities in order. The two women had always been at parallels with one another but it was lines that ran concurrently. Adora just couldn't get a sense of her right now. It completely unnerved her.

Where are you? Maybe more pressing- where are we? She still had no idea where the pair were headed. She considered the beauty next to her, still trying to get a read on her mood. Catra was off in her own world and her claws were partially out. *What was that all about?* Adora didn't sense any danger around them, looking around to assess her surroundings. No external danger from what she could tell. "Sooo… Can I ask where we're headed yet?" Maybe some conversation would bring her back to the real world.

No response. Just noiseless footfalls against the loam. This was serious; wherever Catra was right now, she shouldn't be alone with it. "Uh, Catra? Everything okay?" Adora reached hand towards her, lightly brushing the top of hand.

The contact jarred Catra out of her headspace. The touch was so gentle against her hand, an uncertain caress. It spoke of concern and was brushed with love. The unspoken meaning of the gesture grounded her. *If she can still love me after all that…*

"What, yeah, fine." She instantly hated non-answer but it was really all she could manage in her present state.. Despite how unsatisfactory it must have sounded Adora's fingers slowly slid

down to grasp Catra's hand more concretely, carefully avoiding claws. Catra responded by latching on tight and lacing them together firmly. *I just need you to choose me, princess. That makes the bad thoughts go away.*

The women stood hand in hand amongst the trees on a forgotten path. Slowly Catra eased, her reign of self-torment coming to an end. She felt grounded enough to finally relent with some information after delighting for several minutes in Adora's touch. "Actually, Princess, they won't be docking your pay this time. We're on a mission." Catra was proud of the quip; a call back to the blonde's stupid joke from earlier she knew Adora would just eat up.

The words sank into a deep pit in Adora's stomach flooding it with instant disappointment. A mission. Of course, it was a mission. Why had she ever thought- "... Queen Sparkles needs us to check out some estate her family owns to see if it's fit for the people of Elberon to stay in while the town is rebuilt." Catra was trying to keep the dam that held back the typhoon of her emotions from breaking, though this time with positive ones. It just felt so good to be touched by Adora's loving hands, especially when her destructive thoughts made her feel so unworthy of it. A contented purr wanted to start up as she played with the idea of resting her head against Adora's shoulder. *This is all I want; her to be close to me.*

Adora's brows crinkled in surprise as she thumbed Catra's hands absently. *Family estate?* She wracked her mind trying to recall if Glimmer had ever mentioned other royal properties. Then again, with everything that had happened during the time of their friendship, was it completely unheard of for there to be other residences of the Bright Moon royalty? It's not like they had been

looking for a summer getaway with the Horde attacking left and right. However, it did beg the question of where were these houses when the Rebellion needed a safe haven to hide from the chipped. She made a mental note to check in with the queen later; what other resources was the monarchy hiding?

"So what are we doing, just checking it out and reporting back to Bright Moon?" Adora tried to not sound bitter, though she knew she had failed from it creeping into her voice. It was just that… She was under the impression this would be more than a day's turnaround event. That it would be a vacation from her responsibilities and time to connect with Catra- who really should have given her more detail. Perhaps she was overreacting, but it was just so disappointing.

Without considering any potential ramifications, she dropped Catra's hand. Disappointment was turning into irritation and she needed to move to work out her frustration. She had decided earlier to *stop* working and start being with Catra but all of this was just another endless task. It always came down to what she could do for others, her own wants be damned. *Shouldn't surprise me, but it hurts coming from Catra. She just seems so nonplussed about it.*

"Basically." Catra's voice was sharp as her anxiety flared up. *Why did she drop my hand and leave me? What did *I* do- this was all Sparkles' dumb idea!* Catra unintentionally bared her fangs trying to recover from the sudden spark of hurt that came from losing the blonde's hand in hers.

Adora paused her pacing and surveyed Catra's defensive body language. Her voice came out colder than she was expecting.

"Oh, did I do something to offend *you* ?" Provoking, but the bared fangs were really unnecessary. Catra was the one who led her to believe this wasn't anything work related. A sleep-over was supposed to mean *fun* !

"Not everything is about you, you know," Catra hissed out. Adora was the one that had started this; she broke the moment to go off and pace like a total idiot. Catra really had no idea what set the blonde off, but knew Adora should be apologizing, not antagonizing.

"Need I remind you," Adora began imperiously, rising to her full height and her muscles tensing reflexively. Her muscles seemed to remember of their own accord what happened when she and Catra came to odds. Realizing her intimidating pose, she took another step backwards. *That's not going to help matters.* But still needed to make Catra understand what had pissed her off so badly. "You were the one that invited *me* for this… 'sleep-over'. I don't understand you, Catra. We were having fun back at the castle- at least right before we left, and I just thought with everything at the Heart that…"

"Oh, the Heart, huh?" Catra cut in vehemently, not allowing the other girl to finish whatever stupid thing she was planning to say. Like hell she was going to allow anyone to try and intimidate her. Adora may have backed down from the pose, but Catra definitely saw it and did not like it one bit. And then she starts bringing up the most pivotal and emotional experience of their lives? *No fucking way.* Catra couldn't resist digging her (fortunately this time) metaphorical claws in. "Funny you should mention that... Wait- I think I hear something. Is that Glimmer calling you for another meeting? Or maybe Perfuma or Frosta or whoever the hell needs just a 'teensy bit of help' with something 15 other

people could do!" The dam turned violent as it broke, a cascade of anger rushing out of her as words. "Whatever it is, Adora, you better go running!"

Adora was blindsided. Why in the hell was Catra bringing up her responsibilities when apparently they were just off to care of another one? Like she really needed the reminder that she had once again failed the woman of her dreams. *No, this is a reminder actions have consequences. You were hiding. You did this to yourself. Time to face it.* The small voice that so comforted her in her room earlier was back. It didn't feel good this time, but it was sound advice.

"... I know. I know." Adora gripped her hands to her head, wishing desperately they could rewind. "I was avoiding you these past couple weeks." She kept her voice completely calm, almost detached, as a way to gain control over herself again.

Adora's casual admittance of something that pained Catra so deeply, that struck her to her very core of all her insecurities was the last straw. "Wow, Adora, you really sugar coated that for me. Thanks so much!" At this point, she just needed to escape. She needed a chance to lick her wounds and work through the hurt. Catra stalked away and began to climb the branches of an oak tree. "Do me a favor; stay away for a while. Shouldn't be too hard, you've got tons of practice at it!"

"What! Catra, we're in the middle of the damn woods. Where am I supposed to go?" Adora called out to the branches above her, stamping her foot at the utter *childishness* Catra displayed.

A piece of parchment fluttered down to the base of the tree the feline had retreated to. “Figure it out yourself, Princess. We’re done here.”

This was completely unfair. Adora hadn’t even gotten the chance to fully explain herself before Catra totally flew off the handle! Stomping up to the base of the tree, Adora snatched the paper from the ground. She scanned it, noting Glimmer’s loopy handwriting and crudely drawn maps, complete with a stupid cartoon of Glimmer winking and sticking out her tongue near a circled drawing of a house. She sighed angrily at her best friend’s insanely crude and entirely unhelpful directions. Best she could figure, the estate was about a mile or two away once she left the cover of the Whispering Wood. “Really- a hand drawn map by *Glimmer* ? Couldn’t have at least gone to Bow for a tracker pad, could you!”

Silence was her only response to the jab. Adora huffed as she trudged off in the direction she hoped was correct. At least she got to have the last word. Catra didn’t have a monopoly on childish behavior.

Chapter End Notes

It can't be a Catradora fic without *some* drama, amirite? These girls just love their emotional misunderstandings, don't they?

Not sure when chapter 3 will come to be but I can say bits and pieces have already been mapped out and I will be continuing. I promised y'all smut and I will deliver more than a confused & horny Adora and teasing Catra, I promise. Until then!

Building

Chapter Notes

> I had every intent of posting a monster-sized chapter that wrapped everything up neater, but honestly folks, these girls have FEELINGS and one chapter to sort them out just wasn't going to cut it. The good news is, real world pending, I might be able to get chapter 4 out sometime mid-week instead of the weekend. Fingers crossed!
>
> Thank you so everyone who has read, left kudos, or a comment. I appreciate the support and hope you continue to enjoy. As always, will happily accept any feedback!

Before long, Adora left the cover of the trees. She glanced back as she crossed out of the thicket, idly wondering if she should go back for Catra. *No, she said to leave so I'll give her what she wants.* She really still had no idea what happened back there- but did know the cat had some apologizing to do. Afterall, Adora *had* been trying to explain before she was so rudely cut off.

Consulting her poor excuse for a map once again, Adora put thoughts of Catra from her mind and focused on coming up with a plan. She wasn't given a ton of direction for this project, but she would make the most with the information she had. She knew she would need to survey the perimeter of the building, check the surrounding lands and fields, find the closest fresh water source... and that was even before stepping foot into the building proper. Once inside she would take stock of the supplies currently on hand, assess the number of rooms that could be repurposed into sleeping areas for multiple families, see if there was a place that could be made into a medical facility, and maybe even find a place for some form of entertainment. Who knew what sort of tomfoolery people without distraction may find themselves in otherwise.

She continued to walk as she strategized, occasionally glancing at the map for the vague landmarks referenced on the piece of paper. Why they hadn't just teleported here, Adora would never know. Though she heavily suspected Catra's aversion to that particular mode of transportation had something to do with it. *Yeah and if she had just sucked it up and dealt with it, maybe she'd be here right now…* She gave a slight huff of exasperation as she pushed the thought from her mind. Catra wasn't here and Adora was just going to continue on with this stupid expedition. Because that's what she did.

Finally, after several more miles of walking, Adora crested a small hill and looked down into the neighboring valley. There was absolutely no question in her mind that she had found the house.

It was smaller than she expected, though certainly no quaint country cabin. The manor sat on it's own grassy knoll, with walls that in better times must have gleamed like polished alabaster. The walls formed what Adora would so accurately describe as a "house-shaped" building save towards the southwestern part of the house where it curved into a more round shape. She liked the round part; it was more interesting than a plain rectangle.

It appeared to be two storeys tall with large windows polkadotting the outside frequently. She could only begin to guess how many rooms it had, hoping each window was not indicative of a room. *Rooms can have multiple windows, dummy.* She could almost hear Catra snark the words and she smiled in spite of herself. Refocusing on the task at hand, Adora noticed a medium sized, hexagonal out-building of some kind. It was a good distance away from the main house and Adora had no guesses of what the purpose behind it would be.

She knew that being a part time royal residence the manor would certainly contain ample room and adequate facilities, but she had no idea the last time this house had seen any residents. That would be a large determining factor for how long this would take. Given its size and the slight sag to the roof marking its length of abandonment, Adora regretted getting bent out of shape with Catra over what would definitely not be a one day event.

Before long, she found herself along the cobbled driveway, surprised at the front entrance. An overhang with bumpy columns covered a very modest front door and a large pair of antlers were hung on the crest of the overhang. As she approached, she ran a hand along one of the columns, its medium gray color working and also yet not working against the dingy white walls behind it. It dawned on her that they were almost like tree trunks; it was a strange aesthetic. Adora passively wondered which of Glimmer's ancestors was the hunter who had taken down whatever beast had those antlers.

Regarding the front door, Adora immediately considered how she was going to get inside. It was probably locked, right? The idea of turning into She-Ra and just… removing the door came to her quickly. Her eyes were already beginning to glow when she realized breaking off the front door might not be the best plan, given she couldn't be certain she would be able to fix it later. Expecting the action to be a fruitless endeavor, much like most of the afternoon had already been, she tried the handle. The door slid open easily.

"Oh. Well, at least I didn't do any permanent damage…" Adora called out ruefully to the empty house. Or at least she presumed

empty; from afar she hadn't seen any signs of life- no lights, movement, or smoke coming from the several chimneys. But the door had been unlocked so...

Still ready to slip into She-Ra at any moment should the need arise, Adora stepped inside proper. She glanced around her, taking in the foyer area. She was uninterested in the decor of the house, blazingly focused on doing her job and doing it right. Her cold survey picked up on an end table near the door she was still standing by and the piece of paper folded into a neat tent atop it. The paper had another winking emoji of Glimmer on it, complete with tongue sticking out and peace sign thrown up.

Adora snatched it up, trying to not be annoyed at the cartoon.

Hello My Favorite Utterly Useless Lesbians,

Adora paused her reading a moment to roll her eyes at her best friend's favorite term of endearment for Catra and herself. *Probably not too far off the mark either…* Her shoulders relaxed a little at the friendly ease soaked into the letter.

I hope you both enjoyed your journey to Barkhold Manor. No one has visited here in ages; in fact, I only found out about it myself a few days ago. Bow found this list of royal properties and assets in some book in the library- would have been nice to know about this stuff earlier, huh? My dad was pretty sure he and my mom spent some time here when they were young… But he seemed really, y'know, unwilling to talk about it much. I'm not sure I blame him.

*Anyway, really hoping Adora didn't bust out She-Ra to break down the door or break a window to get in here. I'm trusting Catra had the sense to at least *try* the door before any She-Ra shenanigans could take place- I came here earlier today to make sure the door would be unlocked for you. (If stupidity did indeed happen, I expect whatever was broken to be fixed before your return and a full apology, preferably in written and verbal form.)*

Despite popping in for a mo', I'm definitely leaving the recon up to you two. No idea what you'll find here; be safe! Oh, in case the pantry's empty, I also took the liberty of bringing you two dinner as well. I really am a peach, aren't I?

Have a wonderful time… exploring. ;-)

{Signed} Her Royal Majesty Glimmer of Bright Moon

Biggest Peach & Total Sweetheart in the Land

Adora smiled at her friend's note, happy to have the mystery of the unlocked door solved. The obnoxious sign off could have been left out though. *Leave it to Glimmer to ham up a mission.*

She was also very glad to have not gone through with her original plan involving She-Ra, especially at her friend's call-out. Everyone knew Adora was a "break first, ask questions later" kind of gal and at least this time she had tempered her impulses. The basket of small foodstuffs near the note caused her heart to ache, knowing it was meant for her and Catra both. She couldn't bring herself to eat without the other woman, so instead she set about taking in her new surroundings. As an afterthought, she brought the basket with. She was unwilling to not show gratitude towards the kind gesture from her best friend by leaving it at the front door.

The foyer branched off in three directions: stairs right in front of her leading to the second floor, on her right seemed to be a large sitting room, and to the left a dining room. She chose to go left first, figuring that way would also lead to the kitchens and pantry. Taking stock of the non-perishables seemed like a good first priority. *Shelter, check. Food supply, next on the list. Water source necessary as well.* Her solder mind immediately kicked in; the basic tenets of survival.

Her hunch was correct and a large open kitchen area was located through a swinging door in the back of the dining room, with the pantry attached. She noted a well attachment built into the wall with a generous sink beneath in the eastern part of the room. Trying the handle, she was pleased to see a merry stream of water escape that didn't smell musty or fetid. *Likely fed by a natural spring from the mountains* . Setting the basket on the counter near the sink, she drank from a cupped hand. It was cool and crisp; invigorating her instantly.

After the refreshment, Adora made her way into the pantry. Boxes and boxes sat on long shelves through the room. Cataloguing the contents would alone take a week! Sighing at the tedium before her, she hoisted a box of odds and ends and brought it to the dining room, silently debating the best way to begin this task. She would need paper and pen of course, then an area for sustenance to keep, a pile for her (*maybe Catra too…)* to consume in the time spent at the house, and a disposal heap. Once sorted into those basic areas, she could further narrow down and have a concise list of everything on hand to present to the queen. It was as good a plan as any. She was pretty sure she saw a writing desk in the sitting room; it was bound to have the paper and writing utensils she needed there.

Before long, she was immersed in her task and surrounded by clutter. Adora allowed her mind to sink in fully to the monotony of her labors: unpack a box, sort, grab another. Repeat ad nauseum.

Her stomach was clenching with hunger but she did not give in. Nothing would break her concentration on her task, but mostly she couldn't bear the thought of eating without Catra. *It wasn't supposed to be like this...* She rested her head against the table in the one clear spot she could find. Her heart hurt; it felt as though tears should come, but they did not. It was just so quiet and empty around her. And she didn't really want to be angry any more.

Not for the first time since perching herself in the tree, Catra wished she had Melog with her. At least then she'd have some degree of comfort, both physically and emotionally. Not to mention a faster ride back to the castle and away from this damn branch. But alas, the space cat did not accompany them per Catra's request. She was so certain that things were just going to go *well* for once that it made sense for them to stay behind. Catra scoffed at her own optimism.

She hated this tree. She hated the circumstances that caused her to retreat into said tree. She had been doing so well at controlling herself better and then in one stupid conversation she had ruined all her progress. She had lashed out at Adora, not even allowing the other woman a chance to explain herself. She had been reactive; volatile as before. Unwelcome tears began to prick at her eyes. Adora wouldn't forgive her…

Though they'd only been practicing together for a couple weeks, Catra was surprised to hear Perfuma's airy voice chide her in her mind. The hours spent together must have resonated deeper with Catra than she'd originally thought. *Catra… You're catastrophizing. You do not know how Adora will react until you speak with her. Only she can tell you.*

Well, it was a catastrophe. Everything was ruined, all because she couldn't keep her damn mouth shut. Couldn't keep her blistering temper under control. This was her punishment and what she deserved in life. *Life is not a series of punishments or rewards, Catra. You are not your current emotional state; it is an ebb and flow that can and will change many times in a single day. Acknowledge it, then move past it. The only person that can stop you is you.*

She was either going crazy, considering she having an internal conversation with someone she'd spent only a few afternoons with and was *miles away from her currently* , or the small part of Catra that wanted to succeed was just taking on a comforting (if not a bit insufferable) persona. And apparently had latched on to every damn word the willowy blonde had ever said to her.

She wasn't sure which option brought her more relief; it might be nice to be a bit crazy. The inner voice huffed at her, scolding her for using language like 'crazy' when it perpetuated mental health stigma. Regardless of the source, the thought that something out there, maybe even some part of her, had her own best interests at heart even as she fought for control in the face of her worst insecurities helped immensely.

She drew in a deep breath and tried to let the tension release from her shoulders. She narrowed her focus to the sound of her own beating heart. The pulse, though still elevated, was a firm reminder that so long as it kept beating, she still could make her own choices. She had agency in life; she was not a helpless bystander being dragged around by the whims of fate. Every choice she made- good or ill, was hers and hers alone. So often she had been made to feel powerless, inconsequential and ineffectual. Her youth had been spent striking out against those that sought to hold her down. She had risen to the top anyway, at first finding it barren and empty, until she started to accept what she *truly* wanted in life (friends, companionship, Adora) and saw the possibility that stretched before her.

Like with the switch and the portal, Catra realized she had a life-changing decision to make. She could run from Adora and what she wanted or she could get her ass out of this tree and face it. Own up to her mistakes and apologize for them, to take the time to explain what her head space had been, and allow Adora the chance to explain her own side. She couldn't force the blonde to do so, but she could provide the safe space to allow it to happen. *That isn't going to happen with me sitting in a tree, sulking.* Catra was moving in the direction of the house before she had even finished the thought.

Catra raced along the path towards the house on all fours, letting the still lingering scent of Adora's presence be her guide. Before long, she found herself at the top of the hill overlooking the estate and paused to catch her breath, not wanting to enter the house completely winded. *A mad dash like that would probably cause her to She-Ra out or something.*

Instead she walked calmly up the drive, thoughts unclouded. Her revelations of her own agency fortified her resolve; she was back to feeling in control and most of all, relaxed. Like she was coming into her own personal abode, doing an act done a thousand times before, Catra entered the new house. She made no attempt to mask her presence, only hoped that Adora was nearby enough to hear it. She wasn't hiding any more.

Clumsy footsteps clamored in from the entryway on Catra's left. "Oh, so you found it!" Adora leaned against the wall, sagging in relief. She saw the blonde close her eyes for a moment and breathe deeply. Catra melted, no doubt in her mind that this was a positive life decision.

"I-I thought you wanted to be alone..." Adora winced and bit her lip, hoping she did not sound accusatory. She was so relieved to see Catra but also cautious, knowing how angry the two had been when they parted in the woods. She meant it in a way as to allow Catra to draw boundaries; maybe she wasn't ready to talk yet but just didn't want to be out in the woods after dark. Which would be falling in earnest at any time now.

"Well if you recall , " Catra said, allowing her voice to be as gentle as possible and taking a few steps towards Adora's slouched position against the wall. She still left plenty of breathing room for them both. "I said to leave me alone for a while. It's been a while."

"Yeah, I guess it has. I'm so glad you're here, Catra." Adora gave a honey-eyed smile and gestured to the room behind her. "You wanna come sit down? You must be tired."

“From sitting in a tree all afternoon? Yeah. I’m beat.” She fastened a small smile on her lips, a joking peace offering she hoped Adora would take. She appreciated that Adora had put her comfort at the forefront, even after their spat earlier. *So Adora...*

Catra crossed into the next room and was shocked at the clutter that enveloped the entire room. She set herself into the closest chair at the table, trying to not disturb the organized chaos around her. “What are you even doing?”

Adora could feel her defenses raise at the question, much to her chagrin. *Now don’t go getting all prickly again; any person would ask that upon seeing this jumble.* “Cataloguing. It’s the *mission* , isn’t it- surveying and taking stock of what’s at the house? I thought… Glimmer would want to know exactly what was in here.” She exhaled slowly at the end, hopeful that no bitterness had leaked through her words.

Catra’s ears flicked at the extra emphasis Adora had put on the word ‘mission’. She could feel the poison in the word. “... Is that what’s got you all bent out of shape? A mission?” Catra turned around to peer curiously at Adora, who huffed in response and didn’t meet Catra’s eye. The blonde looked ready to bolt out of the room any minute. “Uh-uh, you come here, Adora. We’re doing this now.” Catra wondered where the line between aggressive and assertive was.

Adora hesitated, weighing her options. She really didn’t want to be mad any longer and didn’t want to do anything to make Catra disappear again. The feline seemed at ease; who knows what had

happened with her out in the woods. But Adora was uncertain. Her head hurt from indexing supplies and from her stubborn fasting. She held fast against the wall. "Doing what now?"

"We're going to talk. Something happened in the woods, something I think we both would feel better about if we had a chance to discuss it. I know I would." Catra was purposefully keeping her body language open, trying to convey to Adora this was a hostile-free zone. "Are you in a head space where you can do that with me?" She tried to mimic the way Perfuma had always opened their sessions; an emotional temperature check before any work was done.

Adora uncrossed her arms and rubbed at her forehead. They did need to talk, but to be honest, she didn't think she had the physical or mental fortitude for it currently. Maybe some food would help. "Do you mind if we eat first? I… haven't all day and I don't think you have either. I just think it'll go better if I'm not fighting hunger pangs and dizziness."

Catra nodded in agreement. She didn't need as many regular meals as Adora did, but something in her stomach would probably make this go better. And Adora was still so on edge about whatever was bothering her. *Give her whatever she needs; she'd do the same for you. Always has.* "I think that's a great idea. I guess I don't have to ask if there's any food in the house." She gestured around to the piles that surrounded the pair. "But what can we make that's quick and easy? I don't think either of us feels like cooking."

"Well, actually, Glimmer packed us dinner. She came and unlocked the house for us sometime earlier today and left it for us to find."

Adora scanned her eyes around the room, trying to remember where she had placed the gift before recalling the sink. "I'll be right back."

As Adora left the room, Catra stood from her chair and tried to find an empty patch on the table where the two could enjoy their meal in peace. Adora had thoroughly managed to clutter every surface in the room. *I know Adora's a force of nature all her own, but was I really in the tree for that long?*

Adora was back in the dining room as quickly as she could after fetching the basket. She was half-afraid Catra would be gone by the time she got back and she was also *really* hungry. Upon entering, Adora looked around at the mess that Catra was surveying and grimaced. "Err… Might not be a ton of space left in here. But I haven't really been in the next room over yet. It's some kind of sitting area. Maybe we could eat there?"

Catra nodded and gave Adora a warm little smile. "Yeah, let's go. I hope Sparkles packed us something tasty. It's been a hell of a day."

"You can say that again…" Adora sighed and headed to the other room, fingers lightly grazing Catra's side as she passed. Catra glowed at the touch.

Catra settled into a plush armchair, while Adora sat on the couch across from it, admittedly a little stiff in her posture. They ate in mostly companionable silence, though a layer of tension hovered over the atmosphere like fog. The basket's contents were simple,

but comforting: salted fish much to Catra's delight, crisp crackers to be spread with a soft shelf-stable cheese, various nuts, and even some candied fruit as a dessert. A bottle of plum wine with two glasses was wordlessly ignored by both women. They needed all their faculties in place tonight. Plus Adora was certain the smallest sip of alcohol would have her passed out on the floor in exhaustion.

"How you feelin' over there?" Catra eyed the blonde, who had seemed to relax a bit more with a full belly. "You sure you're up for this tonight? We could call it for the day and catch some sleep instead."

It was so tempting. She felt better after eating but Adora knew she wouldn't be able to sleep with the way things were currently. Adora shook her head. "No, let's do this tonight. You're definitely right that we need to talk."

"Works for me. I can go first." Catra mentally shook herself in preparation to excavate all her feelings from today- from the past couple weeks. *This is it. I am in control of my own actions. I am enough.*

Catra's mental pep talk was interrupted. "Actually, can I go first? I'm really tired and think if I don't just get it all out in the open, I might not be able to later." Her head was hung low. She felt selfish for asking to spill her guts first, as if either one of them thought that was a grand prize to be won.

"Of course, 'Dor. Whenever you're ready; I'm listening." Catra popped a piece of candied fruit into her mouth. She wasn't normally one for sweets, but couldn't deny they were a comfort from time to time. She didn't mind Adora talking first, in fact, a large part of her was very proud of the vulnerability the normally taciturn blonde was displaying. *She's really not much better than me at Talk…* Her own feelings had just been hanging over her head all day and she was so ready to be free of the weight. But- Adora's needs could be put first.

Adora sat on the couch in the parlor, leg beginning to bounce in anxiety as she tried to make the words flow through her mind in a cohesive way. *Where do you even begin with something like this? Our fight? Me realizing a deep seated fear that caused me to ignore you for weeks on end?* When she realized they were truly one in the same, she threw her head against the back of the couch with a defeated groan. "I don't even know where to begin."

"Well, if you thought it might help, I do have a question. Just to sort of get things started." In truth, Catra had a plethora of questions. A mountain of them. But something stuck in her mind that she figured was as good a start as any. Adora just nodded in consent as her leg continued to bounce. "I swear to you, I am not trying to start anything with this but… Can you help me understand how it is that Adora- the woman who can't relax to save her life, got upset at having work to do? That even the word mission kinda… sent her over the edge?" It perhaps wasn't the most eloquent of phrasings, but Catra was truly perplexed. Adora loved having work to do; it was a defining characteristic of hers.

Adora's bouncing leg grew more agitated. She grit her teeth and tried to get her vocal cords to obey the command to speak her brain was giving them. She was certain if she could just start

talking the words would flow like a raging river. But starting was so difficult.

Catra saw the increased distress Adora was in and it panicked her. What could possibly be so difficult that it would elicit this kind of response? She had to fight to not let her own fears and anxieties enter the fray. Both to help her own mounting fears and hopefully be able to comfort Adora through hers, Catra asked in an even voice if she could come sit by her. Adora looked stricken for a moment, then nodded vigorously. Catra barely took a second to cross over to her. "What is going on, Adora?" She noticed tears building at the blonde's eyes and gently laid a hand across the other woman's arm.

"... It's not the mission…" Her gentle touch eased the pressure inside of Adora enough she was able to barely breathe out the words, so quietly that only Catra's sensitive ears would be able to detect them.

"What is it then?" Her thumb rubbed small circles across Adora's arm. She couldn't keep her own uncertainty at bay any longer and had to take the plunge. "... Is it me?" Two toned eyes flicked away, then shuttered with pain.

Adora turned quickly to Catra, gasping. Her voice came out ten times as strong as before. "No. No, not you. Never you." She gently grasped Catra's face and turned it towards her own so they could lock eyes. Just as she suspected, the words came spilling out of her. "To be honest, Catra, I didn't even know there would *be* a mission, when you invited me. I… thought it was just for fun. So when I found out that once again, someone else needed me to do something for *them* … it just. Hurt."

Catra stared back at Adora, trying to make sense of the information that had been presented. She felt Adora's hand begin to pull away from her cheek and her own hand shot up to keep it there. "Don't. Please."

The pair sat together on the couch, just looking at one another and processing. But Adora did not move her hand from its caress of Catra's cheek. Finally after a beat to calm herself, Catra spoke again. "It was a cover. Glimmer's plan, actually, though I can't really blame her. She was trying to help and came up with the idea of sending you and I away to scout this place. Having a mission to do, it was… the only way I thought you'd choose me." She had to close her eyes to admit this last part.

Tears fell from Adora's eyes as she saw the naked hurt on Catra's face. "I know I screwed up. I screwed up bad- and for *weeks* . That's also what made this whole thing even more messed up. When I was packing, I really realized what I had been doing these past couple weeks. How much I had been hurting you..."

Teary but firm blue eyes met once again opened golden and azure ones. "I decided right then I wouldn't let such… *petty bullshit* ," Catra lips twinged up in slight amusement at her unexpected profanity. "Get in the way of spending time with the woman I love."

"Love, huh?" Catra's body released all the tension it had been holding and holding for weeks.

"...You really love me?"

“With all my heart. Now I just need to start showing it- every damn day; with my words, with my body!” Adora gasped a little at her verbal faux pas. “I meant with my actions. N-not my body...”

“Your body, hmm? And how would you show me you love me… with your body?” There was no way she was going to let Adora’s little slip-up go by unchecked. They’d done enough emotional upchucking for the moment. She flashed the flustered woman a devious smile, feeling a little heat begin to flame at her core. This kind of talk she could do all night.

“Oh! Um, I, what I meant was…” Adora was redder than she ever had been in her life. *Guess it’s time for Act II of the ‘Adora is a Mess’ show.* She dropped her hand from Catra’s face to cover her own in embarrassment.

“Wait! Don’t move your hand. Please… don’t leave me.” The heat was snuffed out instantly, replaced with panic. *Guess it’s my turn to spill now.* “That’s what got me so worked up in the woods. I was… having some really bad, destructive thoughts and when you pulled away your hand so suddenly… I just sort of spiraled?” Ugh.She hated ending a statement as a question.

In a flash, Adora’s arm was around Catra’s shoulder, their hands laced together. Adora would do anything to never hear the panic in Catra’s voice again. She inhaled deeply and asked in a low, concerned voice. “Destructive thoughts? Like what?”

"I got caught up in remembering the war, the battles, the pain. And before that, I swear I heard Weaver in my head…" Shame radiated off Catra and she buried her head against Adora's shoulder, wanting to hide completely. *To still be tortured by a dead woman is so pathetic.* "It's dumb, I know."

"No. Your feelings aren't dumb. What we've been through... what *you've* been through. It's painful… and Shadow Weaver was so toxic." Thick muscled arms embraced her, bringing her into a tighter hold. Catra settled her head against Adora's shoulder, enraptured at the closeness between them they hadn't experienced since the Heart. Adora felt more empowered in this moment of protecting and being present with Catra than any feat she ever managed as She-Ra. "I'm here. No matter what this trip was supposed to be- vacation, mission, it doesn't matter. I'm here for you, Catra. Only you."

This is what Catra had been craving. *To be hers and hers alone.* She just hummed and pressed her head into the spot below Adora's throat a little deeper in response.

The pair held their pose for several blessed minutes, seeking comfort in one another. Adora spoke softly, starting to run her fingers through Catra's hair. "Can I ask you something? Well, something else…" A small dopey grin tipped at Adora's lips at her own joke.

She could feel a nod from the small frame in her arms, certain there was an accompanying eye roll. "If you missed me so much, why didn't you try to come find me?"

Of course she would ask something like that. Catra breathed deep, trying to not let her annoyance get the best of her and destroy this up-until then perfect moment. Her head lifted up to regard the taller girl and review her reaction. "A lot of reasons. One: I know you're busy, you're important, and you're necessary to other people. I'm *trying* to share you even when I so desperately don't want to." Catra's hands slid to Adora's waist and squeezed gently as she said this, mostly to comfort herself with Adora's presence. "I want to be a better person, Adora. Not quite so… me."

Catra paused a moment as she said that, ears lowering. She composed herself and quietly finished. "And two: I wanted you to come find me and to put me first. It can get so tiring always chasing after you…"

Adora considered, a bit perplexed. "I think I've chased after you plenty. All around Etheria, through the Waste, I even missed most of Princess Prom chasing you..."

Catra punched Adora in the shoulder, unsure of how lightly she did so. *Not the time, jackass.* "Would you please take this seriously and maybe put your damn pride aside for a minute? I'm being open with you and you're treating it like some sort of joke."

"You're right. I'm sorry, Catra. You and your feelings don't deserve that treatment. Joking has just always been our go-to, y'know?" She rubbed her shoulder absently, the force the other woman had used a clear indication of her seriousness.

"Yeah. But our go-to also caused three years of fighting, bloodshed, and even the whole fucking world almost being destroyed. I'm sick of our go-to; it doesn't work. So let's try this thing called *adulthood* and maybe keep the jokes down to like… 40% of the time and spend the other 60% actually communicating. If we could both be open with each other, maybe I wouldn't have spent hours in a tree getting splinters in my ass."

Adora reflected on Catra's words carefully, recognizing the truth behind them. A cavalier attitude had been the start of so much going wrong between them, which had had a ripple effect to the rest of the world. Catra's transformation over such a brief period of time astounded her. She was so humbled and fiercely proud to be in love with this woman. Catra was strong, collected, and absolutely driven to make herself the best possible version of herself she could be. Adora was overwhelmed with the certainty that with Catra at her side, nothing was insurmountable. It was enough to make her face her great fear.

Adora paused herself for a second, gathering up her courage. "Yes, it's such a nice ass we wouldn't want that, would we?" She made to peek around at the other girl's backside then quickly turned around an exaggerated movement. "Oops. No jokes, sorry." She swallowed thickly, amazed she had managed to get the words out so smoothly. Not even a crack in her voice, though her heart was starting to hammer.

Catra sucked in a breath, blown away. Not where she expected that tirade to go, but *definitely* not a place she didn't like. Adora had never once been that forward with her. Adora was kind and respectful… and sometimes infuriatingly chaste. This was a new development Catra really wanted to explore further. She slotted her hands to rest back on Adora's hips. "... I'll give you a pass this

time, Princess. *If* you say more nice things about my ass…" Her fingers pressed a little deeper into Adora's hips.

Adora was a mess of contradictions. On one hand, she wanted to flee from Catra's touch and get far, far away from this conversation. On the other… She can't ignore the *hunger* that comes from Catra's touch or the look of want in the other woman's eyes. It was absolutely intoxicating to behold. Before she could collect herself to find a graceful way to start this conversation, she heard something that sounded much like her own voice say, "I'm afraid of sex."

Rising

Chapter Notes

> Actually managed to get chapter 4 in mid-week! An accomplishment. This has probably been the most fun I've had writing a chapter thus far.
>
> Thank you everyone for your continued support; give me a shout if you have any feedback! Enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The house became too quiet for Adora again. She scarcely breathed, wondering who took control of her and forced her to say THAT so plainly, at this exact moment.

Catra felt nothing but confusion; the air rushed past her ears as she sought to process this sharp turn without signaling. *One wouldn't think the mention of sex would be a complete mood breaker, but here we are. Just another level to this weird-ass day.* She bit down on her tongue, hard, before speaking. "You wanna run that by me again? I got lost somewhere around 'Catra, your ass is amazing' and… whatever this is." Hollowly she wondered if maybe joking was all they had.

"L-look, I'm going to pull away but I swear it's not you! I just need to… move for a minute." Adora gently removed herself from Catra's hold and began to pace the length of the sitting room, reminiscent of how she did in the woods. Adora was convinced enough movement would allow her to pull her thoughts together, though she wasn't confident enough to think the situation would be fully salvageable.

Catra watched Adora march nervously while trying to understand what was happening herself. She sat rather patiently in her opinion, eyes merely tracking the blonde as she moved back and forth, back and forth. Catra eventually had to shut her eyes. She focused on trying to regain the calm resolve and determination she felt in the woods on her branch. Except how could she possibly concentrate when Adora was still stuck in a loop: back and forth, back and forth. Maybe if she changed directions *once* or threw up a hand on occasion, Catra wouldn't have felt so utterly disturbed. "Adora, if you don't say *something* I am going to lose it!"

"Okay! … Okay, at the same time I realized I needed to give my all to you, I also realized I'm scared of my feelings for you? My physical ones!" She rushed to finish, hoping no lasting damage would be done. The last thing the pair needed was another misunderstanding from their words; this was going to be challenging enough.

Catra merely flicked an ear and gestured with a wordlessly that Adora needed to continue to explain. Now. "I started to think about how, how much I had to *hide* what I wanted… what I wanted from you, to do with you… in the Horde. Because everyone was watching all the time…" Adora halted mid-step and finally stood still, obviously lost in her memories of the Fright Zone.

Catra nodded sympathetically, drawing a hand over her face in weariness. *It always comes back to that fucking place, doesn't it?* She could clearly remember her own games of hiding her attraction to Adora. Though it appeared that the two had responded in very different ways. Catra had put her natural penchant for agility and sneaking to the test each time it became

too much to just ignore, and sought out the darkest crevices of the Fright Zone to be alone in. Just her, her fingers, and thoughts of a certain blonde with the tightest body.

Not exclusively but often enough, she ended up in the damn vents that Entrapta used as her own personal highway system during her time in the Zone. That was the reason it creeped Catra out so badly when the eccentric fool couldn't be bothered to use the hallways like everyone else. The vents were *her* private area. She never thought anyone would have half the dexterity needed to get up there until Entrapta waltzed in on her stupid, weird hair-hands. Catra made herself sick with anxiety that the basket case would just *know* after being up there long enough and then say something really strange and embarrassing at breakfast or something. She couldn't put it past 'Trapta; that girl could be weirdly perceptive about shit.

Catra couldn't help but to smirk and inwardly cackle at some memories too. She should probably feel more embarrassed about the rumors of some parts of the base being haunted, as her dumber squadmates mentioned hearing moaning above them at night. *Serves them right for sticking around to listen.*

Catra brought herself back from Smutty Memory Lane to refocus on Adora who had also rejoined the present. "... And the lengths I used to go to push down those thoughts and urges, even when it hurt. Because with someone *always* watching, I didn't want to risk losing what we were able to have. The play fighting, the escapes to the rooftop. I didn't want to lose that! So, I threw myself into my training because I thought that if I were the best, always on my game, they'd leave us alone. It was also the only way I knew how to distract myself from… wanting you." Adora nervously watched for Catra's reaction. The feline was neutral, which wasn't

a comfort to Adora but not a deterrent either, though she did notice Catra's eyebrow flick up slightly when she admitted to wanting the other girl.

"I suppose that makes sense. Not like we were really allowed to have much to begin with…" Catra grumbled, for a half-second wondering where the nearest tree branch to camp out in again was. She had prepared herself for emotional meltdowns and sappy moments. Not exactly… *this* .

Despite her outward demeanor, she wasn't *angry* ; she was just surprised. Her sex drive had just always been a part of her life. It wasn't something she questioned, or like, wallowed about. It just was; an annoying itch that couldn't be fully scratched. She was aware it bled out into other parts of her life (as in like every time she saw Adora during the war when she became a flirting mess of hormones and want) but like… So?

Acting mighty confident, aren't we? Think a little harder. Not even sure which inner demon was speaking to her *this* time, Catra's flippancy dropped. She knew exactly what was being implied. Sure, she had her private corners to take care of matters at hand but those corners were also where she would go as an awkward teenager to cry in shame at not understanding what the hell these feelings were or why her best friend was involved so intimately. It's not like the Horde had comprehensive Sex Ed.

Or once she had listened in on enough senior cadet gossip to figure things out a bit more and get better control of herself, those areas became where she could lash out privately about how she would never get to explore the more tender feelings that were also so wrapped up in the sexual ones she had for Adora. Softness

and love weren't allowed in the Horde. She scratched up some corners of that miserable base so hard her claws would break and bleed.

And once Adora was truly gone, it was the only place she could go to weep at the ghost of the girl that still plagued her as she was consumed by her feelings of lust, love, and loss.

Catra came to the conclusion that sex might just be sex sometimes... But it also could come with a whole hell of a lot of emotional baggage tied to it. *Plus it's not like you've ever done it with another person, you moron.*

She rubbed her eyes at the emotional toll this mind fuck of a day was having on her and rose slowly from where she'd been planted on the couch. Soon she stood facing Adora, a respectable distance away, with her arms crossed over her chest protectively. She stared Adora down, who looked like she was pleading with the ground beneath her to swallow her whole right then and there. *You're not getting out of this that easily, princess.*

Catra inhaled a deep breath, willing herself to calm. "Well, dummy, I'm scared too."

"You are?" Adora sank in disbelief to sit on the coffee table that was beside her.

"... Yeah. 'Course I am. You think I did it every day in the Fright Zone or something?" She arched an eyebrow as she continued. "Though, Lonnie probably would have been down, at first. Goodness knows Scorpia would have burst at the opportunity to try…" Catra muttered, glad for her darker complexion that hid the blush of embarrassment as she tried to not envision either person in that kind of way. She certainly didn't need the image of Scorpia *bursting* any time soon.

Adora looked utterly crushed at her words. *Of course Catra would have *offers*!* How could she not? Everything about her just screamed sex appeal- the clothes, the attitude, the body. Adora buried her face in her hands, trying not to cry.

"Hey, hey there… Sorry, I didn't mean anything by that." Catra found herself kneeling in front of the blonde, gently removing her hands that were hiding her beautiful face. "I promise you, there was no one else that even remotely crossed my mind in that way. It's always been you, princess… Well, and my own hands, of course." She gave Adora a rakish grin at her admission.

A surprised *mmrph!* escaped Adora's lips. *Always me? Me?* Then. "Wait, what did you just say? Your own h-hands?" Adora was truly amazed her brain hadn't imploded with this new tidbit of information nor did she feel the black tendrils of unadulterated fear grip at her chest. The small voice perked up, *You're safe with her.*

"Yeah? What, you never got the itch?" Catra held her breath at her answer. *Whatever it is, it's going to hurt so good.*

"Uhhh… I mean, no not really." Adora's eyes flicked away guiltily. But she was safe right now. "...Actually y-yes… one night after Glimmer got back and was healed after Weaver held her hostage all that time, me, her and Bow started talking about how amazing Princess Prom was, up until all the kidnapping and bombs. And then later when I was all alone, that sort of got me remembering a few things…" She trailed off, amazed she'd revealed this much. "I kinda tried but got so upset over the whole thing that I ended up going to the gym in the castle. I think I did more squats and pull ups that night than I ever had before in my life- all as Adora too, not She-Ra! But as like, punishment." She giggled at the memory.

As intrigued at first as Catra was by these *things* Adora mentioned, she was also disturbed (and amazingly not at the memories of kidnapping and bombs, that guilt could be unpacked later). "Sex isn't a punishable offense, Adora." Her tone was dead serious and completely no nonsense. It stopped Adora's chuckle immediately.

"Yeah. Well. It would have been. I can't even imagine what they would have done to us in the Fright Zone... t-to you…" She trailed off, feeling entirely chastised by the conversation. It was never a pleasant feeling to be scolded.

"Hey… Hey, we're not there anymore, okay? That place doesn't even exist any more." Still kneeling in front of the blonde, she once again laced their hands together. Adora tried to look away but Catra wouldn't let her get far. She gazed deep into those steely blue eyes, trying her best to convey nothing but security and warmth. "Look. There's a lot about it that I don't know, just bits and pieces I've picked up along the way. But I *do* know it's not a bad thing. It's just… part of life, a really damn good one if

the stories are even half-true. And even better if it's with someone you sorta… like." She smiled softly at her own words, thinking of the number of times she asserted that she did not like the blonde. Nope. Not at all, not a bit. *You were just madly in love with her…*

The call back did not escape Adora, who smiled wanly in response. "So I hear." Her voice betrayed her still lingering doubt.

"Adora, I promise you, we don't have to do * *anything** you're not ready for. Anything either one of us isn't ready for. And we'll figure it out together, okay?" Catra chuckled, running her thumb along the top of Adora's hand in what she hoped was a soothing manner. "I think even for a couple of 'Useless Lesbians' to quote our fair queen, it's mostly like… instinct."

Adora could feel her blush spread wide across her cheeks, down her neck and collarbone. Nothing would ever be able to convince Adora that she had any "instinct" anywhere. "But. It's hard to start believing that we're truly safe enough to try and follow that… *instinct* ..." It was easier to stay focused on the comfort and security aspect than admit her deficiency to Catra. And it wasn't lying per se; it still really felt like something that either one of them would be disciplined for even considering such things.

"Adora." Catra grasped her hands tighter. "I promise you: you're safe with me. I followed you to the end of the world, babe, and brought you out alive. I am never gonna let *anything* bad happen to you."

"... Babe?" Adora giggled, heavy with nerves. She dropped Catra's hand in surprise. "Me? What, no. I'm no *babe* . I'm…" She trailed off as Catra stood, gently pulling Adora's hands up so they were both standing. Catra made sure to keep her body a respectable distance from Adora, not wanting to completely freak her out. But also, she made sure she was close enough to really *feel* this moment.

She then leaned up next to Adora's ear, tucking a stray lock of hair that had fallen loose from her ponytail some time ago behind it. Adora shivered at the contact and waited with bated breath at whatever the woman's next move would be. When Adora could take it no longer, Catra finally whispered delicately, directly into her ear, so close Catra's mouth was nearly caressing her skin. "You are an absolute fox, *babe* ."

Catra had to resist every urge to cap her statement off with a quick nip of Adora's ear. *God, even her earlobe turns me on.*

Adora was on fire right now, in ways she hadn't been in a long, long time and ways she'd never experienced before. She felt like her brain was short circuiting, stuck somewhere between *oh, god give me more* and *please make it stop* . But mostly she felt… excited. Exhilarated even. It was like turning into She-Ra without the growth spurt. Her heart was clamoring loudly in her chest; goose flesh covered her from head to toe. It was all too much.

"How you feeling, Adora?" Catra soothed, her fingers lightly stroking down her cheek.

"Y-you called me babe…" It was the first words she could articulate with any amount of cohesion.

Catra gave an overexaggerated sigh of annoyance. "Yes, Adora. Twice. Don't ruin it." She said the last bit a little softer, while gently adding a little more space between. Her hands never left Adora's face. "Now, let's try this again. How are you feeling?"

Adora wasn't sure how to answer, being far too *aware* of Catra at the moment. She was so torn; part of her wanted to bring Catra even closer, to mesh their bodies together as tightly as possible. The other was recoiling at the slightest touch of the other woman. She remained stock still, unable to bring reason to her thoughts, let alone speak them.

She did not know how long she stood there, unmoving, but she came back to herself when she felt Catra drop her hand and step back. Adora turned to regard the now distant other person with an inquisitive turn of her head. *Where go. Why leave.*

Catra's pride was damaged and embarrassment flooded her system. She sought to keep grounded, trying to stay present and focused on Adora's needs. *She just told you she was afraid of things like this and then you go and do that. It's a wonder she isn't fleeing in terror right now…* Her voice came out soft and pleading. "What can I do, 'Dor? I… I didn't mean to make things worse." Her ears lowered in the shame she wasn't able to hide and most annoyingly tears prickled at her eyes.

Adora continued to stare at her, head cocked. She took in Catra's body language: huddled, uncertain, nervous. She noticed how her tail was wrapped around her waist, always a clear sign of when she was feeling troubled as if she was trying to make herself as small as possible. But at the same token, Adora also took in the slight flush to her face; barely visible unless someone looked very intently. She fixated on how Catra's wide and filled eyes wouldn't leave her own; the two-toned beauty swept over her, seeking. The longer Adora stared at Catra the more she began to see that below the precariousness of her mannerisms... Catra was ready to act, to respond to whatever the blonde needed from her in an instant.

Adora was working on something, something that felt big. Her rational brain was asserting to her that Catra needed comfort of her own right now and that standing motionless like an idiot would just lead to problems between the two down the road. Catra did not take kindly to being ignored, after all. Particularly when she was already agitated.

Her emotional brain was turbulent; jumping from utter elation to apprehension of a very new and uncertain situation. Adora was barely given a few seconds of each emotion before it leap-frogged away from her and another took its place. From time to time her nerve endings shouted their discontent at no longer being stimulated in any way and inquired if they could go back to that now, please.

But mostly Adora was amazed at how not *afraid* she was… because Catra was there. Ready to give her anything she required, to do anything to fix the situation she perceived she had broken. Catra was prepared to follow her to the end again; to

push away her own insecurities that so clearly buzzed around her and to put Adora first. *Catra will take care of me.*

Adora did not feel the need to flee the situation. She did not feel she needed to go run laps until her legs gave out. She did not want to lift heavy weights until her muscles trembled and snapped. She did not feel the need to be punished or sink her herself into some distraction. What she did need was…

She crossed to Catra wordlessly, took the woman's face in her hands and kissed her soundly.

This was *so much* better now Adora was not on the brink of death. Full on light-years apart better. Though Catra had tensed at first when she felt lips hit her own, it only took her half a second before she was all into this. Adora's lips were soft, warm and even staying close-mouthed, Catra could do this forever. Her tail immediately uncurled from her waist to firmly fasten itself to Adora's own waist. *Talk is worth it if it ends up like this.*

The two broke apart naturally before long and slotted their foreheads together, perfectly contented smiles completed the picture.

"Wow…" Adora sighed out dreamily. "That was just… wow…"

Catra couldn't even bring herself to show any snark at the verbal eloquence Adora just displayed. "Yeah…" She knew she was

purring and purring loudly, but she could no more stop that than stop loving Adora.

They stayed like this for several more beats, breathing each other in and reveling in the moment. Feeling fully relaxed, Adora couldn't help it when a small yawn bit at the back of her throat. She tried to swallow it down, but her eyelids were getting heavier by the second.

"Am I boring you, princess?" Catra couldn't help but tweak at her, finding the small yawn to be completely adorable. *She lives up to her namesake so well.*

"No! No, 'course not. I'd stay up like this with you all night." Adora snuck a small kiss in after she said this, as if to prove her devotion to the idea.

"Mmm, you're definitely making it seem tempting, but it has been a really long day. Maybe we should head upstairs and call it a night?"

Adora nodded and then tensed for a second. Upstairs. Right. "Yeeeah. Upstairs! Right. Yes, there are probably places to sleep upstairs… I hope…." The last bit was said under her breath, as if the feline woman's keen ears wouldn't pick up on that, especially with how close they currently were.

"Wait. Are you telling me you've been in this house for *how long* and you haven't even been upstairs yet?" Catra's tail puffed up slightly against Adora's middle as her purring stopped. "Adora, what if something was wrong? Like if someone was hiding up there, waiting for an unsuspecting visitor to come in so they could get murdered? I can't believe you didn't do a full area-sweep; it hasn't been that long since basic training!"

"Hey! I had a lot on my mind after everything earlier. And this house is Glimmer's so..." The blonde shrugged, case closed and won in her mind. She had a roof over her head, food, and water. Also, pretty sure she aced basic back in the day, so Catra could quit with the theatrics.

Catra just shook her head. She was feeling way too… everything right now. Bone-tired, but in a satisfied way. Actually, everything felt satisfying if she was being perfectly honest with herself. Even the thought of an axe murderer living on the second floor, ready to take them out as they slept really wasn't that bad. She'd take out the fucker first and maybe Adora would reward her bravery with another kiss. Or two. Or twenty. She purred absently at the thought.

Adora giggled. "You really can't be that mad about it since you're purring again…"

"What? Am not." She definitely still was. "... Shut up. I guess now instead of getting some sleep, we had better go scope out the upstairs. I don't know, princess, this is definitely going to merit some remarks on my mission review write-up for the Queen. 'Failed to fully secure the premises before superior officer's admittance.' It doesn't sound too good, does it?"

"Oh, there is *so* much wrong with what you just said, I don't even know where to begin." Adora chucked her tongue, pulling away from their hold dramatically. "But you know what, Force Captain? I am way too tired to get into all that right now. Sorry, not playing into your little game."

"Then why'd you call me Force Captain, eh?" She flashed Adora a victorious grin, fully convinced she'd won. *We'll play as long as I want to, thank you very much.*

"Thought it'd be kinda hot." Adora said plainly before heading towards the hallway where she'd dropped their bags upon arrival. "Wasn't wrong either…" She called over her shoulder as she disappeared into the foyer. But not before taking a moment to waggle her eyebrows at the spluttering woman she'd left behind.

Catra narrowed her eyes before heading to join the blonde. *She can never find out about the power she holds…*

Before long the pair marched in file up the stairs. Catra didn't really think that there would be anything wrong with the second half of the house. In fact, she was momentarily stunned at how at ease she felt in these completely new surroundings. Huh. But still, as she walked in front of Adora up the stairs, she partially unsheathed her claws, just in case.

"Really, Catra? Claws?"

"Shh. Just because some of us just waltz into foreign, unsecured areas completely oblivious to the potential danger, doesn't mean we all want to die a horrible death due to carelessness."

Adora snorted in response and kept walking until they reached the top of the stairs. "Shoot, Catra, it's dark." They had turned on several lamps around the sitting room at the start of dinner and with the rollercoaster she had just ridden, it didn't occur to Adora that light sources would be necessary up here. Until she found herself unable to really perceive much around her.

"More points in the oblivious column of the report for you, 'Dor. You're just realizing this now? Sun set hours ago. Look, you know I can see in the dark. Just stay here a sec while I go check out the first room. I'm sure there will be a lamp or candle or something in there. But I swear if you move from this spot you'll only wish there was a nice murderer up here."

Catra approached the door at the top of the stairs and cautiously opened it, pausing a moment to allow her extraordinary senses to detect anything awry. Adora considered for a moment grabbing onto the tail she could feel swishing around her, just to spook the woman, but thought better of it when she remembered Catra's claws were out. *Don't need a repeat of that damage any time soon. She-Ra's a great healer and all, but it still hurts.*

Wait. She-Ra. "Hey, Catra. I'm gonna-..."

“Would you be quiet? It’s like you have no sense of self-preservation.” Catra’s words were clipped and barely audible. She still stood outside the doorway of the room, trying to pick up any sounds of movement from anywhere around them.

“Catra, I just want to warn you that…”

“Shhhhh!”

“Look, I’m just gonna…”

Catra turned and stuck a hand over the blonde’s mouth to stifle her. She could hear Adora huff out indignantly. A flash of bright light momentarily blinded her. Her hand dropped to her side lamely as the mouth it was covering instantly shot up two or three feet higher.

A self-satisfied smirk from 8 feet up peered down at Catra. “I glow.”

“... Right. Well, get your glowing butt into a room and secure it. We got ground to cover.” Catra muttered something along the lines of ‘stupid glowy show-off’ and finally entered the new room.

It was a standard bedroom; not much different from what one might find back at the castle, though thankfully to Catra’s eyes, not dripping in pinks and purples. She hadn’t really given much

mind to the decor on the first floor, having been far more focused on Adora at the time, but she supposed if the rest of the house were like this room, it was a nice enough place.

She quickly searched the area, paying special mind to check under the bed, in the closet and throughout the adjoining wash room, while also letting her nose pick up any unfamiliar scents. Of course, in a new place, just about everything was an unfamiliar scent but Catra trusted her intuition enough that since nothing felt off, she could mark this one down as done.

She repeated the process with the adjacent room to the left (another bedroom) and prepared to enter her third when Adora came out of the one across from it yawning. "Get murdered yet?" The amazonian goddess said sleepily.

"Hardee har-har, princess. You better be checking these rooms thoroughly. This is your fault; should have been done hours before you decided to rearrange the whole damn pantry." Catra stalked into the third room, which turned out to be a large bathroom, complete with a garden tub for soaking. A window over the ceiling let in a patch of silvery moonlight over the tub. *Perfect for those who want to stew in their own filth for a while. Count me out.* She did a sweep and left the moon-soaked tub behind her.

"Catra, this is ridiculous. There's like a billion rooms up here and I'm tired." It was almost amusing to see a mythical hero whine. "Look, you and I both know the chances of there being anyone up here are slim to none. This place was not only locked but probably warded to hell before Glim got here. Let's just go to bed and we can finish in the morning. If we're killed in our sleep, I take full responsibility, I promise."

The feline just nodded, agreeing that it seemed unlikely the Bright Moon royalty wouldn't have put some protections- probably magical, against intruders on one of their properties. *Sparkles was really stretching with this one, wasn't she?* "All right. You win; we'll finish in the morning."

Adora as She-Ra slumped against the wall in relief. "Thank the stars, I'm this close to passing out." She looked around. "So…"

"Yes?"

"... Where are you going to y'know, sleep?"

"Oh." The thought really hadn't occurred to Catra yet. As with every other detail of the day, bigger things just tended to be on her mind. "I guess in the first bedroom I checked. It was nice."

"Alone?" Adora bit her lip, not sure what she wanted the answer to be.

After a moment's pause, Catra nodded. "... For tonight, at least. I know this is supposed to be a sleepover but." She shrugged, letting the gesture fill in. "You okay with that?"

Adora waited to see if disappointment flooded her system. It didn't, not really. She would never give up the chance to spend time with Catra (not again, never again) but an opportunity to be alone with herself wasn't an unwelcomed prospect either. "Yeah, I am. But you better give me a good night kiss, at least."

Catra sucked in a small breath, more than a little astounded at how quickly they'd come in a short amount of time. She glanced up at the towering blonde and considered. "... Not like that."

"Huh?" Adora looked down at herself, eyebrows crinkled in confusion. "Like what?"

"... Not as She-Ra." It could be difficult enough to be in the presence of She-Ra; difficult in a variety of ways, ranging from the feel of her very existence to Catra's still processing memories of hurt that came from seeing Adora's legendary warrior form. But the fact of the matter was, Catra was nowhere near ready to stop kissing *Adora* , hadn't nearly gotten her fill of that particular activity yet, and just plain wasn't interested in the other form. Even if it was still Adora. *Ugh, space girlfriends are weird. … Is she my girlfriend? Eh, tomorrow.*

"I won't be able to see." Adora pouted as she shrunk down to her regular form, darkness enveloping her once more.

Catra took that moment to stalk lithely towards her prey. "And what would you need to see, Adora? Pretty sure you just need to be able to… feel…" At the word feel, she brushed a finger gently across the blonde's mouth, claw extended just enough.

Adora shivered against the touch but held firm. “You. I like seeing you.”

“Don’t tell me you kept your eyes open before. That might be a dealbreaker if I knew your baby blues were staring me down as we kissed.”

“You’re infuriating, you know that?”

“Yes, but you like me anyway so…”

“Hmph. Remains to be seen sometimes. But were you going to kiss me or-” Lips latched onto Adora’s before she could finish the sentence.

Their fourth kiss held more heat than any of the others, with Catra leading it (and no one in the process of dying any time soon). They tumbled against one another, perfection to be found in their clumsiness. By happy accident, Adora’s teeth lightly grazed Catra’s bottom lip. Catra gave an involuntary moan as it happened, causing Adora to inhale sharply at the sound before repeating the movement with purpose. And adding a small flick of her tongue for good measure, though she could not tell you where the idea sprung from. *Instinct?*

That little move earned her another low moan, louder this time. But also a break from their kiss. “You’re going to kill me if you keep doing that.” Adora could swear Catra was panting as she spoke. Adora knew she sure as hell was.

“Better me than the murderer…” Adora replied, closing their lips together again, albeit in a much more chaste manner. They held this softer kiss for as long as they could, delighting in the feel of how perfectly their mouths fit together.

It was only with great regret and several more short kisses to follow that they finally broke away to bid each other good night. Each woman went into her respective bedroom to lay out across the bed and wait for morning to come again, only so they could see one another again.

Chapter End Notes

Sleep is such a natural place to end things, isn't it? But will they actually manage to catch some zzz's? Hm, hm, hm...

Also can you tell I hate writing setting? The house got a description last chapter, but god knows I'm not pouring through every detail of a room down to a color scheme. Fortunately I think the two girls would agree. If nice enough works for Catra, it works for me. ;-)

Inevitable

Chapter Notes

> Figure it's in best taste to state that there's mentions of blood, child abuse (but no worse than what was presented in the show) and a panic attack during this chapter for those who may appreciate an advanced warning. Oh, and some explicit scenes, but if you're reading a fic that's tagged as eventual smut, I think it can be handled.
>
> The real smut WILL be next, I promise, and has its own chapter for anyone who's not interested in such things. It's mostly written, but my wife-to-be's birthday is tomorrow and I want to spend it with her, which might not leave much time for writing over the weekend. So take some more hurt/comfort, folks!
>
> Thank you all so much for reading/commenting/kudos. It means the world to me.

Adora was having the strangest dream. Was it even a dream? She felt semi-lucid, though unable to exert any control or direction on wherever this was taking her. She could only watch the disjointed pictures as they shifted at their own whim and fancy. It began with Catra and Perfuma walking through the gardens of Bright Moon, arm-in-arm and laughing. Perfuma paused the pair's stride to give Catra a most loving look that quickly turned hungry. "Man, am I so glad I started joining you for… *meditation* ." She heard Catra say while returning the willowy blonde's amorous gaze with one of her own.

It then quickly changed to a scene of a younger Catra being electrocuted by Shadow Weaver. Her small body contorted into unnatural positions as the painful waves of hate shocked her into submission. Weaver's dark energy held Adora against the wall of

the room so she could only watch helplessly as Catra writhed in pain again and again. Weaver laughed, the sound chilling Adora to her very core. She was entirely powerless to stop Shadow Weaver's cruelty which only continued to increase in its severity. Even after Catra was knocked into unconsciousness, Weaver's laughter and torment did not cease.

Next, she was at the Princess Prom, in the middle of the dance floor surrounded by people and yet completely alone. She watched as Bow and Perfuma danced happily together. Glimmer and Frosta twirled around merrily, giggling as they knocked into the other dancers around them. Mermista and Sea Hawk swayed together, oblivious to the outside world. And Catra was surrounded by a gaggle of girls, none of which Adora recognized, but they hung off her as she was looking so fine in that damn suit. Adora was all alone, watching as her friends ignored her soundly, too caught up in their own moment to give her any mind. She could not move from the center of the floor.

Then, back to the Horde where she saw Lonnie and Catra pressed up against one another in the locker room. Lonnie had Catra against the row of lockers and was kissing her neck, licking teasingly and biting. Her hands were groping at Catra's body, pulling off her leather garb. Once her fingers were positioned firmly between Catra's thighs, Catra gripped her fingers in Lonnie's dreads and sighed. "Finally! Now that Adora is gone…"

Huntara pressed her foot against the back of Adora's head, firmly pushing it into the ground. She could feel the blood flow freely down her face and her teeth begin to crack at the pressure. "Such a weakling. Some hero *you* are."

The jumbled onslaught continued as Adora was then tied up on Mara's ship in the Crimson Waste. She saw Catra lounging on the captain's chair of the ship, one leg cocked over the arm of the seat and a smug grin plastered across her face. Scorpia strutted into the room, eyes trained on Catra as she approached the reclined woman. Turning to look Adora dead in the eye, Scorpia smarmed out to her. "I'm brave, I'm loyal, and I give *great* head…" before kneeling in front of a now pantless Catra, who had her head thrown back in ecstasy.

Angella, the portal a whirling dervish in the background, stared at her with cold, imperious eyes. "I'll never see my daughter again because of you."

Double Trouble flashed an impish grin towards an eager looking Catra before they pronounced silkily, "Whatever you want, kitten…" They blurred into another Catra and the pair began to kiss angrily, tearing clothes off one another with loud rips. Adora could not tell you which Catra sunk their hands into who's hot, dripping slit first.

The final scene of the apparent nightmare featured the collapsing Heart. It was once again her and Catra at the end of the world, except this time Catra lay in Adora's arms. Great tears and bloody gashes covered her body and she was scarcely breathing. Adora's own body was not any better, Prime's virus coursing through her and taking its deadly toll. Adora clutched at the broken frame in her arms, tears flowing uncontrollably. She was trying to summon She-Ra but failed again and again. She was not able to summon even a flicker of power; there would be no chance at healing Catra's grievous wounds. "C-Catra, I'm so sorry. I've failed you…" Adora choked out the words.

Catra's mismatched eyes fluttered open slightly as she weakly began to speak. "Adora, you promised… But I..." Before she could finish, the light faded from her eyes completely. She was gone forever. Adora could only hold the girl she cherished so dearly in her arms as the universe came to an end around them. It was all her fault.

Adora awoke panting and crying freely. So much was so real. So much was so painful. It had been absurdity woven into reality; a tapestry of all her greatest insecurities and failures, laid out for her to experience one agonizing moment at a time. She huddled into a tight ball on the bed, weeping and clutching her stomach against all that pained her in that moment.

She willed her crying to halt though her breath still came in short, painful gasps. Her chest ached with the struggle and she was certain she would never get enough air. An unclear, panic-laced thought coursed through her mind on repeat. *Need to know she's alive.* Woodenly she swung her legs from her curled position on the bed. She staggered as she rose, unsteady on her feet but managed to limp her way to the door of her room. *Need to know she's alive.*

Adora yanked the door open, numb to the loud crack it made against the wall behind it. She could not remember which door led to the room Catra was staying in. She looked around, there were so many doors and so many possibilities! Catra could be anywhere and Adora could not remember. She stepped into the hallway and crumbled to the floor. *I've failed.*

Like hell Catra would be sleeping any time soon. Not after *everything* . Adora had kissed her *finally* . Adora had asked *her* for a kiss goodnight and boy, Catra hoped she delivered. Goodness knows Adora certainly had for her. She inwardly moaned at the recollection of Adora's teeth biting at her lip, teasing herself with visions of where that tongue flick could have been put to even better use.

Her body burned at the imprint Adora's own had left on it. Catra's core buzzed impatiently at the memories and demanded attention. She normally would never be so brazen, but desire had overwhelmed her good senses. Her hand shot to where she needed pressure the most and began to rub against herself, pace gradually building. Though her hand still remained over the layers of her sleepwear, too impatient with need.

Her thoughts were a wild, tangled mess of want and desire all circling back to blonde hair, corded muscle, and steel-blue eyes. Her breath came in faster pants as she felt tension build within her. Her body yearned for release, for touch, for Adora's hand, mouth, any part of her Catra could possibly be granted. She envisioned the feel of skin, the heat of bodies writhing together, and the taste of Adora so salty sweet against her lips. She was worked up into a tantalizing frenzy, getting closer and closer by the second...

Until, a loud crash brought her out of her thoughts and activities, her fur instantly standing on point. She bolted into the hallway, claws fully extended and ready to shred anything that dared to threaten her Adora. Her heart hammered at the sudden switch of energies and direction. It was pure adrenaline and muscle memory that kicked into action at the foreign and alarming sound.

It did not take her nocturnal eyes long to take in the form of Adora crumpled on the hallway floor, back slumped against the wall just outside her bedroom door. She gasped and was by Adora's side in an instant, checking her over for any sign of injury or blood. She found none but that did not ease her even minutely. "Adora? What's wrong?" Her voice was tight with anxiety, heart somehow managing to beat even more urgently.

Adora looked straight ahead numbly, the tears beginning again and barely able to register Catra's presence. She could not tell if this was real or not- the nightmare had so distorted her perception of the world. It had lied to her again and again; she *knew* it was lies stemming from all her weaknesses, every stray insecurity that tore at her heart in the private prison of her mind, but still it had a stranglehold on her good senses. She sat motionlessly, defeated on a cold, unfamiliar floor.

"Adora. Adora, you *need* to talk to me." Catra chanced putting her hands on Adora's shoulders to gently shake her. Was she paralyzed? Stunned? *What could have done this to her?* "Please… Please, just say *something* …!" Catra pleaded for any direction from the blonde, the universe, anyone who may be listening to her plight.

At Catra's touch, Adora's paralytic haze seemed to thaw slightly. She turned her head scarcely in the direction of Catra's face and opened her mouth. No words came out. There were no words.

"Adora, please, if you're hurt or if something's wrong, just give me some sort of sign! I can't fix it if I don't know what's wrong…"

Unable to take the idea of her beloved Adora damaged in any way, she threw her arms fully around the other girl, repressing the urge to sob as any semblance of control over the situation was torn from her. She buried her face into Adora's hair, helpless. She didn't know what else to do. It was just so jarring- they could not have been parted for very long. Catra knew she spent time thinking, pacing about her room, and fantasizing before engaging in an attempt at carnal release but she hadn't heard *anything* before the crash. Nothing had felt off, nothing had smelled out of place. This damn house had done something though. Catra hated herself for her inattention. She should have swept every last room before retiring. Once again, she showed how lazy and reckless she truly was.

As Catra held her, Adora's obscurity defrosted even more. That innate urge to protect and to soothe Catra overcame all else. Slowly her hand reached up and meekly rested on Catra's back, a small squeeze given. "You're okay…" Adora breathed out. "You're alive."

The barely perceptible connection was an invigorating shock to Catra's system. She pulled back from where her face was buried in Adora's hair, hands gripping Adora's face, taking in the lidded blue eyes that finally showed some hint of life behind them. " *I'm* alive? What about you?" Catra's voice cracked with high-strung, nervous laughter. *Trust Adora to be worried about someone else when she's prone on the floor.* "Baby, please, tell me what happened. Are you okay? Are we safe? Who hurt you!"

Adora gave a measly shrug in acknowledgement of this newest pet name, a dazed smile at her lips. If she had been able to see herself, she would have been absolutely humiliated at the deranged look she was currently giving Catra. But, Catra was

alive. She was here. Nothing else mattered. She swallowed painfully and tried to sit up against the wall better. More and more of her faculties were returning, brought to life again by Catra. *Just like before… Just like always…*

Catra helped her reposition best she could, still mindful of the possibility of unseen injury. Adora drew in a shuddering breath and summoned the will to speak more. "... A dream. S'just a dream… Bad one."

"A dream…?" Catra inhaled, willing her impulse to lash out to stay down, for once. "You had a bad dream. And it caused… *this?* " The control over her temper was weak, but she had been so undeservedly afraid at this moment. She reminded herself that she was no stranger to bad dreams either; as flashes of green light and tanks of strange liquid regularly haunted the back of her mind and her slumber. Her impulsive vexation cooled with empathy.

Adora gave a tiny, robotic nod of her head, feeling distinctly Catra's barely hidden anger at her. *Failing her again…*

"Okay, baby, let's get up off the floor. It's okay. I promise it's okay. You're safe. We're safe and we're together." Catra painfully rose to her feet, her body protesting at movement given its previously clenched state. She held her hands out to Adora and fought to get her off the floor too. Adora fell into her heavily, but they managed to make it back into Adora's room and on to the bed.

Side by side, the women laid on the mattress silently. Catra was trying to again calm her composure against the onslaught that had just been thrown onto her in such a short period of time. Adora was trying to find the words to comfort and take care of Catra, but she felt spent. The most she could manage was to wrap their fingers together and give a light squeeze.

Neither party knew how long they lay like that. Catra was the first to pull herself upright, massaging her head against her hands and processing the next step. "... You okay?" Not the solace and ease she had hoped to impart on her troubled love, but it was the best she could manage currently.

Adora did not try to move from her position, just nodded mutely in response. She could see Catra digging at her eyes again, clearly in distress. "You?"

"As peachy as ever… D'you want some water?" Her throat burned with thirst.

"Yeah. Please." Catra rose from the bed at the affirmative response, only vaguely concerned at the thought of there even being clean water on premises. She knew she had a partially filled waterskin in her bag, which would have to do for now. Almost as if Adora could read her thoughts, she croaked out. "Sink in the kitchen. Clear water, s'fine."

Feeling slightly more robust at a small sliver of purpose, Catra turned to leave the room. Before she had stepped even two footfalls away from the bed, she paused for a moment, then

turned back and gently leaned down to place a small kiss on Adora's forehead. "... I love you." It came out more terse and tense than she hoped; Catra fervently hoped it would be well received.

"Love you too." Adora's eyes filled with relief, pressure easing out of her by such a simple but profound gesture. "Hurry back; miss you too much."

Catra chuckled, shaking her head in response and stole away downstairs. Adora rested her head more gently against the mattress, the phantom press of Catra's lips still clear against her skin. She hummed in lassitude; the dream felt so impossibly far away from the bubble of care and comfort Catra had crafted around them. Still, she knew that it was only fair to Catra that she try to explain what had prompted such a ruckus. Afterall, Catra's night had just been thoroughly uprooted; she had probably been dead asleep when Adora clattered into the hallway! Adora knew she couldn't do justice in explaining, but for her Catra, she would try.

Catra returned in short order with glasses and a large metal pitcher full of ice cold water. Both women drank their fill, refreshed and soothed by their now slaked thirst. Adora closed her eyes and gave a calming inhale. "Hey… I just want to say, thank you. For helping me."

"Sure, 'Dor, because I would just leave you laying out in the hallway, half-dead for all I know, while I went and had myself a nice nap." Catra rolled her eyes but smiled. "No need to thank me, dummy."

"No, Catra. Seriously. *Thank you* . I know that this hasn't been a perfect time together lately…" Adora bit her lip, wincing at some more recent outbursts between the two. "But you have been just so amazing. And wonderful and patient and I just am so *lucky* to have you." She could feel her eyes welling again, but she fought against that. "And it's like my brain is doing it damnedest to sabotage all of it."

Catra tried to protest, but Adora cut her off by laying her fingers lightly over her mouth. "Hush. I need to get this out. I'm just so scared to lose you again, Catra. I couldn't bear it if anything happened to you or if… well, you decided this," Adora gestured towards herself lamely, "wasn't for you. I mean, of course I would *respect* that and like, let you go or whatever, I just want you to be happy, but… Yeah. Anyway, that's a lot of what my dream was; losing you. Or you choose someone else- Lonnie, Scorpia, girls I didn't even know… But always someone better, sexier, able to *satisfy* you." She gulped loudly at that, licking her lips nervously. *Don't lose momentum; pull it together, champ.* "I mean, there was a lot of other stuff- loneliness, being beaten, failing, more failure… but it ended with us at the Heart. Except, we didn't make it out this time. In fact, you d-died in my arms. And just after everything else… It hit me. Really hard." Adora seemed to wilt as she finished. She really could use a hug right now.

Catra considered the information that was being presented to her; really tried to take it in and digest it. So much she could understand but also... Her eyebrows were furrowed in concentration, mouth drawn into a tight line. The pair sat for several tense beats before Catra finally spoke. "Adora, I know that dreams can be really painful and I am so sorry it hurt you, scared you. I also know that you have no control over it, but… A lot of that is really dumb, even for you."

Adora gave a start; she did not expect her nightmare of losing Catra to be called dumb. Or maybe she was being called dumb for having it. Whatever it was, Catra wasn't that cruel anymore, was she? Adora opened her mouth to speak, to defend herself, but Catra cut her off. "When did you first know you loved me?"

Adora shook her head at this unexpected turn in conversation. It was a little closer to the consolation she was hoping for since the subject of love was at least broached, but the unreadable expression on Catra's face did nothing to ease her. She scrambled to find an answer to a question that had none. There was no defining moment, at least none that Adora could pinpoint. One day she woke up and knew her feelings were no longer just friendly or platonic. "I… don't know. I mean, I always have in some way…"

"I knew I was in love with you from the moment we met. And I don't mean that in some cheesy, mushy way like some people might *claim* to love someone else. No, it's a simple, undeniable fact of life. Grass is green, water is wet, and I am in love with Adora. The second you peeked your head into that box I was dumped in and screamed out "Kitty!" before throwing your dumb little arms around me, I was yours completely. And every single day after that, it grew. It grew so big and so wild that when you were gone, I couldn't manage it. I didn't respond well to it, as you know, but it never let me be for even one damned minute. Everything was you, just you. I could no more stop breathing than stop loving you. Again, not going for dramatics here, princess. I'm stating the truth. All of *this* …" Catra made the same gesture towards Adora that she had made at herself just moments ago. "...is all my fucking wildest hopes, dreams, fantasies, and aspirations. It's what I have spent my entire life craving and

chasing after. And now that I have you, I am never going to let you go."

Catra took a deep breath, continuing to stare Adora down. "There is no one else, Adora. There couldn't be. It's always been and always will be you. I guess now, I gotta show that to you every day, because I'm not sure you'll really *get it* otherwise. And no matter what your brain tries to do, this can't be broken. It's not *luck* ; we were inevitable. At least you were for me..."

Adora wasn't exactly sure how she had lost control of the conversation, her chance at explaining the dream as the newest dramatic unfolding of her life, but she did know she simply did not care in least. Because there were no words to follow that up. Adora didn't even want to try. Anything she could come up with, any affirmation of returned affection would just pale in comparison. So instead she let her action speak for her by folding Catra into her arms and laying them both down at the head of the bed to rest. She stroked Catra's soft curls lovingly, other hand lightly running her fingers up and down Catra's arm in a soothing manner. A purr was easily drawn out. At the sound, Adora gave Catra one soft kiss on the lips before shutting her eyes, letting thoughts of *inevitability* lull her to sleep.

Release

Chapter Notes

> Well, here we go, folks! My first foray into the world of smut. Which turns out will be a part 1 of 2 deal, because naturally these girls just can't get things done in a timely manner. At least not with me writing them!
>
> I sincerely hope you find it enjoyable & engaging (as opposed to ponderous and overly verbose).
>
> Thank you so much for reading; cannot believe the over 3000 hits. Appreciate you all and look forward to bringing you part two as soon as I can.
>
> Comments, feedback, and even-more-effectives always welcome!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora awoke some time later, just as the dawn began to creep in from the window. Sunrises were often the first part of her morning ritual, but it still inspired her to take grateful stock of her current position. Catra's limbs were spread out fully across Adora in a protective embrace. One arm was underneath Adora's head behind her neck, with Catra's own head tucked snuggly against the crook of Adora's shoulder. Her bottom half was slung over Adora's leg and centered against her thigh. It was a privileged position to wake up in, one she would be honored if she got to have for the rest of her life.

Thoughts drifting around the possibility of this being her life's most wonderful sentencing, she took time to really examine the woman wrapped around her: from her short, messy locks that were matted with sleep, then down her angled jawline that held no tension during her rest. She drank in the slope of her neck and

lightly muscled shoulders that connected to toned arms. Her fingers were relaxed, claws in a neutral position, but Adora knew from experience that within milliseconds they could be dangerous weapons. She had no fear of that; Catra's hands were now meant to hold and caress, not claw and punch. Her thoughts strayed slightly as she continued her inspection down Catra's back towards her slackened tail curled around them and her most inviting-looking bottom. Adora did not let her gaze linger long there, blushing for a half-second, before moving on to appreciate the sinewy muscles of her thighs and calves, even admiring for a moment her agile feet.

Catra was beautiful. Stunning. Gorgeous. No words could do justice to the woman, not in the slightest. Adora may not have known exactly when in her history that her feelings for Catra had shifted towards romance, but was certain that she was irrevocably and profoundly in love with her. It was humbling, extraordinary, and nearly brought Adora to tears with the depths she felt for Catra. Nothing was insurmountable so long as they were together.

Her reflection of Catra's form left Adora feeling completely at peace. She was perfectly intent on settling more deeply into the mattress and maybe catching a little more sleep. She gave a stretch of her lower back, allowing it rise from the bed and any tension it was holding to release. What she wasn't taking into consideration was that her quad muscles would *also* rise in turn with the stretch. The repercussions of that motion did not dawn on her in the slightest until Catra gave a small moan as Adora's leg shifted up against her. "Oh…" Adora breathed out at the sound.

Catra's eyes flicked open instantly, immediately registering that she was meshed against Adora entirely, with her arms wrapped

around her beloved. Catra could feel every miniscule movement, every drawn breath, every muscle twitch the blonde gave; everything that surrounded her was only Adora. Any fluster she may have felt quickly disappeared, replaced with the hazy flickers of a need left unfulfilled from last night. That familiar flare egged her on, though she would not let it best her. With a lazy, playful smile she lifted her head to peer at Adora above her. "Well. That's certainly a 'Good morning'. You can do that again anytime, but let's try for when I'm actually awake next."

Adora's response was to turn a deep scarlet and look anywhere but at Catra. Such a stark difference from only moments ago when Catra was all she could take in. But her heart was beginning to clamor wildly at the possibility that errant leg raise sparked. She knew Catra was just teasing her; that's what she did. But the feel of Adora's thigh when it pressed against the lissome woman in that way was so alluring. And coupled with that *moan* ... It generated a craving deep within Adora that she was still processing through. She couldn't rise to the playful jab; oh no, bigger things were afoot.

Catra's bravado faltered under that silence and avoidance. Looks like this was her cue that such things were not welcomed by Adora at this time. It was perfectly reasonable; Catra had meant it when she told Adora they were in no hurry and obviously the bumbling woman just hadn't been thinking about what a shift like that would do to her. Hoping to ease her love's obvious discomfort, she went to swing herself off the other woman and towards the other side of the bed. *If not out the damn window.* Adora had needed comfort last night, that stupid dream tearing her up completely, and the first thing Catra does the following morning is make a slimy joke? *Poor taste, asshole.*

Feeling the shift away from her, Adora's hand shot out against Catra's upturned hip, pinning it back down to its original place against her with an ironclad grip. She did not want Catra to move. She was still working out exactly what she did want and more importantly how to get there, but very much knew that it required Catra to stay right there. The craving only grew in its intensity at the contact, especially when she felt the woman's warming center press against her again. Her own desire settled low into her abdomen, with the realization that Catra was very near a place on Adora that was starting to need some attention.

The force of that unexpected grasp caused Catra's core to rock into Adora's thigh once again. Catra moaned reflexively, shutting her eyes at the pleasure that rocked through her. *Holy shit… She wants me to stay there?!* The flickers were immediately a healthy, burning fire that made her crave more and less. More contact, more friction, and less clothes. She looked up at Adora who was watching for reaction carefully. Catra licked her lips in anticipation, wanting nothing more than to seal their mouths together. But something in Adora's face gave her pause; the blonde was planning. Strategizing. Catra decided it was more interesting to not react *yet* , and just placed her hands on either side of Adora's flat, toned stomach though still remained chastly above clothing. She shuddered at the feel of muscle beneath her hands, claws tiptoeing out to snag at the fabric. *Take your time, Adora. I'm fine here- but I am going to play, if you'll let me.*

Adora's hand was still tightly grasped onto Catra's hip as she studied the scene carefully before making her next move. She liked that her fingers fit along Catra's curves so perfectly; almost as if they were made to be slotted there. *Inevitable* . She really liked hearing Catra moan like that, against her, and honestly wanted to do anything to bring it out of her again and again. Adora was fairly certain she could with just a tiny roll of her hips. She enjoyed the sense of power it gave her; if she could make

Catra sound like *that* with a few motions... The first time had been an accident, but Adora knew what grounding her hand against Catra to keep her stationary would do. *She did say any time she was awake.*

And she **really** enjoyed Catra's hands against her. She could periodically feel the tiny bite of claws against her skin; it was electrifying, nowhere near painful. The low burn shot up several thousand degrees with every swipe of Catra's hands along her. She also couldn't help but notice how patient Catra was being; letting Adora lead and waiting for her to plan her next move. It showed such consideration and understanding that Adora was nearly brought out of her more carnal impulses in favor of sentimental ones. Until Catra caught her eye and held her gaze, flicking one eyebrow up in question as she lowered herself down so her mouth was parallel over Adora's taut stomach. She waited there for permission until Adora gave a slight head nod then began peppering light kisses over her shirt.

Feeling muscles tighten and contract beneath her mouth was one of the best feelings Catra had ever been privileged to experience. She wanted nothing more than to rip Adora's sleep tank off and roll her tongue over every inch of her shredded girlfriend. (She was definitely Catra's girlfriend; no more question there.) But she stayed her desire and kept things more or less under control. Adora could pull the brakes at any time; Catra did not want to take that power from her. She just reveled in the sensation of corded muscle against her mouth; a small layer of fabric the only barrier from the taste she yearned for. She was surprised to find that the anticipation was fun in its own way. Catra busied herself with continuing the kisses, but not daring to rise any higher or lower on Adora's body.

Oh, Catra's mouth felt so good. Every kiss burned into her exquisitely and caused her core to throb impatiently. She needed more. In her boldest move yet, Adora with a shaking hand lifted the hem of her tank top, no higher than Bow's crop top, giving Catra access to bare skin.

When she felt Adora's shift, Catra had pulled her mouth from her stomach, sitting up and away slightly. She was ready to halt operations instantly, no questions asked, and no hesitation. Adora was completely in control of this; Catra already had been favored beyond comprehension with what had been done so far. *No rush, we have our whole lives to do this.*

Instead she was granted access to a swatch of skin. Bare, delicate, wholly enticing midriff. Catra could only gape, mouth literally hanging open and eyes blown wide. She glanced at the bounty that had been presented to her, openly ogling the chiseled muscle and smooth, unmarred skin. She could feel the heat radiating off of Adora and wanted to live in that burn forever. Her delicate nose picked up scents that could only be described as *Adora* , though stronger in intensity and more intoxicating than Catra had ever experienced. Catra looked up at her, mouth still open, looking for confirmation that the blonde had indeed meant to lift her shirt so. This was not a time for misunderstanding.

Adora wasn't sure she had ever seen Catra look so gobsmacked. Another flush of power, of control, hit her when she saw the mess a little bit of skin had done to the normally cool and collected woman. She arched her eyebrow with a smirk and gave a small jerk of her chin towards her exposed middle. *You gonna do something with that, kitty cat?*

Catra gave a look that could only be described as hungry. Hesitantly, as though she feared the universe would make this one more good thing to rip away from her, Catra returned to her original position, mouth hovering over Adora's unclothed flesh. She breathed in, staying there for a few shaky, panting breaths before lightly placing an innocent kiss against her bare torso.

Adora's toes curled at the sensation of Catra's warm breath and gentle lips brushing her skin. She felt her whole body tense and the throb at her center was now a pounding. It begged for pressure, for any relief. Adora gave a throaty moan that Catra returned in response; it reverberated off Adora's now very sensitive skin.

One small kiss against her exposed flesh was enough for Adora to consider removing her shirt completely and letting Catra just have her in any way she wanted. But as she heard Catra's accompanying moan to her own, her desire to feel Catra's skin quickly overpowered every other urge.

It simply wasn't fair that Adora was getting all the attention when Catra was very much right there and not being touched nearly enough. Slowly Adora loosened her grip on Catra's hip, but only with the express purpose of sliding it down to settle her hand against her firm ass. Adora felt a bolt shoot down her stomach at the contact. Her ass just felt so right in Adora's hand. She gave an experimental squeeze and basked in the glory of yet another sensual outcry from the nubile woman. Adora blazed; her need building to even greater heights.

Catra's breath hitched in surprise and her head shot up away from the stomach she was decorating with her mouth as Adora's hand

groped her ass. *Maybe I did die last night, because there's no way this is actually happening.* Adora's hand gripped tightly against Catra's butt, pulling so her center was rocked against her thigh just as Adora rolled her own hip upwards simultaneously. Another groan of appreciation escaped Catra's lips; her body very much needed pressure there. She fought every impulse to grind heavy against the thigh that was so conveniently where she needed it to be.

Her mind was growing clouded with arousal, but one thing was still starkly clear. She needed to be sure this was truly what Adora wanted before they could move any further. She needed to hear it for herself and be assured, before surrendering completely to the moment. Surrender was not something that came easily to her, nor was it acceptable yet, not until she could be certain that Adora was all in like she was. Because if she were to misunderstand, if she were to be rejected at this moment...

Catra tapped into her swagger, that inexhaustible pool of posturing and bluster that lived within her, all to fortify herself against the worry of being potentially spurned. At this moment, it was truly a herculean feat of obstinance since all she wanted was to fold against Adora and give in to her own desires. Catra gave a taunting wiggle of her ass. "Oh, I'm sure you don't want that."

This wasn't what she wanted?! Behind everything else: the fear, the self-punishment, the distraction to the point of destruction... This was the *only* thing Adora had ever wanted. It was her truth from the moment such feelings and desires had first blossomed within her. She bit back a growl at the words and the arrogance in Catra's tone. There was a time for teasing, but this was not it. Not when Adora was as riled up as she was. Did Catra just not get how incredible it was that they had made it this far? Had she not

been *listening* for the past day? She knew there had been a lot of emotional upheaval yesterday, but Catra had to comprehend the importance and what it meant to be doing things like this together. And so soon! To mock it was almost unforgivable. Not what she wanted. *Really.*

She regarded the face above her, ready to bite back and put this condescending woman in her place. But as she stared, Adora recognized the notes of hesitance and fret behind the patronizing mask. She saw the crinkle of anxiety and insecurity at the corner of beautifully mismatched eyes. Her smirk was worn and thin, a mere guise of the confidence it normally projected. Adora heard the plea behind those cocky words so clearly. *Say you want me, Princess… please.*

The impulse to wrap her arms around the woman above her and ease her fear with loving gestures and kind words was strong. But Adora also realized that they really had been doing *a lot* of that recently and sometimes, Catra just needed to snark for the sake of her emotions. It was her armour, her defense, and really, not every subtle soft spot needed to be explored and soothed. Or maybe it could be, but just in a different way…

She returned Catra's smug smile with one of her own. She tightened her grip against Catra's ass and considered giving it a small slap just to see how the jeering woman would react. She decided better of it; Aodra was fairly certain things like that should be discussed and agreed upon before being performed. (Honestly she wasn't even sure where the impulse came from and made a note to reflect on her own aggression- later.)

She slotted both her hands over Catra's hips and pulled the other woman upright easily while bringing their faces close together. Adora made sure Catra was still positioned in a way that the slightest move, the tiniest rock of her hips would definitely be felt. "You don't get to tell me what I want." Her voice was quietly measured, confident, and as Adora quickly realized, absolutely intoxicating to the other woman.

Catra hissed in surprise at the words as a new wave of desire increased her need more than she thought possible. Quickly her motives changed; she had expected Adora to be flummoxed, to shower her with assurances that yes, this was what she wanted very much! Then Catra could pounce and take what she wanted in return. But this… this was better. Those words and the *way* Adora had said them. A full body shiver coursed down her; she could feel her own wetness and it was begging to be felt by someone else. It was all almost too much to take in at once. But she would not be shaken so easily. She refused to back down, she still needed to hear it, even if she was now fervently hoping it would be Adora taking her instead. "What *do* you want, Adora?"

For a half-second, Adora was transported back to the moment of when she had been asked that question before by Catra. She saw the scene clearly; the escape attempt and scuffle in the Woods. She had messed up then and badly. She had let responsibility, duty, and cold manipulation betray her own happiness. It was a damning pattern in her life, one she knew she had to break if she had any chance going forward.This was the first step towards overcoming it; a do-over, a second chance to right a grievous wrong.

This time there was no doubt in her mind, no uneasy pause while she fought against obligation and with herself. There was only one

answer. “You.”

Mouths crashed together in an instant. Adora flipped them over so she was on top of them, with her leg settled in smoothly to rest against Catra’s center. She could feel the sticky heat and pulsing need roiling at the apex of Catra’s legs. Two-toned eyes, blown wide in surprise and arousal stared up at gray-blue ones.

They sat in this position for a breath, in truth a little uncertain of what came next. But Adora did not let the pause last, not wanting any built momentum to dissipate. She brought their mouths together in a steady but quickly building kiss, earning a sigh of relief from the woman under her. It wasn’t long before Catra’s tongue and teeth were drawing moans of pleasure from Adora. The kisses seared her beautifully and she was so turned on by the woman below her taking some control. That was their dynamic; even when Adora was on top, Catra was calling the shots. She wouldn’t have it any other way.

Adora felt her hand being tugged from Catra’s waist to underneath the hem of her shirt. She groaned deeply at the feel of lightly furred skin and toned muscle beneath her fingertips. She allowed her fingers to caress the sides of Catra’s stomach, down to her hips, committing every fraction of an inch to holy memory. She studied Catra’s reactions when she lightly brushed just with the tips of her fingers, when she made clumsy grasping pulls, and when she drew blunt nails down the sides. She could feel Catra curl underneath her with every touch, back arching, and muscles trembling. Her body unconsciously began to rock against Adora’s intentionally positioned leg, which Adora slowly started to match her pace in turn. Catra threw her head back with a sensual whine at the returned motion, breath coming quicker and the speed picking up. Adora followed at the pace she set, while beginning to

kiss along her jaw, trailing her way to the neck that had been so invitingly exposed for her.

Adora could feel her pulse against her mouth; it beat at a frantic pace. Catra's pants sounded in her ears, the flesh of her neck so pleasantly buzzing against her lips. Adora slowly opened her mouth; she needed to taste her too. A light brush of her tongue against the bare skin made Catra arch her back even deeper than before, the pace she was grinding herself against Adora's leg now at near frantic levels.

Catra could feel the mounting pressure deep in her, that wave so close to breaking and washing over her with sweet, sweet relief. Her breathing was more exerted than it had ever been in her life, every muscle was clenched, just waiting for release. That beautiful goddess above her was going to make her come so hard. *Just a little more; don't stop!* Catra wanted to cry out, but words were beyond her.

Adora continued to give small, teasing licks against her before that need for power drove her to nearly bite as well. She stayed her impulse at the last second. *More stuff that needs talked about… no matter how much I want to...* As compensation for the action she really wanted to take, Adora drove her leg hard into Catra's throbbing center. She put enough force into it that she was effectively pinning Catra down, holding her captive in a way that the other woman was not unable to rub herself against Adora's leg in any sort of satisfying manner. It was an impulse move, born from the desire to do something forceful, but not certain what would be okay. Her leg there so far had been fine, so Adora figured a change in pressure was a safe bet.

Catra nearly sobbed at no longer being able to grind against Adora's leg. She had been so close and of course her beautiful idiot had to go and disrupt it. Any other time being pinned like this under her raw strength would be so hot, but that had not been the time. "Don't stop! Please. Please, I need more. I was so close…"

Adora gave a throaty chuckle, her voice thick with desire at the beseeching tone that came from Catra. It was just so rare and did it for Adora. She wanted to hear more. "I don't think I've ever heard you beg like that before in our entire lives." She gave another kiss against her neck as Catra shook in frustration. "It's really hot."

"Adora. I need you to shut up and *finish me right now* ." The words came from clenched teeth, no longer pleading. "And get your hands moving again, damn it!"

Instantly Adora's stationary hands left Catra's stomach. It wasn't until they arrived at their destination that Adora was even conscious of whether she chose to move up Catra's body or down it. Turns out she went with up, gliding them further up her torso towards her breasts. Adora hesitated; just one reach up was all it would take. *This is the moment you freeze up. Kissing, groping her ass, and grinding is totally fine but here's the line. Really?* She berated herself thoroughly, but was still unable to push herself towards action.

"Grab my tits, Adora." Short, easy to follow commands were best with Adora.

Adora, ever the one to follow orders, inched forward and tentatively placed two fingers against her small, soft breast. Adora sucked in a breath tightly, holding it as her fingers just lightly grazed Catra's nipple. A triumphant fanfare sounded in her mind as she glowed in the reverence that she was feeling up *Catra.*

"Oh, come on, you can do better than that, Princess. I'm not made of glass; make it hurt a little." In truth the whispers of touch felt amazing, but things really had been so gooey and heartfelt between them lately. It was time for action and Catra was more than ready.

Adora placed her entire hand against Catra's tit, kneading it forcefully. Catra keened in response to the motion, her head thrown back as a loud moan sounded through the room. It was the best sound Adora had ever heard in her life.

She felt the nipple grow rock hard under her and pinched it between her thumb and forefinger. Catra gave a yelp, but met Adora's mouth with a biting kiss in appreciation. She again tried to grind herself against Adora's leg but it was still stationary between her. "Why are you doing this to me…" Catra's voice was back to a whine.

"Doing? Why, Catra, I'm not doing anything…" Adora was way too focused on teasing the stiff peak between her fingers to pay much mind to what the rest of her body was doing or not doing.

That's the fucking problem! Catra inwardly screamed, unable to tell if the blonde was a complete idiot or a total tease. Either way,

she decided a new tactic needed to be employed to get what she wanted. Catra kissed her deeply, running her hands down Adora's ripped arms. That alone was almost enough to push her over; god, Adora was so fucking hot. She grabbed the blonde's hand and slipped it over top her shorts and between her legs, so grateful when Adora got the hint and eased up her leg some to allow access. "Please, baby. I need you so bad." Her voice was sweet and imploring. Far more genuinely vulnerable than she meant to be but, given the moment...

Adora moaned deeply at the contact beneath her hand. She swallowed thickly and willed her brain to stay focused at this new development. "Shorts on or off?" She just managed to choke the words out, so caught up in the sensation of Catra's wet core against her palm, the fabric doing little to block the sensation to Adora's delight.

"Off, now." Sweet didn't last long with Catra, but she was impressed with herself when she didn't add 'idiot' at the end.

Adora begrudgingly moved her hand, unwilling to remain gone for long, then raised up in a plank position to allow the woman below her to remove any clothing that covered the prize Adora was just waiting to receive. Just as Catra's hands went to shimmy herself out of bottoms, Adora was struck. "Wait! Stop, I want to do it." Catra groaned; it was difficult to say if it was in erotic frustration at Adora wanting to be the one to strip her or supreme irritation at the further delay.

Adora sat up to the side and put her hands back on Catra's hips, fingers flicking under the waistband of her sleepwear and to begin gently rolling them down. She paused again, just when jutting hip

bones were fully visible, instantly caught up in the sight and removed her hands from their task. She suddenly wanted to see *all* of Catra; every last inch of her needed to be revealed. Adora tugged at her shirt and halted again, consumed with the idea of ripping it off her but that was just more undiscussed boundaries.

"I swear, Adora, if you don't do something… Or did you forget that your girlfriend needs fucked?" Catra growled at the paused blonde woman, instantly a little afraid at her word choice, only because Adora could be derailed so quickly. *'Fuck me' and 'girlfriend' in the same sentence? Please, I'll never ask for anything again in my life, just keep her on track and let her take me already.* Her desire had only cooled marginally with this unwelcomed break; she was certain she would only last minutes if Adora could just get on with it already.

Adora yanked Catra's top off. *Girlfriend? Later, later.* She took in the sight below her; Catra topless, flushed and panting, her breasts beckoning Adora's hands and mouth towards them. She was practically drooling over the sight, completely lost to the moment.

Catra roughly took Adora's jaw in her hand and jerked it up so they were eye to eye. "I swear I will let you look all you want, after. I will walk around this house completely naked, solely for your enjoyment, for the entire time we are here. You can absolutely worship me later; I will love it. But first, you need to get your fingers on me *now* ." Maybe that was a bit much; Catra could apologize later. She wasn't trying to ruin their first time with her impatience, but this was just agony at this point. *I will strip for her any time of day if she just would please, please finally follow through.*

Adora nodded, wisely choosing to stay silent and focus at the task on hand. In quick order shorts and underwear joined the shirt on the floor. Adora took a second to stare at her now completely exposed girlfriend, eyes blown wide and her arousal a towering inferno, before returning to her position over top the other woman. She reached a hand underneath them and let her fingers slide against Catra. Her vision went white for a split second, as her senses took in the wet, hot heat that slipped so wonderfully between her fingers.

That first long awaited touch was almost enough for Catra. Immediately she was as coiled as it had been before Adora decided to get creative. This time though, she would ensure there would be no detours or delays. Catra was going to give encouragement and if need be, instructions. Adora lived for instruction. "I'm so wet for you." She placed a deep, but loving kiss on Adora's mouth. "Your fingers feel so fucking good… You're so good, babe. Just a little faster."

Praise and direction. *Oh, thank goodness, because I have no idea what I'm doing.* Adora was fortified by her words; she increased the tempo at which her hands stroked into Catra's folds. She felt a small bump and instantly Catra's claws slid out into a slicing grip against the mattress next to them. "There, yes, there! Baby, you're going to make me come like that."

"I want you to come." Adora bit her tongue with the effort it took to speak. Her concentration was fully going into touching Catra in just the same way, same spot.

“Mmmm, don’t stop. Oh, your fingers feel so good on my clit. Harder!”

Adora increased her application, wanting nothing more than to get the other woman there. She took a moment, just a brief glance to look down where her fingers were busy. The sight was enough to make her rub her partner even faster and harder against her hand. Seeing her hand so splayed and working against Catra’s drenched self was galvanizing; words poured out of her mouth. “You’re so sexy. You feel so good against my hand.” She kissed her hard, the woman’s moans of pleasure echoing deep into her mouth.

“I’m so close. Don’t stop!”

“Mmm, I don’t plan on it, not until you come.” Forearm burning in the most delicious way as it sought to bring her lover over the edge, Adora brought her mouth close to Catra’s sensitive ear and barely breathed out. “Come for me, sexy. You’re *mine* .”

That was it; the tipping point to make the wave crash over her finally. Adora’s fingers were hitting that spot so perfectly, and her possessive words whispered so sultry in her ear were more than enough to break her. Catra gave a deep, guttural moan that turned into a full bodied wail as her body seized tight then shook. She could feel the muscle of her thighs quaking as she rocked herself harder into Adora’s hand, riding out each shockwave of pure pleasure that coursed over her. Adora followed the rhythm of her hips, letting them be her guide through Catra’s release. Soon they both slowed to a stop, Adora’s hand still over her center but not applying any kind of pressure, just resting. Both women lay

there trying to catch their breath, sharing a tranquil moment of afterglow.

Adora placed a gentle kiss on Catra's forehead. "I love you so much, Catra."

"Love you too." Words were almost impossible for Catra right now, but no way she could not reciprocate that right now.

"Was that... was that okay?" Adora's voice was so small and frail. She could tell Catra was spent, but for their future, she would need to hear any notes for improvement. Plus, her anxiety was not going to let her relax any time soon without it.

Catra shut her eyes. Like she could really pull together sentences right now, let alone give a performance review. But she also felt a little guilty at the impudence she'd displayed when Adora had just been trying to take in the sights, so to speak, so definitely she needed to make it up to the gorgeous woman who just wanted to take care of her. Even though her body felt heavy with fatigue, but also oh so satisfied, she kissed Adora soundly and sweetly. "It was perfect. You're perfect."

Adora flushed with pride and returned the kiss, even deepening it as she felt so caught up in her love for this riveting, ravishing woman.

“I’m not saying I’m not all for it, but if you hand stays there any longer and we keep kissing like that, it’s going to be Round Two for me real soon.” Catra was feeling a little more alive after a short break and chuckled at her own wit. It paid to be naturally so dexterous. “And I’ve got a few things in mind for you before my next bout.”

“Oh! Right, of course.” Adora removed her hand a little glumly, having grown used to the slippery and enticing feel against her hand. She regarded her drenched fingers carefully, half-wondering what to do with them, before inspiration overtook her. She placed them into her mouth, gently sucking any essence of Catra off them, nearly on a new plane of existence with the taste. *Oh, I need more of that. Soon* .

Catra watched the whole thing wide-eyed with fascination, before throwing her head back against the bed with a loud groan. “Hope you weren’t planning on doing anything today, babe, because things like that are going to keep us in bed all fucking day.”

“Don’t you mean fucking in bed all day?” She gave a warm, seductive giggle before laying her head down against Catra’s chest to snuggle. Though her own desire was still strong, a moment’s reprieve with the love of her life was more than welcomed. “That’s the mission, isn’t it?”



Chapter End Notes

TL;DR

Adora's a top & doesn't know what to do with that. Just talk to your girl, baby love, she'll help you get there.

Catra's a bratty bottom, but will crumble in a instant over Adora.

Update: Now contains art by @ForceCaptSerena, one of my absolute favorite artists. The piece is so beautiful.

Worship

Chapter Notes

> Y'all are making my LIFE. Approaching 4700 hits and 300 kudos? I just can't even thank you enough. Actually, here's some body worship and Adora finally really getting over her fear as my way of saying thanks. Enjoy!
>
> P.S.- lengthy notes at the end, probably mostly just excited prattle. But answer my poll for the future of this story? Please? Thank you!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Fucking in bed all day? Why, Adora. Such profane language from you!" Catra laid a mocking hand over her chest. As if her favorite word would ever actually affront her in any way.

"Look who's talking, Miss 'Your fingers feel so good on my clit.'" Adora raised off Catra to give her a smug look before flopping back against the bed, lost in the very recent but also very palpable recollection of those words being cried out for her.

"Mmm, it's not profanity if it's the absolute damned truth." Catra rolled on her side to be able to watch the blonde better. She lifted Adora's closest hand to her and gently began kissing her fingertips. She could taste and smell a ghost of herself on them; it made her flush with pride and a sense of being *possessed* by her. The thought was more than a little exciting. She'd gotten a glimpse of a take-charge Adora and wanted more of that in the future. "Such perfect fingers that know how to get me off just right…" She let a small flick of her tongue roll against the longest finger punctuate her sentence, before she brought it into her mouth to suck on it.

Adora watched in fascination, her breathing growing faster and more labored as she languished in the feel of Catra's warm, somewhat rough tongue lapping over her finger. She knew that the moans of frustration that sounded in the room were all from her- but she also really didn't care. It just felt so good. And it was so, so hot. *And this is only my finger...*

Not wanting to miss a single second of this moment, her eyes wandered over the entire scene. Catra was happily licking and teasing, having just taken a second digit into her mouth. As if that wasn't enough, Adora registered she currently had visuals on a still very naked Catra. Her eyes roamed over every inch of bare flesh in front of her. The small, pert breasts that were begging to be under Adora's hands. Her flat, toned stomach that faded into pointed hips. And of course the apex of her legs, that lightly furred center of her pleasure. She saw that area that had just been worked over by her fingers so thoroughly… Her stomach clenched tightly as subconsciously she brought her thighs together to allow herself some pressure against the heat there.

The movement did not escape Catra's notice. She let Adora's fingers slide out of her mouth with an audible pop, then regarded her with a heavy-lidded gaze. "Like what you see?"

Adora nodded dumbly, hand fluttering weakly down to the mattress as it left Catra's oral teasing, not looking away from her exposed form for a second. She was drinking it all in.

Catra gave a low, throaty chuckle. "Just as you declared, it's yours. I'm yours." *She could probably close me with one touch by*

saying that again, just like she did.

Adora still could not take her eyes off Catra; it made her feel ecstatic to know she held Adora's full, undivided attention. Catra gave her a knowing smile, licking her lips eagerly. She had her head in her hand and that was propped up by her elbow, as they lay side by side. She returned an appreciative observation of Adora's form. *Wait a minute here, how does she still have all her clothes on? First things first, that needs to change.*

Adora watched wide-eyed as the vision she was examining so carefully slid from next to her to over top of her, very much in the same way as any number of times Catra had pounced on the blonde. Except this time it was a slow, sensual roll up Adora's body, to show off every flex of her muscles, every curve of her form, as well as give her a completely uninhibited view of a very private area below her abdomen. Adora gulped, held captive by the desire the merciless woman coaxed within her.

"Hey, Adora. My, my isn't this a familiar position." She purposefully kept her hips up and away from the other woman's body so her view wasn't blocked in any way. Plus, she felt a quick check-in might be warranted before any direct contact was made. If Adora hadn't even ever taken herself... it certainly wouldn't hurt to do so. "But also a bit different this time around, wouldn't you agree?"

Another mute nod and thick swallow was her only response. *I broke her.* The thought really shouldn't probably make Catra crow in delight as it did. "I'm really very interested in exploring some of these differences further with you. Specifically, if I touch, taste, and finish you. But also want to make sure you're ready for that? I know this will be your first time experiencing it for yourself at all…

And I'm just guessing for right now, but receiving is probably different than giving." *Emphasis on 'right now'; please, please, please I want her so bad.*

She figured very clear, open intent with Adora was the best way. She wouldn't give away all her secrets right away, but Catra was perceptive enough to recognize this would not be the same rough grinding and frantic fingering that went into her experience. For one, Catra definitely had a better hold on herself now after finally getting the relief that eluded her since last night. Two, it was both their first time but it was Adora's First Time. She wanted to be attentive and indulgent, because this was her Adora whom she loved so dearly that was trusting her with this new shared experience. She also needed to be skilled and filthy enough to finish her with a mind-bending, life-changing explosion that left her crying out Catra's name again and again. She really hoped she would be able to deliver on these juxtapositions, particularly the second… Her ear flicked once in silent contemplation of that slightly unnerving thought.

Adora came back to herself long enough to really consider the words. *Stars, she just gets me.* She loved when her and Catra were so in sync; because in truth, behind the ache for release she was currently experiencing, there was some… shyness? That was probably the closest word to it. Not fear or apprehension and she definitely wanted to move forward with things. She just had no frame of reference on a personal level; had no idea what to expect. It was all totally new and if she spent too long thinking about it…

She had made the conscious decision to break the toxic patterns of her life at the beginning of this; getting stuck in her own head to her own detriment would definitely be one to lose. Adora

answered before that shyness could turn to groundless anxiety and eventual freak-out. "I… am. Yes."

"Mmm, I'm so glad to hear that." Catra sat up from her pounce position, slotting her bare core over top Adora's still clothed one. Straddling her fully, Catra very lightly rolled her hips down, barely a whisper more of pressure but Adora reflexively jerked her hips in response, a cry escaping her lips. "Don't worry, baby, I've spent *years* thinking about this." She leaned forward, allowing her tits to rub gently over Adora's through her shirt, and brought them in for a deep kiss. "I'll take care of you."

The pair kissed for several minutes, slower and less frantic than they had at the beginning of Catra's adventure. It wasn't any less, however; in fact, how they languished against one another was far more intimate and tempting. Instead of an out of control wildfire, Adora was experiencing a well-tended, massive bonfire. A fire she knew Catra would build and maintain; it was provocative warmth and suggestive goodness. The thought made her relax; the shyness eased away as she was reminded in the tactile manner of her kiss that she was with Catra. Her safety. Her home.

"Adora, I want your shirt off. I know I was a little… impatient with you earlier when it was my shirt being removed, but I think you'll agree that I've more than made up for it." She gave a teasing gesture to her displayed body. "And the simple fact is your tits are just so much better; I know that even when I've never gotten a chance to *really* look. Quick peeks after showers and while you changed back in the Horde just really weren't enough."

Adora snorted. *More like they're incredibly inconvenient and generally annoying.* "Speak for yourself. I've definitely been enjoying yours- now and then."

"I know and I was just so mean to you the first time you got to see them up close." Adora couldn't decipher if her tone was mocking or not. She decided she didn't care when Catra lifted her hand and placed it against her breast, encouraging Adora to knead as she continued to speak, little breathless cries periodically punctuating her words at the touch. She wanted Adora to be as relaxed as possible, to know that Catra wanted nothing more than to have Adora's hands on her, so they could touch her and bring her to the throes of absolute pleasure. Because Catra also knew that the possibility for spiraling would be very high after she finished explaining; though she also had to, for their sake. "I'm sorry for that, really. But I will keep my promise; naked Catra any time you want. This doesn't excuse anything, but I had just been so close when you were grinding against me like that, a minute more and I would have absolutely unraveled. I'm only telling you so you don't think I'm an absolute bitch who tried to rush through your first time with me when I intend to absolutely *worship* you…"

"Oh, you had been just about to…" Adora's eyes grew wide with horror and her hand dropped instantly from Catra's chest. She even dimly recalled Catra moaning out to her after she had halted that she had been 'so close', which really should have been the focal point of that verbal exchange. But typical, oblivious Adora she had completely missed it. "And then I kinda stopped things... Oh, my god I'm such an idiot! I knew I'd screw this up!"

So much for preventing a spiral… "Adora, baby, love." Catra placed her hand against Adora's cheek, running her thumb along her jawline. She pressed a kiss to the top of her forehead, down the

bridge of her nose, then on its tip, finally over both cheeks before settling on her lips. Adora still looked a little aghast at herself, but the sweet kisses filled the worst of it. "It's completely okay; the only thing that was screwed here was me. And that's kind of the point. You couldn't have possibly known I was about to come; it's not like you'd ever heard or seen it before. I also gave you zero verbal indication of what was going on with me, which is one hundred percent on me. We're still learning each other like this. And babe, you more than made up for it. I came *so hard* when you were working my clit like that. *You* made me come like that. And I know you're going to do it again and again and again…" She brought their mouths together again in a soft kiss to really drive home her point that everything was okay.

"Yeah?" Adora was mollified at the assurances, more or less. Enough at least. She knew Catra had enjoyed herself under her hand; she settled that this would be an opportunity for improvement. She would learn. She would impress. *Can you be the best at sex? Life goal, right there.*

"Mmm, yes baby, you made me feel so good. I can't wait until we do it all again, until you take me again, but first I'd really like to have you. Which brings us right back to the fact that you are wearing far too many clothes right now." Like Catra was going to let the conversation derail any more. Yes, it was important to have these moments of communication and care, but she was still a woman on a mission."Strip for me, Adora. Top first."

Adora gave a somewhat sheepish smile, but also thrilled at the commanding tone. Directions just worked for her. She brought her tanktop up her torso, perhaps a mite bit leisurely, and let it join the ever-growing pile on the floor.

Catra wondered if the blonde had been intentionally moving so slow and languorously; not that she was really complaining at being able to take in each stretch of skin as slowly as possible. She wasn't exaggerating about the reverence she wanted to show to her girlfriend and her resplendent body. Adora could give her a show any time, especially if it ended like *this* .

The sight of her topless girlfriend was more breathtaking than Catra had ever imagined in her deepest, most feral fantasies. If the small swatch of stomach she'd been granted earlier was heaven, this was impeccable nirvana. Her stomach was *ripped* . Catra's own may have been lean and toned but Adora's just screamed "I work out 23 hours a day" and "My other persona is a Warrior Goddess". It was something Catra had been anticipating and bracing herself for. But now that it was right there in front of her- looking like *that* , she knew no amount of preparation would ever prevent the short-circuiting of her brain's ability to function and reason.

She audibly, pathetically mewled at the sight.

Adora gave a rough, husky chuckle from deep in her throat. Every part of her felt thick with desire under Catra's gaze. But then that pathetic and utterly endearing whimper at what just really amounted to her stomach? She hadn't even taken a single peek at the tits that were supposedly so much better than her own! "Nothing you haven't seen before, like, an hour ago." An hour, three hours, last year; who knew the actual timeline. Affection and playfulness colored her tone, though in truth, the whole situation just made her want Catra even more. *My goodness, the*

littlest bit of skin and she comes undone. My big, mean girlfriend.

Catra just shook her head, still transfixed. "More now. S'not the same." Her voice was thick; utterly wrecked. Normally she would be appalled at her lack of verbal eloquence. Now she just wondered why her tongue was being used for the mundane task of speaking when *Adora's abs* were right there, begging to be kissed, licked, and rolled under her mouth.

"Oh, really? Why don't you show me how it's different?"

The heavens themselves opened up in angelic chorus at Adora's-admittedly teasing, but also blessed invitation. Catra was fully focused on that impressively muscular stomach as she bent down to run her tongue over every sleek dip, every hard plane, and every defined bulge that so graced her sight. She used broad, long strokes that merited deep moans from the receiver. She used short kissing jabs with her lips and tongue working in tandem that prompted staccato gasps and cries in reply. And the pièce de résistance for both parties was when she dragged a single fang down a particularly developed section of her physique. *I want to ride these muscles; fuck myself against them until I come all over her.*

The second Catra's tongue met her body, Adora felt every muscle in her stomach clench instantly in response, every nerve ending on her body fired at once. It was the best kind of sensual torture; a near overwhelming, relentless onslaught that immediately hardened her nipples and left her feeling *drenched* . She was gasping for breath. Her hips were jerking of their own accord, seeking contact with anything that could possibly end the

torturous need in her. And then that sharp point of a fang dragged down her six pack, not hard enough to break skin but definitely enough to really *feel* it, she cried out. "Catra!"

Catra exalted; absolutely lived in the fact that Adora was already calling out her name. Emboldened, she lowered her mouth to the waistband of Adora's shorts, a devilish smirk on her lips when she heard Adora's breath hitch and hold from the close contact of her mouth to the peak of her lap. Catra looked up at the already ruined face and they held eye contact as she ran her tongue from navel to sternum at an excruciatingly slow pace. Once finished with her tantalizing caress, she turned her attention to the succulent tits that were on display, just for her. Adora's breath was ragged, gulping pants through her slightly ajar mouth. Her eyes were wrenched shut tight and eyebrows drawn together in a sharp crease. And damn if that didn't make the sight even hotter. *She is wrecked for me.*

Catra sat up only high enough to get the best possible angle for her next move. Steeling herself against the tremble in her fingers, like *hell* she was going to show any nervousness in what would be a crowning moment of her life, she took Adora's ample breast into her hand. Adora moaned at the contact, face losing its tension, morphing into an almost surprised though exceedingly pleased visage.

How can everything she does just feel so different but so damn good? If the foray across her abdomen was a beautiful concert orchestrated by Catra's expert mouth, this erotic massage of her breasts was a lingering crescendo. The first grasp led to a gentle but firm rolling motion that was just smooth pleasure. That motion shifted into a more steady squeeze, revealing the insistence of the motion. Finally when Adora's back was arching

off the bed in a way so reminiscent of how this whole journey began, Catra let her mouth close over one hardened peak, rolling and sucking as she had with Adora's fingers. She lightly ran a single claw point over the other, hoping to draw out the highly contrasting sensations.

"C-Catra! I need…" Adora didn't know what she needed. More? Less? Everything and nothing at all?

Catra left where her mouth had been eagerly teasing only long enough to inquire. "What do you need, Princess?" While waiting for her reply, she moved away from her nipple, towards the top of her tit and began to lick and suck at the skin- hard. She was determined to leave a mark, to show she had been here and remind Adora of that fact later.

Words were impossible with the sweet stings Catra was currently painting on her chest. It hurt, but in a way that only made her crave more. "You!" It seemed like the most comprehensive answer she could come up with. Besides, it had worked for her earlier this morning. She needed more of whatever Catra was able to give to her.

"Are you feeling hot for me?" Catra breathed out against Adora's chest, right over the spot that was already bruising from her earlier ministrations but was no longer touching her any more than what their current position deemed necessary.

For Adora, there was just the delicious lingering nips of pain, the echoes of nerves still firing from Catra's tongue razing her

abdomen just moments before and now Catra's hot, tantalizing breath hovering just right above her skin. Adora could only moan in response to the ridiculously obvious question. She feebly tried to bury her hands into Catra's short mane to urge her for more contact, to finally put her out of this agony, but they only made it as far as her sides before they fell there pathetically.

"Poor little Adora. Always crumbling under the Big Bad. No wonder I was always winning back then…" It was inconsiderate stupidity to bring insinuations of their shared history into the bedroom but Catra was always one to push. "Maybe we should stop, since you seem too weak to go on." She was feeling cocky and at the top of her game; expecting Adora to roll over and just take it given the state she was in. Beg Catra to please, please fuck her. It was pure arrogant bravado born from that part of her that secretly wanted to see Adora crumble- though this time, crumble for her. Besides, they both knew that it was also completely false; Catra barely won ever. Teasing Adora just came as naturally to her as anything. She once again knew she would have to apologize later but-...

Whether it was from the pent-up sexual frustration she was feeling or just from the condescending, almost too raw taunts... something broke within Adora. She immediately latched onto the back of Catra's head, fingers laced tightly into the wispy curls there to pull her back away from her chest so they could meet face to face. Adora's steel-blue eyes were hard, cold, commanding. They left no room for argument. While it certainly wasn't the hardest hit she had ever inflicted on Catra, the motion was not gentle. "You need to stop *now* . And get on with it."

Catra's eyes were wide in shock at underestimating Adora's potential towards aggressive reaction. *Oh, sweet merciful fuck that so does it for me.* She gave a small nod of her head, for once

in her life being a good girl who did not open her mouth to argue further. Adora released her grip, running her fingers in a soothing gesture over where it had raked into the woman's hair then settled her head back to wait in curt anticipation for Catra to follow command.

Shaking off her stun, Catra became a coquettish kitten. She slotted herself between Adora's thighs and waited for a little nod of affirmation from the blonde, before her hand cupped over Adora's center entirely. Deftly she began to make small circular motions against it. The heat and wetness she could feel under her hand even through Adora's shorts was almost enough to make her topple over the edge again. *You are rubbing Adora's pussy right now, after being handled a little roughly and fucked by her. This is it; the pinnacle of your life has been reached.* "I want you, Adora. So bad. And you wanna give me what I want, right?" Maybe this was pushing a little more, but when had Adora ever not responded well to giving?

"Always." Adora could barely focus on the words as Catra's hands passed under her bottoms, sliding them down to around her knees at an achingly slow pace. They were thrown haphazardly away, landing who knows where.

Catra eyed her handiwork; the fully naked, golden, irresistible woman splayed out before her. *I'm about to go to the happiest place in the world* . She was a little giddy, but quickly composed herself. She drew her claws back as far as they could possibly go and looked Adora in the eyes, both sets impossibly wide.

Catra slid her fingers amongst the blonde curls, both parties moaning in tandem at the contact. She was near overwhelmed at

the sensation; the only scent she could register was Adora's, more pungent and intoxicating than ever. Her moves were gentle, exploratory; they had plenty of time and Catra did not want to rush a single second, for herself or Adora. She took in the feel of each fold, purposefully avoiding her clit, which even at this slight distance she could feel was literally throbbing with need. *Best damn compliment I've ever gotten.*

Each slick ridge against the pads of her fingertips was driving her absolutely wild with the insistence to go harder, faster, and deeper... but Catra did not give into the direction her body was trying to push her. No way she was going to sprint through this; this was her moment and she wanted Adora to be worked into an absolute frenzy first. "Mmm, Catra. More."

That's a good start. A little more could be given, Catra reasoned. She quickened her movements, destination clear. It was a graze, a bare whisper, the most minute brush over that highly sensitive, aching bundle of nerves. Adora literally shook in response and gripped her hands into the sheets tightly.

Catra returned to the survey away from the spot, though to Adora's mercy and consternation, increased the pressure and speed somewhat. *Can't say I'm not benevolent.* Adora's hips began to move against her still far too gentle flicks, trying to wordlessly convey her needs. She was certain Catra understood perfectly, but obviously was not ready to acquiesce to her desires. "More."

More force was applied, the pace again upped. A stronger press to her clit, though still so unmercifully short. Adora bit her lip, a growl just waiting to escape the back of her throat. She may not

have had any past experience with this, but it was really very obvious what part of her was begging for contact. The teasing woman was going to *pay* for this later. “Catra! More, now!”

Close enough. She reached the source of Adora's throbbing, two of Catra’s fingers slid on either side of the bundle, rocking it gently between them. Adora made a sound unlike any other she had before; her body was instantly rigid. Catra allowed her to get used to the feeling before ramping up the pace, positioning her fingers in a slightly different pattern to try and draw out even more pleasure for her. “Like before.” Catra instantly returned to the two-fingered rocking motion, filing that away for future use. She was graced with another deep moan and cry of her name for her efforts.

It was everything Catra could have hoped for; her fingers sliding against Adora’s clit, as Adora cried out in gasping breaths beneath her, rocking her hips against her hand hard. Even though Catra was the one touching her, it almost felt like Adora was just fucking her hand, just using it to take what she wanted from Catra. The distinction was starting to be more than Catra could bear; despite all her restraint, she could feel her claws desperately wanting to stretch out. They had always betrayed her most powerful feelings-physical and emotional. And Catra was experiencing quite a lot of both those currently.

Before this scene could turn grisly in any way, shape, or form Catra abruptly removed her hand despite Adora’s shrill whine of protest at the absence. Catra was working to regain control of herself, digging her claws into the bedding beside them and trying to figure out her next move. *Apparently need to work on my self-control later. Or invest in a file.*

This really had never factored into any of her plans; of course, in her fantasies she was always one hundred percent put together, able to bring Adora into a crumbling orgasm within minutes. Reality was such a cruel bitch. She was still trying to get a hold of herself when she caught movement out of the corner of her eye.

Catra made a strangled cry at the sight; it was jarring to see the single hottest thing of her life, Adora's own fingers working her clit madly and yet be filled with such dread at it. "Oh, no you don't!" She roughly pulled her hand away and stared a whining Adora down. "You're not taking this away from me."

"Then w-why did you stop?" Adora's face was scrunched into a mask of near agony, licking her lips before biting down hard on her bottom one. Catra watched Adora's tongue flit across her lips and privately cursed at herself for being so incredibly dense.

"Trust me, princess, this is going to be so much better…" No longer struck with Utter Stupidity just because a few unforeseen factors had come into play, Catra brought herself down to the floor at the edge of the bed, pulling at Adora's legs as she went. The other woman was still whining slightly, but quieted and did not resist against being repositioned since it was now apparent *something* was about to happen.

This time there was no exploring, no teasing, and no desire to take it slow. Catra launched her mouth against Adora's clit, working it against her tongue, trying to mimic a similar rolling motion that Adora seemed to like so much before her damn fingers had betrayed her so horrendously. She barely even took

the time to really savor the taste, though it was impossible to not be in ecstasy as it rolled through her mouth and overwhelmed her senses. Catra was just so intent on making sure she was the one who gave Adora her first orgasm. It was probably a stupid point of pride; might not even happen, really shouldn't be the focus as if sex were some kind of game that could be won and orgasms were the way to keep score, but damn it if she wasn't going to give it her all anyway. Pride was kind of a thing with Catra.

"C-Catra!" Instantly fingers clawed into her mane, pushing her face even deeper into Adora's slit. She still worked her tongue hard against her, only briefly lamenting the decreased ease at which she could breathe from the force at which Adora was pressing her face into her pussy. *If I die here, I regret nothing.* After one particularly sharp swipe of her tongue, she began to suck her clit instead, which caused Adora to fully lift her top half from the bed and absolutely *keen* out her pleasure. Catra reached a hand up to her own, which had dropped from her head at the new sensation, and linked their fingers together.

Catra continued to eat her out; she licked and sucked the other woman mercilessly, not deviating or experimenting when she found something that worked. Adora had one hand completely tangled up into the sheets and bedding, the other locked with Catra's in a near-crushing grip, while continuous, generally incoherent cries came streaming from her mouth. They were mostly centered around the word 'Catra' much to the name-holder's absolute delight.

She plunged on, ignoring the ache in her jaw, letting the taste and scent that was just *Adora* fortify her so she could finally finish the woman she loved so much. She could tell, though had no idea if Adora could as well, that she had to be so close. Adora's thighs

were bunching tight around Catra's ears, her breaths were nothing more than desperate, panting gasps, and her hips were gyrating her pelvis roughly into Catra's mouth, making her take it. Catra received willingly.

Before much longer, Catra assumptions were proven correct when she felt Adora's clit quiver and spasm in her mouth. She slowed her motions to work Adora through it, trying to let her mouth be more a presence than a force, lapping lightly to hopefully heighten the experience for her. The rest of Adora clenched and then released; her back again arching off the bed. Catra was fairly certain she heard cloth ripping as Adora tore the sheets under her. After her string of gasps and noises earlier, Catra was somewhat surprised when they devolve into one soft "Fuck…" as she came. She felt Adora go slack against her and removed her mouth, but not before she gave this beautiful part of her girlfriend's anatomy a light kiss first. Adora twitched in response, with a low and destroyed groan at the contact.

Catra ran her tongue over the sides of her mouth, trying to take in every bit of Adora that still resided there. Almost regretfully, she wiped at her mouth with her arm but was satisfied at knowing the scent would linger there instead. She moved up from the floor, pleased at the dull ache in her knees, to join Adora on the bed. *I will get on my knees for you anytime, Princess.*

Adora still was still hanging off the bed, so exhausted by the experience that moving was just simply not an option at this time. Catra chuckled warmly and did her best to help her love in a more comfortable position. Once situated, Catra began to run her fingers through blonde locks, a purr rumbling loudly in her chest. Adora smiled at the soothing contact through her hair, eyes barely able to stay open.

How long they spent like this, Catra playing with her hair and purring with such careless, happy abandon, Adora couldn't say. She was feeling so elated and sublimely exhausted. Every muscle in her body ached in a deep rooted way; it was as if each section of her body was coming back to life in tiny shifts. She might be able to wiggle her left pinky at this point, maybe flex a toe or two. Much more than that seemed to be an impossibility, but she also couldn't deny that she also felt pretty fucking fantastic. Intellectually, she had known that coming felt good; that was pretty obvious even for her. But now that she felt it for herself… Staying in bed to fuck all day sure as hell wasn't just sexy banter at this point. She had a taste and wanted more, more, more.

But first, her body still needed some time to recover. She was fairly sure she had just gained control of her wrist again, maybe could twist her head if her life really depended on it. Really, it seemed like getting some more of that sleep she had wanted at the outset of this beautiful adventure was her best bet. But her mind was ever awake, wanting nothing more to hear the voice of her beautiful love. She decided to try to use her vocal cords, since it seemed like her neck had been reanimated. "What was your favorite part?" *Hah, can't stop me for long!*

The hand petting through her hair paused. "My favorite part… of having sex with you?"

"... Yes?" She was still coming out of her post-orgasm reverie, but it had seemed like a perfectly reasonable question in her head. Where was the confusion?

Catra's responding laugh held no scorn, only limitless warmth and total attachment. "You absolute goof. How am I supposed to pick one thing out of the most exhilarating, passionate experience of my life? Everything was so good, 'Dor." She placed a kiss on her brow, feeling so much affection for her big, dumb love.

"I dunno; I think mine was…" Her sentence was cut off with a loud rumble from her stomach. *Guess that's awake now.* She blushed bright red and smiled bashfully. "Um, heh, that did take a lot out of me. Sorry; guess I'm hungry."

"C'mon, you absolute loon. Lemme go make you some breakfast." Another sweet kiss across her brow, followed by a tight squeeze. "Can you walk yet?"

An impish half-smile was fixated over top Adora's line of sight, but honestly, it was a damn good question. "You know, there is a distinct possibility I won't be able to yet. Mind blowing orgasms from your sexy girlfriend can do that to ya."

"... I would say this was all a ploy to get breakfast in bed, but damn if stroking my ego isn't the way to go about it." Catra nearly glowed in pride at Adora's words. "You stay here, recover, and I'll just keep on taking care of you."

"Hmmm, pretty sure that's the plan even after breakfast. Also think I'll be stroking a few other things of yours before long…"

“I do love how cheeky sex makes you; your quips are really just on fire. Speaking of on fire, better get to cooking.”

Adora flashed her a dazzling smile. “And think about your favorite part while you do!”

I’ve said it before and I’ll say it again: She must never know the power she has. Catra gave her one last kiss before going downstairs to practice at domestic tranquility. There were worse ways to spend a day.

Chapter End Notes

Catra's got a muscle kink, Catra's got a muscle kink!

Woo, buddy, I could give extensive notes about this one. I am hoping I am setting the stage nicely for the girls to really explore their kinks later and doing it in more or less believable, organic fashion. I think it's a safe assumption that Catra would be way more in tune with such matters, but if that bratty bottom keeps it up, Adora's really going to let loose with some of hers.

The claw scene... Please let me know if that moment of humor didn't flow. I've got thoughts on that particular subject and plans to work around it in the future but if it kind of took y'all out of the moment a bit, I've got an alternate version sketched out. Personally, I love awkward moments in sex and figured Catra needed her own oh shit what now moment. But feedback is always welcomed!

Speaking of exploring future kinks... I started this fic with the idea of doing a pretty true to canon character study/development piece that would absolutely end with them gettin' it on because reasons. Technically, this has been achieved. I've had the bones of the ending written since like... chapter two? So I know where I want to end up, could probably pull it together in one or two more chapters, but

also I'm having fun and I think a few other people out there are as well.

I wouldn't mind churning out more for you all, but to be dead honest, I don't have a major plot any more (at this point- who knows what might come out in the writing process). It honestly would probably be fluffy moments- if you've read my other piece, Her, you know I love me my fluff (would not anticipate this getting nearly as silly, however), along with some hopefully alluring smut. When I'm reading a fic myelf, I prefer it when you get some time to see the girls just be happy and in love for a while. Breaks my heart when it's like "And they're together, byeeeee"; you just dragged me through hell for 10-30 chapters of slow-burn hell, give me some happy chemicals, dammit! I heavily digress.

What are your thoughts on the matter? Think you can stomach some romantic antics and sapphic-lovin' scenes with little or no actual plot to back it up? Let me know!

Domestic

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had made many grievous mistakes in her life. But this… this was in a league all its own.

Why she had ever thought she would be able to make breakfast, hell *any* meal, was beyond her. *I must have gone insane from post-sex chemicals.* Hardened eyes swept the kitchen area, as if daring it to reveal its secrets to her or to face the consequences of remaining silent. Her experience with food up until recently had been bar-shaped and ugly; even in her time outside of the Horde, food was just provided and she ate. Some things were better than others; some things she would never touch again even in the face of starvation. *Leaves. Who the hell eats leaves?* End of story, really.

It was Adora who worshipped food. Begrudgingly, she realized that was likely the main factor that led to this disastrous decision; of course it would be making her Adora happy. Every other bad decision Catra had made had her at the root; why wouldn't this one?

Her mind flipped through the various types of sustenance she'd imbibed in recently and tried to recall the names. It felt as though if she could name the thing, she would gain power over it. The aforementioned leaves would never be permissible as an option. You could give it a fancy name like salad; mix it together with as

many other crunchy, bitter things as you wanted, but it still amounted to just a bowl of foliage. Basic survival training taught her not to eat random leaves from the forest and Catra wasn't about to ignore her training or her taste buds.

Salted fish was one she actually liked; a small part of her warmed at the idea that Sparkles had remembered that enough to include it in last night's dinner basket. But that felt neither breakfast appropriate nor did she really have any urge to go fishing. Catra glanced down at her still unclothed self. *Especially considering the new dress code.*

She tried instead to think of the things that Adora liked, but of course, the answer to that was everything. Adora was on an entirely different plane when it came to eating. Still, Catra had to concede that she knew cake held a special place in her love's heart; possibly one she could never hope to live up to. She recalled the way Adora had paid homage to the slice on her plate during the Victory Feast the first night after the Heart. She had drank it in lovingly, admiring it in a way shockingly similiar to the way Catra herself had just worshipped Adora's body (*Oh, don't tell me food is going to be a sex thing…)* before devouring it so quickly it made Catra faintly ill to behold. But that cake had looked exceedingly complicated; layers of cake… stuff? with that smooth, ridiculously sweet cream in between each layer and surrounding the whole damn thing. Just looking at it had made Catra's teeth hurt, but Adora ate her own, most of Catra's piece and even considered a third piece before declining with the comment that now that they had won, she could have cake every day! She loved her idiot so much.

Catra knew if she could provide something like that for her beloved, untold favor would be won. And if her baby wanted cake

every day, she would deliver. But how? Cake eluded her. Cake; how could she provide cake?

Wait… Cake. There was something similar; something she had largely ignored at the breakfast table in favor of the various salted meats that were offered instead. What were they; pan… cakes? Yes, that was usually part of the first meal of the day. And really, they were just flat circles. Catra could make a flat circle.

But how does one make food? She almost felt as though she were being subjected to one of Entrapta's lessons; the answer being so obvious, but the method completely unclear. She wanted to rake her claws down something in frustration of the puzzle that had been presented to her. She continued her survey of the mocking room around her before narrowing in at her possible salvation.

A book sat upon a shelf above the stove; Catra was elated to see the spine said 'Refined Culinary Recipes for Unrefined Culinary Skill'. Aha; it was the strategist's logbook, the battleplans for the upcoming front, the master key to unlocking the mysteries of this bastard kitchen! Catra wasn't quite tall enough to reach the shelf, but nimbly angled herself onto the stove and claimed her prize. Yes, there would still be the gargantuan task of *comprehending* the instructions written on the page but she near-conquered a world, like hell a cake made in a pan would stop her.

She thumbed through the index at the front of the lexicon, pleased that breakfast items were listed first before throwing herself a soft 'Duh.' at the obviousness of it. First meal of the day, first section of the book.

She was elated to find what she was seeking in the list; ‘Fluffy Pancakes with Sweet Cream and Fruit Compote’. Catra had no idea what a compote could possibly be, but knew Adora really enjoyed fruit (she herself could take it or leave it) and sweet cream was the stuff that had covered the Bright Moon celebration cake… She flipped to the page and reviewed the instructions; it might as well be written in the First Ones glyphs for all she understood. But still, Catra was the definition of stubborn. She may not fully comprehend the code of the recipe, but she could at least match words. Catra left the detested kitchen, book in hand, to sort through the wreckage of supplies Adora had left in the dining area and hopefully find the boxes and bags that matched what was written in the ingredients list.

Adora was feeling satisfied; an elusive and rare feeling for her, but certainly not one she met with ill-content. Her body’s stupor had more or less worn off; truthfully, she probably should have joined Catra in the preparation of their morning meal. Except also she was feeling really very comfy and Catra hadn’t really protested too much at playing chef, offered even…

Idly she wondered what in the world she would make for them; had Catra picked up cooking as a hobby in the past couple weeks? Adora would never consider it a pastime of hers, but she had done enough roughing it away from any sort kitchen to pick up some basic cooking over campfire skills. Bow had been exceedingly patient in trying to teach her to not burn things too badly.

Regardless of her own skills or lack thereof, Adora knew that Catra was quite a bit more clever than she was, so was certain that whatever culinary delights she would concoct this morning for them would be delicious.

She happily moved on to the next, far more important, topic in her head: They'd had sex! *Hah, take that self-destructive tendency. I owned you!* It wasn't often that Adora took a moment to be really, genuinely proud of herself but this was definitely one of them. And it was only possible through her loving, wonderful girlfriend. Adora's heart ached at the affection she felt for Catra in this moment. As that little voice reminded her so many times since it had first cropped up during her mental duress back at Bright Moon, Catra was safety. She was love. She was Adora's inevitability.

A blissful smile was spread wide across her face as she settled deeply into the blankets. Blankets and bedding that smelled like...

At the scent reminder, Adora mused that even better than breakfast was sure to be, there was something far more enticing that she wanted to be tasting as soon as possible. She shivered in the memory of cleaning her fingers of Catra's slick. Adora was struck sharply with the impulse to rush downstairs and have her fill of the woman right then. She didn't indulge, just barely resisting, but did allow herself to fall deeply into memories of the morning.

Catra's tongue against her clit had been the best physical feeling she'd ever experienced; it was pure, unadulterated pleasure and she wanted nothing more than to give that feeling to her beloved in return. That had been her favorite part she had prepared to tell Catra about before her stomach interrupted. She let herself further drift into reminiscence; her brain wandering aimlessly through the recollection. First at how good Catra's fingers felt, so accommodating to her, using just the right amount of pressure in

her stroke. Then the excitement at getting some really tangible relief at the tension Catra had so expertly built in her. Even appreciating that however long pause after Catra's hand, though so agonizing in the moment that Adora was driven to using her own fingers before Catra so roughly shoved them aside to relentlessly lap and suck her folds. Which ultimately resulted in... *Fucking your hot and ready mouth, pushing your face deeper into my pussy and making you eat it as I came hard against you...*

Adora paled and tensed at the now lewdly aggressive thoughts coursing through her. She really didn't know where these impulses were coming from; while she was never one to back down from a challenge and considered herself an action-oriented person… So many of her urges seemed to border on downright *violent* . Smacking Catra's ass? Ripping her clothes off her body? These charged, vulgar descriptors of Catra's mouth and tongue being used to bring Adora sweet pleasure? Sure, they were just thoughts; nothing she had really acted on but… A low buzz of shame filled her stomach when she remembered she had acted on one when she had grabbed Catra's hair so roughly. She consoled herself with the explanation that it had been a one off thing, just from being pushed too far by a mouthy brat of a girl in a highly excitable moment. Plus well, Catra had turned completely docile in response, maybe seemed to enjoy it? *That* just added a whole new layer of confusion to the whole situation, so Adora neatly sidestepped that train of thought for the moment.

Besides, this *aggression* wasn't who Adora was as a person; not at all. Right?

She willed herself to turn to better, more pleasant things. Maybe forcing her feelings down wasn't exactly conducive to the new path she was trying to set for herself, but these things just

probably were a result of years of pent up feelings. She and Catra had spent most of their lives roughhousing together, if not flat-out fighting, so it followed that a few wires in her brain might cross the two. But she would get a handle on it now; sex was an expression of their love for one another, not another way she could dominate the other woman.

Adora smirked slightly. *While I definitely overdid it with the hair pulling, I do not regret stopping that asshole from talking. Always winning… Pff. In your dreams, kitty cat. I'll put you in your place any day. That place being underneath me.* Adora tried to ignore the flush of arousal that ran through her at that thought; these wires needed to get uncrossed as soon as possible.

Feeling the heat growing at her core, Adora went back to remembering how good it felt to have her own fingers working against herself when she couldn't take Catra's teasing absence any longer. That would definitely be something that merited further exploration; really, the fact she'd never fully indulged in her twenty-some years seemed preposterous now. Sure Catra's hand and mouth had felt *astoundingly good* and it was all that she could hope that Catra would want to do anything like that again and soon. But at the same token it felt… selfish to think that would always be an option for her. To expect Catra to perform whenever the mood struck Adora was an untenable expectation. Really, it was just good planning and common sense to have a backup option.

Memories swirling around her head; the heat between her legs was rapidly rising. It was sorely tempting to begin that exploration right now. She traced a finger down her own stomach, halting before her nest of curls. But the possibility that Catra would want a repeat of their performance stayed her hand. She wouldn't

expect it of her, of course, but if the opportunity arose… Best to be prepared.

Grudgingly, she realized no good was going to come from just laying in bed and waiting. The atmosphere was way too charged and far too tempting with desires she definitely wanted to follow, but wanted her partner close for them. She rose from the bed and stretched fully, yawning as she did. With the inhale of her yawn, she wrinkled her nose in distaste. *Yeah, Catra's definitely going to say no with me smelling like that.* A bath was definitely in order; bathing was a rare luxury for Adora, the chance to soak out her troubles and ease her worries in the steam. She'd come to love it after the shared baths in Mystacor, a lifetime ago, and took the opportunity to indulge again when she could. It did not happen often.

But now seemed like the perfect time; they'd already decided today was going to be unproductive and Adora had packed one of her most treasured possessions. It had been a gift from Perfuma from early on in their friendship after she'd shared with the willowy blonde how much she enjoyed soaking. A set of bath oils, made from the various flora of her kingdom, and each bottle was meant to invoke a different set of emotional states of being. Adora was once again glad for the misunderstanding between 'vacation' and 'mission'. If the word mission had cropped up from the start, the set would have likely remained in her room at the castle. But instead it was here with her, much to her delight.

Adora ran over to her pack to examine the vials and decide which to use. Written on the first bottle, in Perfuma's own loopy writing, read "Atlas Cedar & Cypress: Grounding, Centering, Balancing. Sweet woodsy aroma." Adora carefully uncorked the top and took a small inhale. While it did make her feel like she was in the

deepest, calmest part of the Whispering Woods the scent did not match her mood. *Spent enough time in those damn trees yesterday. Part of why I'm even needing this bath so badly.*

The next label read "Cinnamon Bark & Vanilla: Comforting, Soothing, & Energizing. Spicy, warm and sugared scent." That had been the only one she'd used thus far; it smelled so delicious she honestly wanted to eat it. Adora recalled making that comment to Perfuma upon receiving the gift and was told in no plainer words that her stomach would regret that decision. It really had only been a comment; despite popular opinion, she wasn't that dumb. Even if Perfuma had to spend a good amount of time explaining what she had been gifted in the first place. Still, as hungry as she currently was, Adora really didn't need to be surrounded by something that smelled like fresh baked dessert.

The third bottle was labelled "Patchouli & Lemongrass: Romantic & Stimulating. For someone so naturally loveable." Several small hearts were drawn near the scrawl on the bottle. Adora recalled the way Perfuma had placed her hand on Adora's arm and commented this was her personal favorite scent and how she really hoped Adora would think of her when she used it. She chose then- and now, to not think too deeply on the little hearts on the label or ponder why this one wasn't given a scent description quite like the others. As appealing as something to invoke romance might be at the present moment, this bottle would be a definite pass. Even just considering using the contents of the bottle brought images of a teary eyed Scorpia to mind; it was far safer for all parties involved to avoid it entirely. Even if she was fairly certain Perfuma would want to redo the label and pretend it never existed if she saw it now.

The final bottle seemed like her best choice. “Lavender & Basil: Refreshing & Relaxing. Gentle earthy-floral profile.” She inhaled the scent deeply, feeling a pleasant sensation of uplifting calm. Her thoughts were stilled, a lackadaisical smile crossed her lips. And yet also, she felt invigorated, as if she’d just had the best nap of her life and could take on the world. Revitalizing tranquility seemed a good headspace to be in. Also it was a softer scent; not nearly as aggressive as the others. That would also be the best choice for Catra’s delicate nose, as well.

The choice for this luxurious addition to her favorite form of self-care finally sorted, Adora climbed halfway down the stairs. She called out, knowing her girlfriend’s superior hearing had already detected her presence on the steps. “Catra, I’m going to go take a bath, just in case I’m not finished by the time you are!”

“Okay, but don’t bother getting dressed after; I’m just going to undress you again!” She hollered back from what was possibly the dining room. Adora flushed, a large smile on her face. *Okay, so it seems like she will want to go again… Made the right call back there, chief. All the more reason to get clean.* She bounded up the stairs again, wanting nothing more for both of them to finish their tasks and rejoin one another’s company.

Catra had many skills in life, though years of torment and abuse would make it so she would be the last one to recognize them as such. But they did exist. She had organizational ability, strong persuasion skills, and a blunt style of leadership that churned out results. Her mind held a whole catalogue of battlefield tactics and strategies and one could not fail to mention her close-combat prowess. While she’d only gotten the chance to refine skills that were deemed useful to the Horde, who knew what competencies she would develop now that they were out of war times.

Catra was certain cooking would not be one of them.

The hunt for supplies had been mixed; the dry ingredients had been there and fortunately were well labeled. Milk and eggs were a different story, however. She knew enough that these things would not be kept with shelf items and highly doubted the availability or freshness of any that might be in the icebox of this long deserted house. She reasoned that recipes were really more just guidelines, suggestions of how the food could be created. Catra was all for improvising when it served her. Skipping two stupid things on the list couldn't possibly make that much of a difference.

She gathered up the various packages she'd collected and returned to the kitchen to combine them into something wonderful for Adora. *She's the only one worth all this trouble…*

Reading the instructions below the list of ingredients, Catra stared at the powdered mess that was in her bowl. "... *the batter should be smooth and glide easily when stirred with a spoon… combine thoroughly to remove as many lumps as possible…"* She supposed that the dry powder was indeed smooth, even if this seemed really fucking unlikely it would turn into anything resembling food once heat was applied. It more seemed the mixture would explode if it were placed over fire. Catra gritted her teeth in frustration as she reviewed the list of ingredients yet again; almost ready to call the whole thing off and tell Adora to make her own damn breakfast. Something was missing, but what could it be?

How about the two things you skipped, dumbass? Oh. Yeah, that would follow and she supposed some sort of liquid would indeed make the mixture smooth and glide-able. She didn't have milk, but water was pretty much the same thing. Egg was a different story, but as she added the water to the mix and combined, she shrugged and figured it would be close enough. She now had a batter that indeed ` *glided easily when stirred with a spoon'* . Fucking finally.

The next line read *Heat a pan or griddle over medium heat; grease lightly with butter or oil to prevent the cakes from sticking to the pan.* Great, more shit she didn't have and fire was finally coming into play. She was fairly certain there had been a small bottle of oil in one of the boxes she'd rummaged through already (*Everything else in the fucking world was in that room.)* and after some searching returned with it.

Pan sufficiently lubricated and beginning to heat over the stovetop, Catra read on with her instructions. *Using a small cup or large spoon for uniformity, place dollops of batter into the pan. Pancakes are ready to be flipped when small bubbles appear over the surface and several have burst. Flip only once and bake until golden brown.*

Catra approached the pan on the stovetop to survey whether it was ready to produce food. When she drew near, a puddle of the oil popped and shot out towards her. Instantly she recoiled, fur raising and tail poofing out of its own accord. She was still very much naked and wasn't exactly looking to get some of her more delicate parts burnt to hell. She looked around for some sort of temporary cover up and found an apron hanging on the door to the pantry. Slipping it over her head and tying it about her waist,

it would at least shield her most vulnerable areas. She also turned the heat down a smidge to be certain.

Her first attempt resulted in one side being burnt to a crisp and the other practically raw. She wasn't sure how many bubbles should burst before flipping and decided for once to error on the side of caution, then completely overcompensated on the other side by barely giving it any time to cook. Obviously that was the incorrect choice for either side. The next attempt was less black and more of a dark brown, but her hand slipped as she was flipping the cake so the shape came out closer to a weird, lopsided oval. Catra hated these flat circles more than she had hated anything in her life; truly an accomplishment.

The third go-round was better; not quite the rich golden brown she associated with the cakes made at the castle but not burnt to hell. The shape was closer to a true circle too. It had been difficult to extract from the pan however, so she reasoned that more oil must be needed. As she waited for that to heat back up, she reviewed the other parts of this disaster.

Sweet cream was right out; it took a ton of milk and she was pretty certain water would not be a fitting substitute this time. The fruit compote seemed simple enough- fresh fruits, honey, and salt then heated until it all got melted and mushed together. Easy. Except Catra did not have fresh fruit or honey. Why did everything with cooking need to be so damn complicated?

Maybe it wasn't fresh fruit, but there was still a good amount of candied fruit from last night's dinner basket left. She reasoned that honey wouldn't be necessary since it was already covered in sugar. Learning her lesson with the dry batter, she put some water

into the pot with the various fruits and left it to come to boil, per the instructions.

A short time later, Catra had a plate full of pancakes, all varying in size and shade but in theory edible. The compote was actually pretty tasty, she'd stolen a quick bite to make certain, if not achingly sweet. It would likely taste good to Adora and that was all that mattered to her. Catra was exhausted by this activity, but determined to see her journey through. Most helpfully she'd found a tray in the kitchen that allowed her to balance the plate of pancakes, the small bowl of compote, and a water pitcher on her descent back upstairs.

Adora had finished her bath just a bit before she heard Catra climbing the stairs, hopefully with food. The bath had been absolute bliss; the lavender aroma was immensely relaxing and the basil added a somewhat spicy, herbed flair to the experience. Best of all, she felt clean.

She had broken Catra's rule slightly, however, and was wrapped in a towel. Though she figured that was easily rectified should the situation call for it. Brushing out her hair to let it dry in a somewhat neat fashion, she waited for the reappearance of her love.

Catra could smell whatever Adora had used in her bath as soon as her feet hit the stairs. It wasn't a bad scent, though it did tickle her nose a little and that was a little distracting. But she had just spent however long being tortured in the kitchen and was not going to let a strange smell distract her from delivery.

Catra entered their room and paused for a moment to drink in the sight of Adora wrapped in a towel, brushing out her golden locks of hair. The weird scent was definitely coming from her, though that was pretty obvious even from the stairs. Whatever Adora used in her bath smelled good; soothing but there was another part that made Catra's eyes glaze over a little. She shook her head of the fog, chalking it up to the natural radiance that haloed her girlfriend in everything she did, even simple things like grooming herself.

Adora stopped her brushstrokes and marveled at her partner. Catra was looking utterly delectable in just a simple apron, a little dusting of flour on the front and even a little on one cheek where possibly she'd tried to swipe it away to no avail. Her presentation screamed a mix of sexy and domestic; the allure of just enough skin peeking out below the apron and the knowledge she had been *cooking* for them. "Mmmm… Welcome back. I missed you."

Even with the cloying scent disrupting her slightly, Catra did not miss Adora's sultry appraisal of her. She shivered under the gaze, but did not shy away from its intensity. "Brought you something to eat." Her hips seemed to sashay of their own accord as she walked the tray closer to Adora's spot on the edge of the bed.

"Great! Just go ahead and put the tray to the side so we can get started." A smug grin covered her face as she leaned back on her arms, eyebrow arching up suggestively.

Catra exalted at the boldness, but she had spent way too long creating this mess for Adora to ignore it. "Uh-uh, you eat what I give you and it's not that… Yet. I worked way too hard on this for you to ignore it. Behave." Turning that down was far harder than

she made it seem; but her culinary efforts would not be wasted. Plus there was just something about knowing she'd prepared a meal for Adora that just sort of… Halted the more lusty feelings in her. It brought up feelings of home, of peace, and just being together. *Caring for my mate…* A satisfied, primal rumble echoed deep in her chest at the thought.

"Not sure I can anymore; think you broke that part of me." Adora caught the annoyed tail flicks from her girlfriend and adjusted. "But, you're right. I was the one who asked for this and you so graciously, amazingly provided. Thank you." Her tail stopped its staccato sway and she joined Adora on the bed, resting her head on Adora's shoulder.

Even more than usual, Catra found herself wanting to be close to Adora. As soon as she lay her head on the woman's shoulder, she was nuzzling against it. Her upper arm was just so sturdy, comforting, and warm. Plus, there was still that puzzling, though Catra decided, also very agreeable scent. Being this close to its source was almost overwhelming, but in a good way. The rumble of her chest began to sound through the room.

Catra being this affectionate was almost enough to make her turn her attention from the meal again. A nuzzling, purring, and happy girlfriend was hard to ignore. But she realized that said girlfriend was feeling this happy at providing for her and turned her attention to the contents of the tray. "Pancakes! Oh, baby girl, I love it. And some sort of fruit syrup to go with?"

"Compote." Catra corrected. She couldn't even be certain she was pronouncing it right, but that did not matter; she was far too distracted with the goal of nestling as deep into Adora's shoulder

as she possibly could. Her claws itched to knead something, but she buried the impulse. She hadn't kneaded in years.

"Very fancy. When did you learn to cook?"

"I'm a woman of many talents, Adora. Now, hush, and eat."

Though they weren't the best looking pancakes in the world; goopy in some spots, burnt beyond recognition in others, when smothered with the compote the taste profile was there. Adora hummed happily as she munched, thoroughly impressed Catra had managed this. "I can't believe you did this! I can barely boil water. I once made a soup that slowed our pace by two days because everyone was so sick after." Adora chuckled at the memory through her next bite.

"... Appetizing, babe." She had worked her head under Adora's neck after thoroughly marking up her shoulder and the left half of her collarbone area, but much to her delight, the blonde just positioned around her to continue eating, not even seemingly particularly interrupted by it. It was almost as if it were completely commonplace for her to have to eat around someone attempting to mold their body into hers. When she heard Adora give a particularly satisfied sounding "Yum." her claws on her left hand did finally emerge and begin to gently knead into Adora's chest.

Adora finished the last bite of her breakfast and chewed carefully as she registered the rhythmic pinpricks of her claws. It was not exactly a new sensation for Adora; just one she hadn't felt in many, many years. Not since Catra was more kitten than apex

predator. She remembered the day that she finally asked Catra about it, both of them half grown rascals curled up in Adora's bunk after just barely escaping being caught out of beds after curfew. Old enough to know better, young enough not to care. They had been breathless from their flight, now trying to hold back giggles, but slowly settling in; Adora on her back at the head of the bed, Catra near her feet though more spread out than her normal curled position. As they regained their composure, Adora felt the telltale pricks against her leg and threw an eye open to see Catra against her calf, arms spread out and kneading her quad in quiet bliss. She didn't mean anything insulting by her question; it was just a behavior Catra had sometimes done and Adora had never really asked about it. But she wanted to know more; wanted to know everything there was to know about her best friend in the world. "Why are you doing that?" Her voice was not audible to anyone without Catra's sharp hearing.

The claws stopped their motion instantly. "Don't know. Just happens if I'm..." She felt Catra slip away up to her own bunk. It was the last time she could recall feeling that gentle kneading. And would be days before she'd reclaim her place on Adora's bunk at night.

Adora did not question the return of the kneading and took any slight discomfort from it gracefully. It only hurt a bit, really more comforting than anything, and just as in every other time it had happened, wasn't something she wanted to bring a stop to. As Catra kneaded so incessantly against her, she was also rubbing the side of her face all along Adora's collarbone and up her neck. Adora just leaned her head back so Catra had more access to the area which she took no time in exploiting.

Catra felt like she was on a different plane of existence. Everything just felt so good, so intimate between her and the love of her life. Adora was so soft, yet so strong and solid against her. She languished in every brush of her face against her warm body, so intensely grateful that Adora just accepted what was happening and didn't question anything. She was completely blissed out but there was one thing that could make it better. She tugged lamely at the string of the apron, wanting nothing but skin to be between her and Adora. She gave a whimpering little trill.

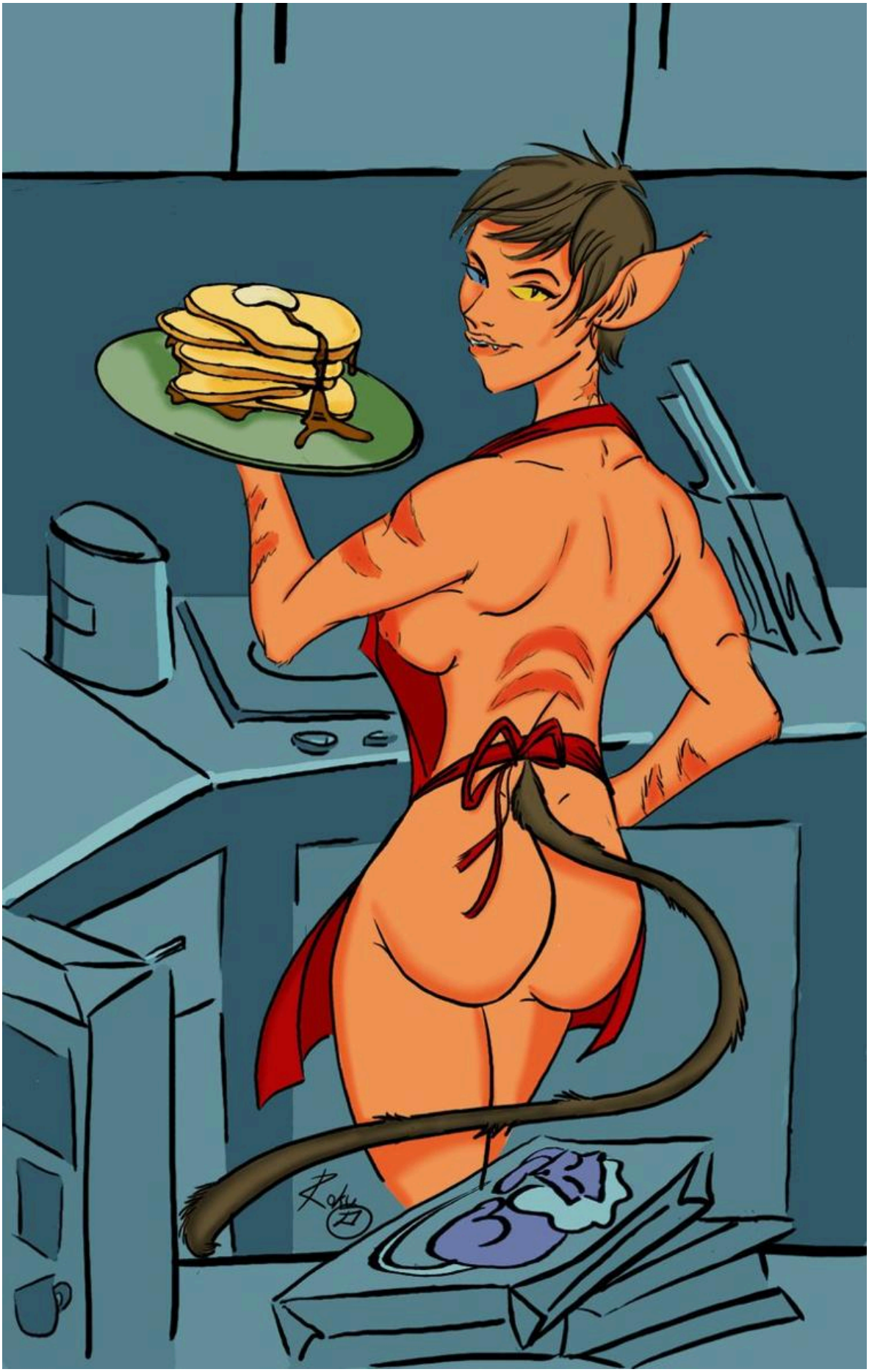
Adora glanced down at the noise with an affectionate smile. She pulled at the strings of the apron, helping to release Catra from the cloth. The claws that were kneading against the towel paused for a moment, then slowly sliced down the towel though masterfully avoiding the delicate flesh underneath. The offending cloth partially fell away from Adora's body. Adora surveyed the change passively, though there was a certain thrill that came from the sound of the razor edge of her claws ripping through the towel so seamlessly. *Could have just taken it off, but I can't say that wasn't effective either.*

"Hey," Adora's voice was gentle, not wanting to spook the affectionate woman partially in her arms. "I'm just going to put the tray on the dresser, okay? Just… Hold on to me." She felt Catra wrap her arms tightly around her neck and chest. Without much effort, Adora rose from the bed, one arm cradled under Catra to steady her as she walked the tray to the dresser. The rest of the towel floated to the floor as she rose. It wasn't a long trek, but Catra was astounded at this reminder of her girlfriend's strength. *Letting go of me wasn't even an option in her mind…* The purr somehow increased in its intensity.

After discarding the tray, Adora settled them back into the bed, this time with her back against the headboard and Catra fully and completely in her arms, their uncovered bodies flush against one another. Catra found herself lamenting that she couldn't physically get any closer to Adora. *It will never be enough… I want all her, her whole being.*

Adora closed her eyes, letting the blissful sounds of Catra's purrs lull her into a soft doze. She was now kneading with both claws, the purr resonating so deeply through her chest Adora could swear the vibrations were her own, and still giving small, comforting nuzzles under Adora's chin.

The day just kept getting better and better.



Chapter End Notes

Did you know that basil is in the catnip family and tends to produce a much subtler activation response in our furry friends? Yeah, if you didn't (and I certainly didn't before this chapter), parts probably make a little more sense now. I didn't want to give her the zoomies, just sort of made her more affectionate, vulnerable, needy. One of my own fluffy little beasts always rubs against it incessantly before eating it; that was kind of my inspiration.

Write a cooking scene, I said to myself. Have it end up with Catra in just an apron, playing housefrau for Adora. They'll love it!
...Do you know how difficult it is to write someone cooking who arguably has little to no experience/knowledge of some of the most basic food items or skills? God, I hope you all got some laughs/awww's out of it because I *struggled* through it. Just take some of it with a grain of salt, all right? Trying to make this fairly canon-compliant but whew buddy. That was tough. "Catra could make a flat circle." may be among my favorite lines ever written, however.

I promise that discussion of Catra's claws will be coming; in fact, this whole fluffy sentimental mess is just leading up to that. I know someone asked for more cat traits and hopefully I brought them with this.

THANK YOU ALL SO MUCH. I love all the comments, the support, and I cannot wait to keep writing for your- and my own, enjoyment.

Now contains fanart done by the amazing rokumonshi. Check her out on tumblr (rokumonshi)!

Hands

Chapter Notes

> As I post this, I currently have over 8300 hits and almost 450 kudos. I am blown away and humbled, everyone. Thank you.
>
> Please enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora awoke from her nap and gently kissed the top of Catra's head. She stirred at the touch, though Adora was uncertain if she had fallen asleep as well or was consciously reacting to the sensation. The kneading had stopped by now, but they remained as tightly woven into one another as before.

"Hey, there. You awake?" Adora said quietly, running her fingers through Catra's short mane and down her cheek in a loving caress.

"Mmm, more or less." Catra's head still felt a little off, but the incessant need to touch and rub against Adora had worn off. Well. It was at least back to its normal intensity.

"I think that was the best nap of my life. Sex and a full belly make for great sleep." Adora had a euphoric smile spread wide across her face as she continued to run her fingers through Catra's hair.

Catra gave a soft snort of amusement, drenched in affection. "Good thing that's my life's plan now; feed you and fuck you. You alright with that?"

"Only if I get to return the favor just as often."

Catra gave a happy little trill and began to purr steadily. "Anytime you want, babe. I'm yours."

They laid in cuddled contentment for a while longer, Adora still playing with her hair and Catra rumbling away. It was a peaceful quiet, but at the mention of sex, Adora's question from earlier tickled against the edge of her mind. She decided eventually to indulge it. "So, back to our favorite parts…" A playful smile tugged at her lips. "You come up with one yet?"

Catra blinked. It wasn't that she'd forgotten, exactly, but providing a meal for her mate had just taken up most of her focus. And then when she felt as though if she could not physically meld her body with Adora's spicy-sweet smelling one the very universe would cease to be… She hadn't really had much time for reflection. The sex was good, it felt great, and how soon could they do it again? was about as much depth as she had been able put into it. "You're serious, huh?"

"Well, yeah." Adora was suddenly feeling self-conscious; was it really that strange of a question? "I just wanna know what you liked so I can do it again. Or get even better at it! I suppose also if there was anything you didn't like we could also talk about that; really might want to… I guess we sort of did already before I had my go; though, if there was anything else I could improve on, I'd listen and stop. Or start? Ugh, whatever needed done. But I'd prefer to focus on the good… Motivating, y'know? Not that I really need much motivation; god, just two seconds remembering *everything* and I'm wanting to go again…"

She knew she was rambling; Adora did have that tendency when she was feeling nervous. She tried to steady herself, because there was nothing to be nervous about. Catra may tease and snark, but her feelings were just as safe with the feline as her body had been. "I could say mine first? If you wanted." The words came out not exactly bursting with confidence, but still she was putting herself out there and not backing away from any discomfort.

The onslaught of babbling was a certain indication that Adora was absolutely serious and that this was really quite important to her. *She's getting anxious; let's get her reeled in a bit.* "Of course only

the good, goof. Not that there's any bad to even talk about. Tell me your favorite part; I wanna know." Though she was certain to pay careful attention to the blonde's response so she could give an appropriate, meaningful reply, in the back of her mind, Catra ran through the events of the early morning and tried to identify her 'favorite' moment. It really didn't seem possible. How do you pick and choose from among the immaculate?

"I really liked when you were eating me out." She said it in a way that was confidently shy; the words were unwavering in their sincerity but a little self-effacing. Her cheeks had a rosy sheen to them and Catra noticed her pulse was quickening.

Even after everything they'd done earlier, Catra's brain still reeled at the casual way Adora said the words 'eating me out', especially when she was currently pressed against her naked body. *So hot. So, so, so hot.* She sopped up the roiling mess that was her cognitive ability and pressed further. "Oh yeah, Princess? What exactly did you like so much about it?"

"Pff, beyond the fact it felt great and made me come like amazingly hard?" Adora fell back against the headboard with a dazed grin, lost in memory. She momentarily pulled her hand from Catra's mane to wind her fingers through her own locks. *Does it always feel like that? Oh, stars...* Adora was starting to feel a little worked up again as she recalled Catra's tongue so relentlessly working her and was becoming increasingly aware that she still had naked Catra viewing privileges. Touching privileges as well, if their intertwined bodies were any indication. She felt a low pulse emerge deep in her core. "Oh, Catra, it was just everything about it. The way you built me up; especially with that *teasing* right before? Ugh, I thought you'd called it quits on me to drive me up the wall or something. But then you come back with *that* ?" Adora was looking at Catra like she hung the sun in the sky each morning.

Teasing? Quitting on her? What was she talking- oh. That. How could Catra possibly forget that her anatomy tried to ruin the best moment of her life?

Catra ground her teeth at the reminder. She almost never was angry at the fact she had claws, at least not later in her life. As a kid, sure, to be *different* was a tough pill to swallow; especially since Shadow Weaver exploited it cruelly at every opportunity she had. But with time, particularly when she began to excel at training and hand-to-hand combat, they grew to be a point of pride. They were something she liked about herself (and those things were few and far between, to be honest). Her claws were lethal, precise, and unlike other people's weapons, always on hand for her. Literally.

They belong to an animal.

She shifted uncomfortably at her last thought, knowing exactly where it came from. Dimly, she realized those traits were only good things to have in her *old* life. Those qualities now in her current and any future life she wanted to build; not so worthwhile. As she considered her present life, it struck her that since her claws could shred through *metal*, really if she hadn't stopped herself, what chance would Adora's… area stand against them? Catra swallowed uncomfortably and felt her throat close at the thought.

She had known it in the moment, which is why she stopped using them, but she really *felt* the weight and implication of it now. With a sick feeling growing in her stomach, she also remembered the times the less delicate parts of Adora had been mangled underneath her claws. She knew she would just need to look at the woman's back to see the evidence of her proficiency at mutilation.

"Uh, Catra? Love? Is something wrong?" Adora wrinkled her brow at the sudden stillness that had overtaken Catra.

Catra knew she probably looked ready to vomit at any moment. She tried to regain her composure, but the room was quickly closing in on her, and her impulses were raging. *Flee. Escape. Run.*

Wordlessly, she launched from the bed to grab some clothes from the pile on the floor, and began ripping them on to her body as quickly as possible. It didn't matter who they belonged to; she just needed something so she could get *away* .

Run, run, run as fast as you can. You cannot escape yourself. The haunting laughter echoed in the deepest vaults of her mind.

"Catra! Wha- where are you going?" Adora was shocked at the voracity in which Catra fled their embrace. Panic gripped at her chest; she had no idea where this sudden turn had come from. She was already out of the bed before Catra was able to even throw on bottoms to go with her hastily applied shirt. "Please, tell me something!"

"Need space. Gotta get away." Catra numbly called out, turning to drop to all fours and abscond from this house as quickly as possible.

Before she could bolt, steel arms enveloped her. "No! Not like this, please." Adora was a fighter; she would fight to keep what was hers. "I-I'll leave the room; let you have the space you need for as long as you need. But please, just promise me you'll *stay* !"

Catra suppressed a feral growl at her sudden confinement. She felt Adora's heart hammering away in her chest and her entire body was shaking. She was overwhelmed by the ferocity at which she clung to Catra, even in spite of the potential danger implicit in the action. She heard Adora's pleas… And that word. *Stay.* That word that held so much poignancy between them.

She would only cause pain. *Stay.*

It would be so easy to rip herself away. *Stay.*

She could be out of the house in minutes, then off into the horizon. *Stay.*

Gone forever, so she would never hurt the one she loved so dearly. *Stay.*

And there was only one obstacle to prevent her escape and it… wanted her to *stay.*

Catra slowly came back into herself as Adora continued to hold her. She wasn't *okay* , but the room was not closing in any further on her. She wasn't *okay* , but she didn't feel the crushing urge to flee either. She wasn't okay, but she was going to stay *.* At that decision, she began to cry, the stress finally bubbling up to its breaking point.

"Oh, Catra..." Adora loosened her grip slightly, but only to position herself into holding the sobbing woman in a more soothing manner. She rubbed along Catra's back, letting her tears soak her still naked chest. "Love… It's okay. Whatever it is, it's okay."

Catra had no idea how long they held that pose; how long she spent sobbing into Adora's front. Her head was throbbing. Her eyes burned from crying (ugh, she *hated* crying) and her nose felt all gross and stuffy from it too. At some point, Adora had shifted them on the floor, though at no time did she stop holding her so despondent lover. Catra finally sat up slightly, trying to reposition her aching head to get some relief.

"Hey…" Adora began and faltered, unsure how to proceed or if she even *should* . She was trying to not let her own confusion and panic influence the situation. "How you feeling?" She lamely finished.

Catra snorted, unable to control her irritable demeanor when she felt so completely strung out. "Fuckin' peachy."

"Yeah, I know…" Adora began to run her fingers through her mane, wanting to bring some small comfort. Catra froze at the touch. "Is this okay?..."

"... Yeah. It feels good." It really did feel great for her headache, even if most of her did not feel she deserved comfort at this moment. "Head hurts."

Adora increased her strokes, gently massaging her scalp as she did so. Catra was still so tense, but with time loosened up in her arms, almost to the point of relaxing. Adora decided to take a chance when she felt her girlfriend's distress ease. "We don't have to right now, I know you're still not feeling well… But, at some point, can we talk about this?"

Catra sighed, steeling herself with the reminder that she had *chosen* to stay. Of course Adora would want to talk about it; hell, if she were in Adora's position, she wouldn't be so damn patient about it. She would demand that Adora explain immediately. She deserved one, even if Catra was sick at the prospect. "... I wasn't teasing you."

"I'm not sure I understand." Adora blinked, completely forgetting in the wake of everything else what they had been talking about before Catra's abrupt break down.

"When we were having sex. During your turn... When I s-stopped like that. That wasn't… *teasing* ."

Oh, right. Their favorite parts; Adora remembered talking about how Catra had riled her up so well. But she still didn't understand; if it wasn't her teasing then what was it? "I'm a little more caught up now, but…"

"Fuck, Adora, I have damned *blades* for fingers! You think that would have felt good if I'd slipped?!"

"Oh." Adora was struck by the outburst.

"Yeah."

They sat in an uncomfortable silence before Adora needed to have something clarified. "But… you were, um, using them? Before you stopped?"

"Real perceptive, Adora; I was indeed using them before I stopped using them." Catra bit at the dumbfounded woman. Even before she saw Adora look away, embarrassed and hurt, she was

preparing herself to apologize. "I'm sorry; that was uncalled for and you don't deserve to be snapped at. I got a little too… excited and the damn things decided they wanted to join in on the party. I could barely control them so I stopped using my fingers. I didn't want to hurt you..."

"Well, I appreciate that." Adora's mind was whirling at the dichotomy in her head; how *good* Catra's fingers had felt against her clit but admittedly she flinched from the thought of the appearance of claws in that area. But also, Catra had stopped herself and then finished Adora in a spectacular fashion; was there really a problem here? "But I'm still confused; nothing bad happened. Not even close."

Catra scoffed bitterly. "Oh how nice that I didn't maim you during your first time. How absolutely lucky you are to have someone like that as your girlfriend." Catra tried to not spiral too far into thinking this might make Adora reconsider their relationship status entirely.

Adora paused, drawing her brows into a tight crease. She must still be misunderstanding somewhere. "I am lucky to have her…" Her voice was impossibly soft and sincere as she said it. She cleared her throat, which had thickened with the thoughts coursing through her head. Now it sounded only resolved and certain. "No, not lucky. I was *meant* to have her. I know from experience that 'destiny' is a raw deal but… I was meant to have this beautiful, considerate woman who even in moments when she feels like she's about to lose absolutely control? She still puts me first and wouldn't ever, ever hurt me."

Catra scowled bitterly, deflecting away from the sweet sentiment. *Can't just pretend it's never happened before, Adora.* "I have hurt you though, so many times. And I could have hurt you *so easily* when you grabbed me to stop me from running…"

Adora paused, eyes thoughtful. Claws never even came to her mind as a possibility when she had been so dead set on keeping Catra from leaving. "Yeah, I guess you could have. But I know

you, Catra, and you would *never* intentionally harm me. Not now." She stopped to draw in a deep breath. "And if we're gonna go there; I've hurt you too. Plenty."

"Adora…" Catra croaked out, immediately wanting to tell the woman that *Catra* was destruction and pain, while Adora was the personification of restoration and goodness.

Adora did not let her even start. "We've hurt each other and despite that, we still love each other. I love you, Catra. Every part of you. That includes your hands, just as they are."

Catra shut her eyes tightly, far too lost in the depths of her own self-hatred to face what Adora was saying to her.

Slowly, Adora drew Catra's hands into her own, allowing the woman the opportunity to stop her or pull away. When she did not, Adora began studying them carefully. She examined in great depth every ridge and every crease that made up these beautiful extensions of her girlfriend's arms. She poured over the lines that criss crossed her palms and created the stripes of her fingers. Adora's focus shifted to the retracted points that peaked at her fingertips. She felt regret that they'd been trained to hurt and to maim when she knew in the deepest part of her heart they were created for so much more than that. But to dwell on the past brought no satisfaction to the future. What they had experienced, no matter how dire and destructive, was necessary to craft them into the people they were today. Their circumstances were the foundation they would use to move forward. Together.

"We *chose* each other and that's actually way more potent than destiny or whatever. Catra, I mean it, if I had to go through everything again, exactly the same way, I'd do it in a heartbeat if it meant in the end getting to choose you. To live for you... To live for us." She grew quiet for a moment, reflecting in her absolute certainty of her statement. She gently drew Catra's palms to face upwards, before beginning to kiss the entire surface of them on each hand. She was careful to not miss a single spot. "These hands are our future."

Catra stilled at the brush of her lips, then was entirely ensnared by her words. *Our future?*

Adora kissed up the index finger of Catra's right hand, not hesitating for an instant to also place a loving peck on the sharp point that adorned the end. She had absolute confidence, complete certainty, that no harm would ever come to her from these claws again. She mirrored the trail along the same finger of her left hand, once again tenderly kissing the prick of her claw. "These fingers will hold and caress."

Adora moved to her next digit, kissing along the nimble length of them in the same way as the first. "These fingers will cook and care." She moved to the other hand and repeated the action on the same finger.

"They will play and banter." The action was duplicated in full along the third finger of each hand.

She smiled before kissing the smallest digit on each side. "They will create beauty in everything they do."

She naturally then moved to each thumb, still kissing the entire length right to and including the claw. "They will make us a home full of safety and protection."

Adora finally flipped her hands over to kiss each knuckle there softly and slowly; luxuriating in the motion. "I trust these hands; I know they are meant to love. And to be loved. I am so fiercely proud to be the one who gets to return that love to you."

Catra was near catonic. She watched Adora's ministations with a wide-eyed, unblinking intensity. She listened to each phrase and allowed it to fill the deepest, most broken parts of her. She knew that more work would be needed to fill in the gaping holes completely, years worth, but this was a start. Their start towards the future.

"You really mean all that? A future… a home together?" Catra's voice was gruff, overwhelmed by the emotions churning through

her. She had never felt so raw before, so acutely examined and perceived. She was staggered to not be found *wanting* in some way at the end.

“With all my heart, if you’ll have me.”

Catra gave a meek whimper, became unthinkably still, then threw herself against Adora’s mouth, kissing her with the most cherished appreciation, boundless passion, and unconditional love she could possibly will into a single kiss. Adora met her mouth gratefully, returning everything in full back to the other woman.

They wound their hands together as they continued to kiss. Hands that chose to love one another.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm feeling a little spent over this one, folks; hope it satisfied y'all. I had Adora's scene of lavishing love over Catra's hands worked out for a while, but the rest was a *struggle*. (You almost got a Catra fleeing successfully scene, a lot more Shadow Weaver trauma, AND Catra referring to their relationship using the past tense, as in no more. Woof. I decided to trim back and I think it works?)
>
> I find the 'inevitable' scene from the end of chapter 5 to be such a beautiful moment; so much that I have Catra's monologue screenshot-ted so I can read it when I'm feeling a little inadequate in my ability. But the pair, Adora particularly, reveling in that they've chosen this for themselves? If I'm not coming off as completely full of myself here... Mwah. Chef's kiss. Growth! Development! Sapphic love!
>
> The previous chapters show how ready Catra is to give her love to Adora, but I wanted this one to highlight her struggle to receive love back and touch on her self-hatred/trauma (but without making it a whole big long arc, which is why this is on the shorter side and so much fat was trimmed out. I might do super hardcore angst/trauma study one day but...). Does

it ruin the moment to have little author's notes like this? Am I pulling back to curtain too much? It's late and I'm tired; we'll blame that and move on.

Slight warning, the next update for this may take some time. As I said, this took a lot out of me and I'm struggling with some writer's block on how to get these girls out of bed and on to other things... Though maybe I need to just get them back in bed, huh? ;-) I'm sure y'all wouldn't mind too terribly at that.

Thanks for sticking with me and sharing your thoughts on this piece. Every comment warms my heart to the core. Until next time; toodles! (Though for those interested, you will likely catch me on 'Her' again very soon; fluffy college AUs just flow a smidge easier.)

Discussion

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Despite the passion of their kiss, there was no great urge to press things forward much more- at least for the moment. Adora's words hung thickly in the air, coating the room in a loving blanket. It felt as though since they would have a lifetime to explore and love one another fully, there simply was no rush. Neither had chosen to speak much after everything, content on just savoring their person's presence.

They did return to the bed for their comfort; Catra was curled up tightly in Adora's lap as they lounged together, Adora absently running her fingers through Catra's hair. The purrs were automatic as she lay listening to the firm and steady heartbeat of the woman she loved so dearly. Her thoughts during this moment of tranquility were generally jumbled, though not in an unpleasant way. Catra just could not focus on a single topic for very long, as it would undoubtedly cause a cascade of other warm feelings and thoughts to ripple through her. What had they even been discussing before Adora filled in the cracks of her deepest insecurities and worries with her loving kisses and tender words? *Ah. Favorite part. Right.* As utterly relaxed and safe as she felt, Catra gave a small yawn and finally decided to divulge her favorite moment. "So, when you pulled my hair…"

Before she could finish speaking, Adora interrupted her. "Oh, Catra, I am so sorry about that!" Her hands stilled their affectionate strokes through Catra's mane. "I can't believe I got so… worked up like that. Can't believe that I would be so rough just to get what I wanted at the time. At least you were able to stop yourself before you hurt me… I promise, I will *never* do anything like that again."

"Uhh, well, this is...awkward." Catra sat herself up from Adora's chest and onto the edge of the bed. She curled her tail around her body and tucked her legs against her chest. *Fuck, fuck; what the hell now?* Adora was looking at her, feelings of shame at her earlier behavior blatant across her face. She did not try to stop Catra from pulling away, likely believing that the feline woman was somehow scared or disgusted by her. It pained Catra to see, but she was struggling with her own issues at the moment. As she processed, she realized addressing hers could solve both their ills. But what do you do when you like something that your partner doesn't? *She doesn't know you liked it, dumbass. Start there.* Catra pushed through her fear; honesty had been working for them for the past couple days, so might as well keep up the streak. "I was gonna say, that was my favorite part…"

Everything around the two women halted into eerie motionlessness. Adora lost the ability to gauge time; truly most of her cognitive abilities had been temporarily stunned at Catra's admission. Realizing she quite possibly had been blankly staring at her for several minutes, if not hours, she cleared her throat. "Oh."

"Yeah."

Adora's head was spinning. *That* was her favorite part? As she reflected, it shouldn't have come as much of a surprise; the feline's entire demeanor changed the moment it happened. She became utterly docile and downright pliant. It was as if Catra suddenly existed solely to please the blonde, a thought that gave Adora equal parts thrill and unease. She never wanted to control Catra, but the enthusiasm at which she had stepped into the role was at least enough to give Adora pause. "I really don't know what to say to that. The hair pull was your favorite." She let the words roll around her mouth; a deep, unexplored part of her psyche crowing in delight at the possibility they held.

"It wasn't just the pulling itself but it was more… just you taking charge? You were really, I dunno, possessive of me. It was just incredibly hot…" The tip of her tail unfurled itself from her waist, flicking back and forth.

Adora's eyes followed the motion of her girlfriend's tail, as her brain was left to do its best to process this new information. It wasn't necessarily uncomfortable for her to hear; in what universe would Catra calling her hot be a negative? And she wasn't judging her for feeling the way she did, either. But it was also a whole lot to take in at once about a topic that brought new parts of herself and her partner to light. "Possessive? I don't… Was I? And you *liked* it?"

"Adora, you literally said, 'You're mine.' and that's what pushed me over! Yes. I like being yours. I like you *taking* what's yours." Her ears lowered as Catra tried to work past her knee-jerk reaction to begin throwing out verbal barbs to compensate for her fear. She was scared of being judged, frightened she might be rejected or even jeered at. Adora wouldn't do those things but… The anxious mind could be the real terror sometimes. Catra had spent enough of her life trapped by her insecurities; the needling whispers that urged her to keep her true feelings locked away tight lest they be used against her. That path had only brought pain and misery. Communicating her needs and wants, especially with her partner, was her second chance and she intended to seize it.

"Oh."

The pair sat in thick silence. Adora began to speak slowly, still figuring out exactly what she wanted to say, but knew she needed to try to communicate her thoughts. "... I don't like hurting you." That wasn't all she had to say on the subject, but it felt important to get that out right at the start.

"It didn't hurt. Not really." Catra's tail continued to swish back and forth nervously, with her gaze trained forward, too embarrassed to look Adora in the eye. "The opposite…"

"Oh." Another pregnant silence followed.

Catra crunched into a tighter ball and spoke into her knees. "You're making me feel like some sort of freak here." Finally, she exposed the raw, bloodied heart of her distress.

Stop being dumb and frozen; you're scaring her! Adora quickly moved beside her girlfriend and wrapped an arm around her. "No! You're not a freak. I'm just… I don't even know where the urge came from, honestly. I'm not a violent person! Right? I mean, I'll do what needs to be done but… Ugh. I mean, to grab you like that just to, y'know, get what I wanted faster… It, uh, makes me nervous to admit and talk about because I just wouldn't have guessed that about myself? I really don't know where it came from." Her anxiety was making her stomach clench wildly. Gulping thickly, she pressed herself forward. "But it would be pretty hypocritical if I totally shut down on you; I wanted to know. *Want* to know. It just is also kind of a lot? Especially since there's other stuff that came to me to do to you…I just don't want to say too much. Or the wrong thing! This is all so new, Catra. I don't know." She removed her arm from Catra's shoulder, holding her own hands together tightly.

"Like what other stuff…?" Catra's face was still pointed downwards into her knees, but her tail had come over to wrap itself around Adora's arm. Her consternation at being perceived too closely and spurned as a result weren't exactly gone, but the need to offer some comfort to a fumbling Adora was stronger. Even more pronounced was the pull to know more about these impulses her girlfriend had had earlier.

Adora remained quiet for a few breaths, willing herself to answer her partner's question. As she worked up the courage, she twisted her fingers into themselves with great apprehension. The motion continued incessantly until she felt the solid weight of Catra's tail beat against the top of one of her hands. Despite her anxiety and the tension overall, she smiled slightly at the tactile reminder to calm herself and also stop irritating the love of her life with her nervous tics. It was enough to right Adora's mind, at least for the time being. Catra was always enough for her. "Umm, a few different things… Like bite your neck hard and, um, t-tear your shirt off. Oh and I, uh, I sort of wanted to slap your ass? Heh."

A single golden eye peeked out from where it had previously been hiding and regarded the nervous blonde carefully. "So, why didn't

you?" She felt the rumble of a purr wanting to begin in her chest. *That's even hotter than her saying she liked when I went down on her.*

"Uhhh, kinda felt like things we should talk about beforehand? I mean, Catra, I don't know what I'm doing here. And where does any of that even come from!" Her hands began to wring together again of their own accord.

Catra turned herself to face Adora and put her hands between her love's nervous ones. "Stop, babe. You keep saying that. Does it really matter 'where it comes from'? They were thoughts, nothing more. At least for now..." She laced her fingers in between Adora's twitchy ones and gave a reassuring squeeze. "You're totally right, probably best to not completely experiment without a check-in first. It's like what you said earlier, in your rambling, round-about way, if we don't talk about it, how do we find out what works for each other and what doesn't?"

Adora nodded her agreement, not trusting herself to speak yet. Though she was being validated, her heart was still thumping in her chest wildly. *I'm not a violent person… But all that stuff is just so aggressive. Why does it appeal to me?*

"So here's me being completely, one hundred percent honest and open. I liked when you took charge. A lot. I liked when you were possessive of me. Which, really, if you think about it for just two seconds should not be surprising at all to hear. I mean, just the shit from the last few years could fill a whole book, but even back when we were kids… I hit Lonnie *hard* for just trying to be your friend. Being yours and only yours is kind of a thing for me; always has been."

Seeing her girlfriend smile despite herself, Catra continued on. "Did I actually ever apologize to her for that? Or to you for scratching you after! Ugh, I was such an ass; 'Never gonna say I'm sorry'. How did you put up with that shit?" Catra paused for a moment to chew the inside of her lip, wondering where she might be able to track down the Horde's most famous throuple and give

its leading lady a firm apology for the many, many transgressions over the years. "But I'll show that little punk... Adora, I'm really sorry I did that to you."

"Catra, I forgave you a long time ago. Like, immediately after it happened. We were just dumb kids doing dumb stuff; can't expect us to have had rational reactions. But thank you for saying it." *She's changed so much; I might have grown to love her back then, but it's a drop in a bucket compared to how I feel for her now.*

Not sure I deserved forgiveness so quickly; dumb kid or not. But Catra figured the best way to earn it was to continue to be as open with her perfect girlfriend as possible. "Anyway, got *way* off track here... Hearing you say things like 'you're mine' and just generally being a little forceful is a huge turn on. You're so fucking strong, Adora, and I love seeing it. And the thought of like, experiencing your power firsthand is just… I don't really understand it fully either, but I'm also not questioning it too deeply. Because I know you'd never actually *hurt* me, hurt me. To steal a certain someone's line, I'm totally safe in these hands." She brought Adora's fingers to her lips and mimicked the tender kisses the blonde had performed on her own.

Adora's nerves stilled somewhat at the softness of her girlfriend's lips against her skin. "I appreciate your honesty. Your directness. At least one of us isn't a *complete* idiotic mess with this stuff." As Catra continued her display of affection, each kiss allowed Adora's mind to function and process at a more normal baseline. A lot of what Catra was saying made sense, but there was still so much that would need discussion. "Er, I have some follow-up questions if that's okay?"

"I mean, sure, but I'll remind you that I've had just about as much time with this as you have, so might not have great answers." Catra shrugged, pulling her lips away from Adora's skin rather regretfully. She wanted to be able to give her full attention to whatever was weighing on the blonde so heavily. *Probably gonna benefit from it later though, if this all goes well.*

“The things that I thought of doing when we were... when I was, y’know, to you…” Adora was already feeling tongue-tied. Not exactly the position she had wanted her tongue to be in compared to earlier in the day, but maybe she’d have a chance later. If she survived this.

“When we were fucking? Adora, you really need to take a breath here.” Catra placed one hand on her sternum, a grounding presence Adora could focus on. “We’re just talking. Like we agreed we’d start doing at least sixty percent of the time as real adults? And it’s just me, babe. You can talk to *me* .”

“Right. Right, of course you’re right.” She cleared her throat and focused on the calming pressure of her girlfriend’s hand on her chest and on breathing steadily. “I mentioned wanting to try a couple different things. Is there one that sounds better than the rest to you…?”

“My top pick among the hypothetical ones you threw out? You really are a little obsessed with favorites right now, love.”

“Just wanna make it as good for you as possible.” Adora offered weakly, knowing truthfully she just didn’t want to choose *wrong* .

“Appreciated. I mean, none of them would be the wrong choice; I don’t think at least. Bit hard to say when we’re not actually in the moment… But I guess you slapping my ass sounds pretty appealing.” Catra gave a little half-shrug, as if agreeing to something as plain as their evening meal. Internally, her heart was racing at the prospect, but she couldn’t appear too *eager* .

“Oh…” A flicker of annoyance crossed Catra’s face, obviously unimpressed by the continued use of a mere, unsatisfactory ‘Oh.’ The casual way Catra had stated such an action made Adora’s throat dry instantly. She swallowed thickly, thoughts overwhelmed with images of her hand on Catra’s ass; caressing, grasping, and… “Ahem. Okay. Um, noted. And are you saying you’d want me to do things like this… every time?”

"Well, I don't know. No? Maybe?" Catra placed her head on Adora's shoulder, loving the way she fit so naturally there. She sat with the question for a moment, then decided to trust her gut instinct. "Probably to some degree, but I haven't really thought that far ahead on it. We've got one time under our belts, babe, we don't need to figure it all out right now. You asked my favorite part and I delivered. But to summarize again: I promise you that I liked it, it did *not* hurt, and stuff like it is something I'd really like to explore in the future. Together and in ways we're both comfortable with."

"Okay… It's not a 'no' but I just need to think about it. Figure out how I feel about it when I'm not ridiculously turned on." *Even though the thought of doing it does make me ridiculously turned on.* Adora tried to not get lost in the weeds of her brain, resolving that she would think things over and they could revisit this in the future.

Catra nodded. "That's fine, babe. Everything we did was amazing and I can't wait for more. So even if you decide it's not gonna be a thing for you, I know we'll still have a great time. Don't stress too much over it." She wrapped her tail around Adora's waist, suddenly very aware that she was against her bare flesh. "Mmm, there's only one thing about what you said that just isn't going to work for me."

"What?" The panic was clear in Adora's voice.

"You, not being ridiculously turned on." Catra bracketed her hips to either side of Adora's. She gestured down to the bottoms she'd hastily thrown onto herself in the preparation to flee. "Really, this also isn't working for me any more. But I'll let you decide what direction we go; more clothes or did you want to continue to take advantage of your naked Catra viewing privileges?" Her chest rumbled in delight of putting the decision in her girlfriend's hands. *Choose for me, princess. Whatever you want; though pretty sure I can guess.*

"Oh. Naked, always. Yes. Yes, that's always going to be my choice for you." Adora nodded enthusiastically, her eyes bright.

"Hmm, always? Sure is going to make Bright Moon a lively place. Everyone's eyes on your girl…"

Adora stilled, trying to tamp down the irrational jealousy she felt from picturing *other people* eying her woman. Especially that much of her woman. However, when she envisioned the pair down at breakfast, Bow, Glimmer and Micah stunned by Catra's presentation, she laughed heartily and the green-eyed monster in her was instantly defeated. "Hey, now. That's not fair! Don't ruin naked Catra time for me."

"You're laughing? I'll give you something to laugh about." She flashed a knowing smirk and kissed her deeply, nipping and pulling at her lips. Just when Adora had really started to get into the motions, Catra leapt from her lap, leaving Adora as a flushed and panting mess. Catra then took great care to slowly shimmy out of her bottoms, letting the fabric ease down her body, delighting at how fixated the blonde was by the action. She wished fervently she had more clothes to remove, just to be able to watch her girlfriend's reaction to her stripping. Adora's eyes widened as the view she was presented with grew more and more uncovered. She stepped out of the shorts, kicking them behind her with no regard as where they landed. She wouldn't be needing them any time soon; her love had chosen, wisely, to enjoy her special privilege and she wasn't going to let her down. "Mmm, that's better. Now, perhaps I can make it up to you? Since I'm just so mean with the way I tease you."

Adora's eyes did not leave the sight of her bareness. It was all so exciting, especially the way Catra had made it into a show for her. That really upped the whole experience to a different level. *The things this woman does to me…* She flushed, then spoke with a low voice. "No. No more teasing. Here. Now." She pulled Catra back on top of her, kissing her firmly as she positioned them where she wanted them to be. Catra smiled into the kiss briefly, but allowed herself to be drawn in. She tried to let her hands

roam over the blonde's body, but felt her wrists being grabbed and pulled away from their expedition. Adora gave her bottom lip a sharp bite, quickly licking over the spot to soothe it. "Uh-uh, none of that. It's your turn."

"My turn? Is that how you think this goes; we switch off every time?" Even as she broiled; immensely turned on at the way Adora had spoken to her, handled her, and physically barred her hands from doing what they wanted to… A small part of her mind laughed as well. *That would be so Adora; everything has to be fair and equal.*

"No. I'll tell you how it goes. I want you, so it's your turn." She quickly flipped the pair over, as Catra breathed in a deep, shuddering sigh. Steel blue eyes met two toned ones. "You're *mine* , after all."

No part of her was laughing now; there was only merciless need as she lay under Adora, exquisitely and deliciously trapped. "I do love when you listen." Catra laid her head back in quiet surrender as Adora trailed kisses down her neck and collarbone, hands working over her breasts as she did so. "I'm yours, Adora. Take me." She felt a new rush of want course through her body as she uttered the words.

Adora began to make her way down the lithe body, only pausing in her descent to kiss Catra's toned abs thoroughly and run her hands over her sharp hip bones. As much as she wanted to take time to really enjoy her girlfriend's body in full, her overwhelming desire for a specific part of that body was the far greater urge. Adora spoke from low on Catra's torso, making her intent known more than asking for permission. "I want to taste you."

She moaned at the words, scarcely able to nod her agreement to the blonde's desire. Satisfied at the wordless acquiescence to her will, Adora then lowered herself to the floor, spreading Catra's knees apart and placing her thighs over her shoulders. She took in the view with voracious delight; savoring each enticing fold and

curve of this area she knew was hers and *only* hers to experience. "I can't wait to get you against my mouth."

Catra whimpered, wanting nothing more than to press herself against Adora, but also relishing the way she was being so carefully appreciated by the only person she truly craved attention from. Still, her need for relief was quite pronounced, apparent by the slickness and heat of the area Adora was examining. "Then what are you waiting for?"

"Admiring the view. Naked Catra privilege and all. You rushed me the first time." Adora moved her face slightly closer, enough that Catra felt every breath against her quite acutely. "Also want to make sure you *really* want it…"

"I do. Please, Adora. Fuck me. Please."

"Your begging is still really hot. Let's add that one to my list of likes." Adora chuckled somewhat viciously, enthralled at the rush of power she held in this situation. Catra wanted it badly and it was completely up to her to decide when to give it. The sense of control was like no other.

Catra bit her lip, knowing this had to be delayed punishment for her earlier impatience. While yes, she could in theory just move herself mere inches and be met with some needed friction, the possibility that Adora would then choose to pull away and not satisfy her need was far too abhorrent to her. So instead, Catra waited, letting Adora have her fill as she simmered in near-misery.

"You're being a surprisingly good girl here." Adora cooed, turning her head to kiss the inside of Catra's thigh. "Just letting me take my time."

Catra bit her lip, gasping at the light and teasing touches. But it wasn't enough, she needed more. "You can take whatever you want from me."

"Such a very good girl…" They both groaned at the first full stroke of Adora's tongue against Catra's pussy. Cleaning her own fingers

after working Catra's clit earlier was a bare wisp compared to the piquant, intoxicating taste that rolled through her mouth now. Adora allowed herself to explore the entire stretch, thrilling at the way Catra had jolted and moaned as her tongue lightly lapped against her opening. She moved upwards to focus on her clit, but Adora had no doubt she would be back to Catra's center very soon, intent on filling the woman entirely.

Catra was almost completely gone at the first graze of Adora's tongue against her. It was only through sheer willpower that she held on, not coming undone instantly. She wanted to lose herself for as long as possible in whatever sensation Adora saw fit to provide for her, be it sweet bliss or even succulent pain. She would surrender herself completely and accede to the will of her partner, knowing whatever choice was made would be one that put her pleasure and comfort first.

With her mouth still lavishing against her clit, Adora very slowly brought her fingers up, lightly tracing her way along Catra's inner thigh and lifting her chin to better position herself. Catra continued to moan and writhe at the relentless laps of Adora's tongue against her. She was oblivious to where her girlfriend's fingers were headed, entirely lost in the ecstasy the rapid flicks ignited within her. It wasn't until Adora's fingers began to tease at her entrance that Catra realized what the blonde was up to. "Oh, yes, yes, yes. Inside, please Adora, I want to feel you inside me!"

Adora chortled roughly, pulling her mouth away temporarily from the beseeching woman. She wanted to get into the best position possible before she obliged her lover's pleas. Catra whined at the loss, bearing her hips down to try and regain contact. "Patience, kitten. You know I'm going to take care of you." She stopped hovering and gently slid a single digit into the woman, pausing part way to allow the receiver to adjust to the sensation.

Catra gave a sharp, gasping breath as Adora eased into her. "Oh fuck…" Her voice was a half-choked whisper, saturated with ragged lust.

Adora exalted at the sound, satisfied to no end that *she* was the cause of such desperation. She began to pump her finger into Catra more readily, curling against her front wall, the tight heat of her feeling so impossibly good on her hand. "Catra, you feel amazing…"

"Feels so good." Catra panted out. As astounding as it already felt, she was certain this was the mere cusp of the pleasure her lover would coax within her. Wildly impatient at the prospect, she jutted her hips down to try and encourage as much of her girlfriend's finger into her as she could possibly take. "You're so fucking *good* , Adora."

Adora flushed at the praise, only encouraged further. She followed the suggestion her girlfriend's hips made and increased the pace at which she worked; instantly she was rewarded with a low moan of approval from Catra. "I love being *in* you." She slipped a second finger inside, quickly followed by a third, awed at the ease of which Catra was able to accept it.

The feeling of fullness Catra was experiencing was sublime. Whatever Adora would give her, she would take time and time again, a fact she solidified with a keening wail and fevered bucking of her hips.

"I love tasting you." Her fingers thrusted and curled inside her tight pussy with renewed vigor, matching Catra's zealous rocking of her hips pace for pace. Her forearm burned at the exertion, but every gasp, moan, and whimper was more than enough fuel for her to continue. She would only stop when Catra was done. Wanting nothing more than to bring Catra to her sweet release Adora brought her mouth back to her clit, sucking and thrashing her tongue in concert with her hand.

At the contact of Adora's tongue back against her, Catra's hands flew into the blonde locks, grasping and pulling frantically, an uncontrolled mess at the duel sensations orchestrated within her. The edge was imminent, Adora masterfully pulling her closer and closer with every stroke. "Gonna c-come…!"

Adora gave a deep, near-feral groan of satisfaction at hearing those words, increasing her efforts until she was granted with the feeling of Catra clenching tightly around her fingers, clit pulsing against her tongue. She eagerly lapped the fresh wave of wetness into her mouth, savoring the flavor as Catra loudly cried out her pleasure.

With great care, Adora slowed her movements, gently working Catra through the aftershocks of her release until the woman's tension eased entirely. She slowly slid her fingers out, wincing at Catra's low whimper from the discomfort of the loss. Both women were panting heavily, Adora resting her head against Catra's now entirely limp thigh. She took in the beautiful sight of her entirely spent girlfriend basking in the aftereffect of the orgasm Adora had brought her towards. *I love her so damn much.*

A short while later, Adora rejoined Catra on the bed, wrapping her tightly in her arms. "Mmm, so that was pretty fucking great." Adora could not wipe the smug smirk off her face, certain and confident of the unquestionable pleasure she'd given Catra. "You have an okay enough time?"

Catra gave a throaty laugh, feeling utterly exhausted, and charmed by her love's cocksure attitude. Adora deserved to boast a little after that performance. "I suppose you could say I'm pretty damn well pleased." She pulled herself even closer to her self-satisfied lover and allowed herself to be lost in the afterglow of her release. She ached, but it was a delectable kind of burn, a reminder of Adora's intimate presence in her. Completely taken by the woman; was there a better state of being?

"Good. I live only for your pleasure." Adora was laying it on rather thick, giddy over the experience they'd just shared together.

"Do you now?" Catra rumbled in delight at the prospect, even if it had been delivered with a joking cadence. "I'm guessing that means you'll do whatever I want?"

Adora dropped the teasing tone, certain her words were not just playful banter but irrefutable truth. "Basically, yes. Whatever you want, I'll make it happen." *I'm just as much yours as you are mine, kitten.*

"Hmmm, intriguing. If that's the case, I'm hungry. Work on getting me more salted fish. Think Sparkles does home delivery?"

"Hah, maybe if we had an easy way of getting in touch with her. She'd probably gripe, but pretty sure she'd end up doing it." Adora smiled, picturing the fit of outrage her best friend would throw before dropping the basket off and teleporting away in a huff. She shook the image away, suddenly all business. She *needed* to meet all of her love's even most minute whims. "You want fish? I can fish."

"Have you ever *been* fishing before?"

The skepticism in her girlfriend's voice was almost enough to make Adora dash out to the nearest body of water immediately. *Questioning my ability, love? Hmph. I'll show you.* "Well, no. But how hard could it be? Fish are in the water, use something to get fish out of water, make Catra happy. Easy!"

"Oh, my Adora. My sweet, simple Adora…"

"I'm choosing to believe you mean simple as a good thing here. Because insulting your provider's intellect is not a good way to get food in your belly."

"Why, of course, baby. How else could I mean it?" Adora was certain if the feline were facing her, eyelashes would be fluttering in mock innocence as Catra spoke. "But seriously, Adora, you do not have to go fishing for me. It's not a big deal; we have plenty to eat here."

"Would having fish for dinner make you happy?" She spoke evenly, not allowing room for any more quips.

"Well, yes, but--..."

“Then consider it done.” Adora gave a small kiss to Catra’s head. *Anything for her.* It was as simple as that.

Chapter End Notes

Your comments and kudos astound me. Thank you all.

It's good to be back. Hope you enjoyed. <3

Barehanded

Chapter Notes

> All my targeted ads on my various devices are now fishing related, thanks to this chapter. The things we endure for our art...
>
> I know many of you were really anxious for blonde jock fishing antics, so hopefully I've provided well enough for you. Thank you all so much for your continued support of this work; the kudos and comments bring me life.
>
> Enjoy!

It was with some reluctance that the pair dressed and left the house to scavenge something for their evening meal. Adora had encouraged Catra to stay inside and relax, but the feline woman scoffed at the offer. “Like I’m really going to miss the show.”

“Well, first and foremost, to catch fish we need to find some water.” Adora nodded her head resolutely, as if speaking some great, wise truth about the nature of the world. She led them around the perimeter of the house and through the fallow gardens, looking for some sort of tool shed or maintenance house. She reasoned that a property such as this would have had a team to care for it in its heyday and that seemed a logical enough place to start looking for fishing gear. And even if she struck out, she could always She-Ra something into existence. “Which actually serves a double purpose in that having a reliable water source will be important for when the citizens that need to stay here arrive. Even better if it can be a managed food source too. Look at us; solving problems left and right!”

Catra laughed a bit unkindly as Adora made her statement. “Sparkles was making that shit up, babe. Little perv just wanted to get us into bed together; no one needs to set up camp here.”

Adora remained stubborn, grounding into her plan all the more at the mocking chuckle. "We don't know that for sure. What if we, or any of our friends, need a place to stay someday? Especially after we go exploring in space! If we meet another Prime out there, I want a secure secondary base. This house could be it."

"Uh, I know we were all quick to agree with your 'Bring back the magic to the universe' plan after everything, but I'd like to propose a counteroffer. Let's stay here on this planet, safe and sound, and fuck as much as possible for the rest of our lives." Catra's tail flicked lazily as she offered this far more appealing course for their future.

"... I really hope you're joking right now because I was dead serious. It might take us a while, sure. Darla needs some serious boosts before we think about going anywhere, at least from what Entrapta said. But you do picture doing more with our lives than that, right?" Adora gave her girlfriend a concerned look, eyebrows arching together. *She's kidding; just being snarky Catra...*

Catra grew uncomfortable, taken aback by the question. *No, not really because I never even expected to live this long, let alone long enough to care about 'doing more with our lives'.* "I mean, I don't know. Is it really that bad? I think we've earned some peace and quiet after everything. And a life with you… That's kinda all I've ever wanted." Her ears were flat against her head, tail now wrapped around her waist. Her voice most annoyingly had chosen to crack as she spoke. She cleared her throat, forcing her voice to come back with a coolness she did not really feel. "Sex is just a new, added bonus."

Adora took her hand as they walked, giving it a gentle squeeze to reassure Catra of her sincerity. "And you know I want that too. I meant what I said earlier, Catra; a life and a home with you is definitely endgame for me. But I'm also not completely done with adventures. When I think of planets like the one the Star Siblings call home it just… I have to try and fix it. I couldn't be content with just living my own life knowing I might be able to make such a difference for others."

"But when does it end, Adora? We don't even know how many planets are out there! Entrapta goes on and on about how space is like infinite and ever-expanding. Considering the topic is practically a fetish for her, I'm inclined to believe whatever she says about it. I'm not sure this is a problem you *can* fix, babe."

"I'm not sure it's one we can ignore, either." Adora paused her search around the grounds and pulled Catra into an affectionate embrace, holding her tightly. "This is all future stuff, love. It's important, but doesn't have to be solved right now. What does need to happen is feeding you, which means I need to find water. You still wanna come or…?" She trailed off, glad to see at least most of her girlfriend's huddled body language had loosened. But still, Catra might need some time to think things out on her own. They were still close enough to the house she could easily turn back.

"I go where you go." *Even if that's a cold, void vacuum and every alien planet along the way.* Catra's tone left no room for disagreement. She might not be thrilled at the prospect of interplanetary adventuring, but any life without Adora by her side simply wasn't one worth living. She'd learned that lesson the hard way and wasn't looking for a repeat in this lifetime. She sighed heavily, unsure if her budding headache was from hunger or the stress of this fruitless conversation. "Let's just go find a stupid lake or river or whatever. Find out if you have a career as a fisherwoman while we wait around for the chance to traipse about in space again."

Adora very carefully made a note to avoid any more conversation about potential interstellar travel, at least for the time being. It really wasn't necessary to discuss and might just lead to more fighting or fleeing attempts. She replied mildly, still holding her girlfriend's hand as they walked. "The Salineas docks are probably hiring. Mermista does have to rebuild the export business of her kingdom's goods again. She might even put in a good word for me. Maybe."

“Err, I’m your girlfriend and I kind of wrecked her kingdom, multiple times. Wouldn’t depend on it too much.” Catra resisted the urge to bury her face in her hands at the consequences her past self had sown for her current self. “But guess if you’re working the docks, I can try to fix what I destroyed… Not sure I’ll get paid for it, but it needs to be done. Actually, I think that needs to happen no matter your vocation. Remind me to get in touch with her once we’re back. Just… miles away from any amount of water. It’d suck if she drowned me before I could make any repairs.”

“She would learn quickly to not drown She-Ra’s girlfriend.” Adora’s tone came out far darker than she meant as she grasped Catra’s hand exceedingly tight, lacing their fingers together. The sea princess’s reaction to Catra’s presence in their lives hadn’t been even remotely amicable, much to Adora’s extreme vexation. How could someone make amends for their past if they weren’t given a chance? “Very, very quickly. If she tried to hurt you in any way...”

“... This is getting to be a lot of really depressing and, um, charged topics.” Catra enjoyed the fierce protective vibe her girlfriend was radiating, especially since it came from just the mere *suggestion* of harm against her. But this coldness, especially towards a friend, also just wasn’t her Adora. “Uh, you still up for fishing, Princess? Because we really can just eat back at the house.”

Adora took a moment to inhale, shaking her head clear. “Yeah, I’m good. Think I found what I was looking for anyway.” She gestured towards a large shed a slight ways off, noting a pile of wood stacked along the side of the building. Recalling the fireplace in the front room of the house, Adora chalked the wood up as a great find on its own and resolved to bring some back to the house on their return. “If there’s any gear for fishing on property, it’ll be in there. I think.”

“Eh, sounds reasonable enough.” Catra shrugged, leaning against a conveniently placed tree nearby. “Go investigate and let me know what you find.”

As Adora began to walk towards the toolshed, the lounging feline called out sweetly towards her. “Oh, but Adora?”

“Hmm?”

“Just making something clear right now. She who catches the fish, cleans them too.”

“Ah. And I’m guessing Miss Prissy Paws isn’t going anywhere near the water when we find it? Nevermind trying her hand at catching her own dinner.” Adora really hadn’t thought through *all* the steps that went into a fish dinner. Suddenly ‘fish in water, get fish out of water, make Catra happy’ didn’t seem quite so straightforward and easy.

“Not a fucking chance, babe. I’m going to observe only, since you said you wanted to do this to make me happy. This was your idea entirely; I just get to reap the benefits.” Catra flashed her a rascally smile. “Hop to, we’ll be out of daylight soon.”

The shed turned out to be well stocked with various tools and all the gear to maintain the ample grounds. She had guessed correctly, as Adora did find a large net she suspected was used for the catch of the day once upon a time, as well as a flexible pole and reel. She draped the long, heavy net over one shoulder, pole in one hand, and a bucket to hold her cache in the other. As she went to exit, she noticed an open lidded box that contained various hooks and brightly colored dangly bits. Her knowledge was limited at best, but she did at least understand hooks were an integral part of ensuring the activity’s success. With some difficulty, she snapped it shut and balanced it in the same hand that held the pole. Fully equipped, she finally exited the building, calling out to her girlfriend excitedly. “Catra! I was right!”

Her girlfriend’s tail flicked in amusement as she regarded the wannabe fisherwoman, crossing the small stretch to join her once again. “Where’s your dumb floppy hat to keep the sun off? Seems you managed to find every other part of the getup in there.”

“Hmm?” Adora was half-listening, focused on not dropping her gear as it jostled precariously about in her hands. “Hat?”

“Nevermind, babe. Just- here,” Catra took the pole from Adora’s hand, much to the blonde’s relief. She still had the bucket and box to carry, not to mention the netting slung over her shoulder but not having to contend with the pole on top of everything was so much better. “So you don’t break anything or yourself along the way.”

Adora nodded her thanks and considered a moment before offering her elbow out for Catra to grab. “I don’t really have a hand right now but… afternoon stroll, my lady?”

The feline woman smiled at the gesture, rolling her eyes, but took the arm that was offered to her nonetheless. “You are such a dork.”

Picking a direction away from the house more or less at random, the pair soon found themselves walking through a serene meadow, surrounded by tall trees and rolling hills off in the distance. Adora was a bit preoccupied to fully take in the natural luster of her surroundings, but was grateful for them all the same. The pristine setting made a surprisingly peaceful backdrop for some of her more colorful thoughts- musings that centered around Catra’s favorite part and their subsequent discussion of it. Her feelings on the matter were numerous but as a whole... positive.

It did not take long for them to find a river, its course hugging the outside of the meadow. The current was slow and the opposing banks were a surprisingly short distance from one another. A running leap and Adora would be able to clear it easily. Her dexterous girlfriend likely wouldn’t even need the headstart, not that she would ever bother to do so. They followed it down a short ways more, finding that it emptied into a good sized pond.

It was here that Adora decided to set up operations. She laid out her equipment on the grassy bank, examining it thoroughly to

check for any quality issues. After she was satisfied by the condition, she turned to the body of water to scrutinize it carefully. With her thumb on the bottom of her chin and index finger over top, she stared intently, strategizing. “Hmm.”

Catra watched the gears of her girlfriend’s mind turn. “Well, dear, here’s the water. You said that was ‘first and foremost’. So what’s next?”

“I use these,” She gestured absently towards the gear laying on the ground near her feet, “to catch fish.”

“... Exceedingly astute, my love. I’m stunned you were able to figure that out as I was entirely lost. I thought you would use your hands to pluck them from the water.”

Adora ignored her girlfriend’s sass, more intent on examining the mouth of where the pond and river met. Decent sized boulders jutted out on either side, more or less parallel to one another. She glanced at the net, noticing the longer lengths of rope at edges of the top and weights along the bottom. “Aha!”

Without a word of explanation, Adora hoisted the thick net into her arms and strode to the edge of the bank. She tossed the net over to the opposite side, backed up a few paces and then vaulted over the sleepy river. Catra merely watched in quiet observation.

Once on the other side, she picked up one end of the netting and secured it to the boulder. She made certain her knots were tight; though the current was not particularly strong, she didn’t want to risk having it come undone on her. Satisfied by her work, she picked up the other end, cleared the river once more and set to work on tying the remaining side.

“Any reason you tied the other side first before this one?” Catra asked lightly, arms crossed over her chest. “Seems like throwing it over there entirely was just a way to flex a bit. Not that I’m really complaining at the reminder that you can throw heavy shit and all.”

"I didn't want it to get wet while I jumped over. You know, be floating half in the water."

"... You know that answer makes absolutely no sense whatsoever, right? Because this side or that side, it still hung out in the water for fifteen seconds as you jumped and also it's *designed* to be used in wet conditions."

The blonde shrugged. "Does it matter then? This side or that side, just like you said."

"I suppose not, Adora. Ya got me there."

Adora finished tying off the end of the net, certain that her idea of stringing it along the mouth of where the river met the pond was pure brilliance. She watched the gentle current flow in between the lattice work of the net, the motion causing it to billow out horizontally like a windsock. "There! If the fish wanna get out of the pond they gotta go through my net first. Hah!"

Catra stared at the rigging impassively. "Couldn't they just swim under it?"

Well," Adora was crestfallen for a half-second at the question. Then her face set with a cheerful, unperturbed smile. "There did seem to be some small anchors to kind of weigh it to the bottom and help hold it in place. It's my best guess on how the darn thing is supposed to be used, anyway. It should get the job done, I think."

Catra watched her girlfriend cross over to the remaining gear and transport it closer to the water's edge, near the widest part of the pond. She settled herself down next to everything, bringing the pole across her lap and idly looking through the contents of the tacklebox. Without looking up, she motioned for Catra to join her. "C'mon, sweets. Come sit with me."

The feline was vaguely annoyed at the distracted invitation, but gave in, plopping herself down onto the ground with a slight huff. Her eyes flicked over to see Adora trying to thread a hook onto

the end of the line, tongue poking out of the corner of her mouth, and brows furrowed in fierce concentration. She could see the frustration clear on the woman's face after she failed several times to secure the lure to the thin line. "... You do know this activity requires patience, right? Something you don't exactly have an abundance of."

Adora blinked, focus broken momentarily. She sighed at the still incomplete task in her lap before trying again. "Okay, yeah. Maybe I'm not the most patient person out there but I *am* determined! And I have a net *and* a pole so... double the chances, double the speed! I got this, babe. No sweat."

"Uh-huh. I'm sure that's exactly how this works." Catra laid back into the soft grass, each blade bending under her body to create a cozy bed. Nestled against the sweet smelling earth with the sunlight gently warming her fur, her eyes closed almost instantly as a gentle rumble stirred in her chest. "Wake me when you're done with all this."

Eventually, Adora was successful in getting the hook and lure attached to her line. Feeling victorious at yet another step in the process being accomplished, she glanced over at Catra basking in the sun. The sight confirmed her resolve to do anything to make her gorgeous woman happy. She gave a lazy flick of her wrist, satisfied by the small 'plop' that sounded as the line sunk down into the water.

It wasn't that she expected instant results. But the longer Adora sat with the fishing pole in hand, waiting for anything even remotely interesting to happen, the more dissatisfied by the lack of *any* results she became. She considered trying to strike up some conversation with her beloved, but Catra really did seem to be dozing. With a soft sigh, she turned her attention inwards to reflect once again on bedroom possibilities and pass the time. Unsurprisingly, that was a whole hell of a lot more engaging than fishing could ever hope to be.

“Any luck?” Catra didn’t even bother to open her eyes, knowing the answer already.

“Hmm?” Adora had been entirely lost in her thoughts. Not that it really mattered since fishing was just so boring. She could not believe some people did this for *fun.* “Not even a nibble.”

“What’d you use for bait?” She could feel Adora’s eyes on her. She opened her own, confirming that her girlfriend was giving her a most puzzled look. “Adora, even a dumb fish isn’t gonna bite metal without something to attract it first.”

“Oh… Well, I kinda thought the dangly thing attached to the hook would do the trick. Like the fish would be all, ‘Oh, what’s this pretty thing, let me just put my mouth on it.’” She cocked her head to the side. “Otherwise what’s the point of it?”

Catra stared at her for a moment, astoundingly choosing to not to bring up a pretty thing Adora could put *her* mouth on. “You could be right; hell if I know. Fishing’s dumb.” Catra yawned and stretched, an indulgent smile lazing on her lips as she regarded her girlfriend before shooting her a pointed look. “Though getting to nap in the sun has been nice. Especially since someone and her fingers took quite a lot out of me earlier…”

Adora returned the look with a bashful smile and small shrug, flickers of overwhelming pride making her attempt at graciousness a true challenge. “Happy to be of service.”

Catra turned over on her side, facing Adora. With her arm propping her head up, she appraised her girlfriend thoroughly. “Mmm, how long before I be of service to you again? It occurs to me that I never repaid the favor before we ran out for this thrilling adventure. The fish might not be biting right now, but I certainly could be…” She allowed a single fang to peek out from her lips.

The blonde gulped in response, nearly dropping the pole from her hand at the offer. “Uhhh, I’m not saying I’m not interested, but

I’m barely used to doing it in bed. By the pond just seems really, um, public. Later though?”

Catra gave a small shrug, turning to lay on her back once more. “Whatever makes you comfortable, babe. But while you’re thinking over the other things we discussed in that department... different locations could have some *real* possibility.”

“I’ll add it to the list.” Adora replied faintly with a shallow nod, turning her gaze out towards the pond again. It was one thing to talk about those kinds of things right after or right before, when they were all alone, but they were out here in the real world. What would the birds and bees have to say if they overheard? “I’m, uh, gonna go check on the net. See if we have any progress there at least.”

Catra smirked, a little enchanted by the rosy cast on her girlfriend’s cheeks, certain it was not from the beginnings of sunburn. *Blush all you want, my innocent angel. I know how you* ***really*** *get.* “Of course, Adora. You can leave the pole here; I’ll watch it for you.”

“Watch it do nothing.” The blonde grumbled, brushing non-existent dirt from the seat of her pants as she rose. At the net, she was dismayed to see that her query remained uninterested in being caught. She began to pace the perimeter of the pond, wondering exactly what key component she was missing. She could *see* the shadows writhing under the surface, taunting her with their lazy swirls. Why were they refusing to be caught?

Adora racked her mind, pulling up all the past exposure she had to this activity. It was a commonplace thing to do; a manageable way for the citizens of the world to get a fresh source of protein. The methods to do so were as varied as the people that performed them. In the sea kingdom, large nets were thrown off fishing trawlers to draw up huge schools at one time. Lads and lasses in the Bright Moon territory might cast a line tied to a stick into the creeks that ran by their villages. Even Frosta had boasted of her citizens' proclivity for fishing in the depths below the ice

that covered her kingdom. Her people used heavy-handled spears to pull great creatures up from the frigid waters, the fiery snow princess assuring everyone that she'd been partaking of the activity herself since she was six years old. Though of course she made her own spears out of thick ice for the task.

She'd tried netting, the pole remained useless… So without another thought, Adora brought forth She-Ra's power to create a long, wickedly sharp spear.

At the scent of magic, Catra was instantly roused from her nap. She regarded her girlfriend and the newly-created weapon in her hand. "I don't know what the hell this is, but I swear if you stab yourself, Adora…"

"I'm not going to stab myself! I don't think I need to remind you that I carried a sharp sword just fine for several years, almost no incidents." Adora huffed as she heard Catra mumble ' *Almost* no incidents?' before pressing on, ignoring her girlfriend's quip. "Only the darn fish are gonna get stabbed today. The snow kingdom people do this all the time. I can see the shadows swimming around down there, so if I time it just right…" She closed one eye to focus her view, tip of her tongue once again peeking from the corner of her mouth, and zeroed in on the swirling shapes in the water below her. She brought the spear up and over her shoulder, picturing the victory of finally capturing one. With tremendous force, she swung the spear down, ready to see one of these bastard fish kabobed on the metal point.

Her form was perfect, as was fitting for an individual who had trained all her life in the art of combat. However, what she did not take into consideration was how images underwater were distorted, their distances deceptive. As the spear sunk heavily into the silt and muck layering the bottom of the pond, Catra laughed uproariously at her girlfriend's failed attempt. Her laughter came out even harder when the momentum of Adora's thrust being stopped so suddenly by the muddy earth caused her hands to slide down the handle of the spear, quickly throwing her off balance. She nearly toppled headfirst into the water, saved only by

rapidly throwing back one leg and her arms out to her sides. Her limbs wobbled dangerously as she fought to regain equilibrium.

"For a moment, you actually looked like you knew what you were doing! Such a mighty fisherwoman with her big, sharp spear." Catra cackled with glee.

"Oh, just be quiet, you." Adora pouted at the sight of her girlfriend, doubled over in laughter at her expense. She tugged at the lodged spear, determined to try again. "I'm doing this for you, remember!"

"Me or your pride, babe?"

"... It can be two things!" She finally freed the instrument from the bottom of the pond, sighing disgustedly as it dripped water over her boots upon its exit. Adora waved the object out of existence before sinking to the ground, minutes away from a very uncharacteristic temper tantrum. "This is just ridiculous! I can *see* the damn things down there, why can't I catch them?"

Catra got a hold of herself and tried again to reason with the blonde. "Adora, babe, let's just head back, okay? It's wonderful you went to all these lengths and all, but it's really not that big of a deal."

"No! I've invested this much time into the whole thing already. So there's no way am I giving up until that bucket," She pointed angrily at the metal container, as if it were to blame for her lack of success, "is full to the brim. Or at least not completely empty! I *will* catch a stupid fish for my beautiful girlfriend who I love very much." She crossed her arms over her chest, the picture of willful obstinance.

Catra resisted the urge to break into hysterical laughter again over the grade-A hissyfit happening before her. She really hadn't seen Adora throw a snit of this magnitude since the day that Lonnie had bested Adora in a footrace, outlifted her on the bench press, and pinned her to the mat during a sparring bout within seconds.

As she continued to recall the events of Adora's cantankerous mood that day, Catra wondered if the bloody nose Lonnie was granted from Adora's fist later on was *really* because she had pulled Catra's tail or if it was delayed revenge from her multiple defeats. Her love did not accept loss graciously. Though, to quote Adora, Catra reasoned it could indeed be two things. "I love you too, ya stubborn pain in the ass."

The blonde continued to simmer on the ground. Catra had just been about to rise and go to comfort her when with no preamble or warning, Adora transformed.

"Why the hell is She-Ra here?" Catra's fur prickled uncomfortably with the change and at the feel of magic permeating the air around them. She was glad to be some distance away.

"Don't want my regular clothes to get wet." Adora as She-Ra grumbled out in a terse, unflinching manner. Piercing blue eyes caught Catra's multi-hued ones for a breath before the warrior strode a few lengths away from the pond and halted.

Catra blinked owlishly, the synapses in her brain unable to connect what her girlfriend's explanation could possibly mean... until she saw all 8 feet of legendary warrior rush forward, jump into the air and swan dive into the middle of the pond. Her tail poofed out at ten times its normal volume as the column of water from Adora's splash rose high into the air, raining down on the land around it. Catra did not think she would be in Adora's splash zone today, but really that was her own fault for not taking the time to *think* like her girlfriend. It was just such a scary place to go. "I swear, Adora, I'm letting you drown if you crack your head open on the bottom!"

Adora stayed submerged in the pond for long enough that Catra's ears began to twitch with concern. Suddenly her mean-spirited jest about letting her girlfriend drown after smashing her head open on a rock didn't seem to be the least bit funny in the light of it possibly being true. The feline faced her great loathing for water and clamored to the edge of the pool, eyes scanning for any sight

of her love. Just when she thought she'd be next into the pond, bright, billowing locks crested the surface, resplendent in the sunlight.

Adora shook out the enviable strands, flicking them backwards and out of her face. She turned to regard her wide-eyed girlfriend, corner of her mouth tugging up in amusement at the sight of Catra being mere inches from wading into the water. "Ready to join me, I see."

Catra scrambled away from the edge, hissing out, "Wet idiot…"

"I thought you liked it when I was all wet…"

"Oh, very funny! Didn't know She-Ra was a comedic genius. Thought all the rippling muscles were her best feature." The feline hugged her knees to her chest, tail encircling her body as she willed her heart rate to steady. She scowled, waves of adrenaline still surging through her body at the thought of losing her moron to a watery demise.

" *My* best feature. The muscle *and* the wit is all mine, babe!" Adora called out with a smug smirk before diving back down under the surface. When she emerged again, she held aloft a beautiful trout high above her head. "And now victory is all mine too!"

Before Adora could congratulate herself any more, the fish gave a mighty flap and extricated itself from her hands. It might have managed to escape were it not for the lightning reflexes of the warrior avatar that allowed her to snatch her prize back from midair. Before it could make any further attempts at freedom and with no real thought or consideration for the effects the action would bring, Adora flung the fish from her hands towards the grassy bank. It landed with a thud dangerously close to where Catra was hunched.

"ADORA! What the ***fuck*** *!"* Catra scrambled backwards across the ground, eyes wide at the aquatic lifeform hurtling towards her.

“The bucket, Catra, the bucket! Get it into the bucket!” Adora was flailing in the water, pointing desperately towards the metal basin as if without her direction Catra would have no concept of what the word meant.

“You are INSANE! I am *not* touching that thing!” Her tail was straight out behind her, frizzed from root to tip.

“Ugh, just use the edge to scoop it up or something! Put some water in too, the poor thing is gasping. It doesn’t need to suffer!”

“Says the woman who decided to *throw it* !” Catra stomped over to the bucket, then gingerly edged the miserable creature in, before returning to the pond and somehow managing to fill the container partway without losing the catch. She did not care about the well-being of a stupid fish that much, but Adora was so damn soft hearted about everything that it wasn’t worth the guilt later. “You do realize now that you’ve caught one, with your bare freaking hands because you’re a *maniac* … It’s gonna meet a pretty definitive end, right? Not exactly gonna keep it as a pet when we get back to the house.”

“Well, it doesn’t need to be tormented before that. Just… Ugh, I’m going back down for more. At least being a maniac is getting results, finally!” Adora made to dive back under the surface.

Catra placed the bucket at the water’s edge, not exactly in the most gentle manner. “Absolute idiot. I was *kidding* earlier about plucking them from the water. Ugh, fine! It worked but no more throwing! You can walk your ass over here and put the damn things in yourself.” She stomped away, muttering as many synonyms for the word ‘idiot’ and ‘asshole’ as she could think of. She positioned herself far away from the pond, facing away. “And don’t you *dare* talk to me again until you’re ready to leave.”

Adora continued her task until she had a number of sparkling, silver-scaled specimens in her bucket. Climbing out of the pond, she glanced over at her net set-up, somewhat dismayed to see it still had not yielded any results. Noting that the sun was

beginning it's gradual descent, she chose to leave it for now, promising she would return in the morning to clean up her mess.

For now she reeled in her line, even having the foresight to remove the hook lest painful tragedy befall her, and grabbed the box and bucket. Adora called out softly, knowing her girlfriend's superior hearing would pick it up. She really couldn't tell from this distance if Catra were truly angry or just needed to steam for a little while. "Catra? Um, babe? I think I got enough for us tonight and I have everything packed. We can go."

Her girlfriend's tail twitched in response, then she rose from her spot on the ground. She began to walk towards Adora again, before hesitating a short distance away. "... Can you clean them here? I really don't want it anywhere near the house if we can help it." She wasn't squeamish, not really, but it was a fragrant activity for someone with a delicate nose.

Adora was utterly relieved that Catra didn't seem to be actually incensed by her poor life choices. She admitted ruefully that she might be momentarily grumpy if someone had chucked a fish at her too. Determined to make up for her lack of prefrontal cortex planning skills in that moment, Adora nodded vigorously at her girlfriend's request. "Yeah! Of course. But, uhh, I didn't bring a knife." She stared down at the swimming trout in her bucket, wondering how she'd go about the task. For the amount of time and effort she'd put into this activity, they could have made it to Bright Moon and back with a whole barrel of already caught, cleaned, and salted fish for Catra's culinary pleasure. The thought made her grit her back teeth together.

"I'm always packing, but no way in hell my claws are being used for *that* ." Catra crossed her arms protectively over her chest, as if trying to hide her natural-born knives.

"I'd never ask you to." Adora said simply, keeping her tone neutral. She wasn't looking forward to the last leg of what had been a very long journey. She gave a fortifying sigh, reminding herself that this was very much the circle of life and that it was all

to make Catra happy. “Lemme just…” With a small wrinkle of concentration to her brow, Adora willed the magic of She-Ra to create a thin bladed knife.

Catra nodded her approval at the decision. “Be careful with that one too, dummy.”

Adora looked down at the creation in her hand. “… What do you think the weirdest thing Mara ever She-Ra’d into existence was?” She didn’t often think about the day-to-day life of the past rendition of the warrior avatar. But as she held the magically forged knife the thought struck her. It was a direct follow-up to her previous train of thought; had Adora been abusing her power all afternoon? She consoled herself with the reminder that everything made today was with the purpose of feeding them, so it really couldn’t be considered misuse. And who would dare tell She-Ra off anyway?

Catra leaned back on one foot, arms still crossed over her chest. The scent of magic was burned into her nostrils by this point, so she supposed there wasn’t a real rush for her to exit the scene. Adora seemed a little subdued, so she decided to try for shock with her answer. “No idea, babe. You met with her once, I guess you could say. She seem like the type to strap up?”

Adora glanced up from her instrument, a genuinely perplexed look on her face. “Uhhh, I’m not… Sure what you mean?”

“... The sex list just writes itself, doesn’t it?” Catra arched a brow before striding forward, tail twitching in amusement to give her lamb of a girlfriend a small kiss on the cheek. She had to pull at Adora’s shirt to get her to bend down so she could reach, as tall as she was as She-Ra. Catra was pretty proud of herself for that choice; facing the uncomfortable spark of magic to show her girlfriend some delicate affection. “Nevermind, Adora. I don’t want to overload that brain of yours with *too* many new things at once.”

Adora stood up straight, eyes suddenly wide. “Oh! Wait, you mean… Uh, gosh, I don’t even know if she had a girlfriend! Or

boyfriend, I guess. Though probably won't need *that* if it was boyfriend, um, I think."

Her girlfriend snorted at the reply, glad her love wasn't completely unfamiliar with the concept of strapping. "Or maybe had both at one time or another, if not both at once. Or maybe preferred to keep to herself. She might have used it to cook something up if she got too… lonely."

Adora consciously chose to not respond at that point, not really wanting to entertain that train of thought any more than she already had. She glanced at the contents of her bucket and steeled herself to get it all over with. "Best get this done."

Catra disappeared off a ways, knowing she'd smell the scent of fish innards and magic no matter what she did, but not wanting to be right by the source as it happened, either.

The grisly work completed, Adora once again used the legendary power of She-Ra to create a new object, this time into a spade so she could bury the leftover refuse of her task. She washed herself off as best she could, glad that at least she hadn't transformed back into her normal form. At least her everyday clothes would be clean and dry.

The pair returned to the house, Catra loping off ahead to keep ahead of the bucket. She had at least taken the tacklebox from Adora's hands. When the shed came into view, Adora waved Catra to head inside and freshen up as much as she wanted. "I promised you a fish dinner, so I'll even do the cooking."

"I'll draw you another bath tonight, even keep you company during- from a very dry distance." Catra trilled at the prospect, the chance to care for her love after Adora had worked so hard to provide for her today.

Adora gave her girlfriend a grateful smile at the offer before she raised an eyebrow. "And I'm sure it's entirely altruistic in nature, not because you'll get to see me naked."

Catra's ear flicked. It was a real upside to the whole thing but... "Ah, uh. You know, normally I would be all the chance for some sexy banter, pre-gaming for later, if you will. But the aroma of blood and other stuff is a bit much right now, so, yeah I'm mostly focused on getting you clean."

"I hate fishing."

"You never have to do it again. We'll buy our fish at the market like normal people."

"Promise?" Adora flashed her great doe-eyes, bottom lip threatening to jut out and tremble.

Catra endured the overwhelming attack on her olfactory nerves to close the distance and slot her forehead against Adora's for a moment. "I promise. Never again." She left for the house after a quick grasp of her tail on Adora's wrist, hoping it was enough to show her appreciation of all her girlfriend's efforts for now.

As Catra refreshed herself inside, Adora returned to the shed to gather several large armfuls of wood and used it to get a merry campfire going fairly close to the house. Just in time too, as the sun had almost set entirely. As the new scent hit the edge of Catra's perception, she peeked her head out from the front door. "Fire?"

"I only know how to cook over an open flame." Adora shrugged, rolling the efforts from the long afternoon from her shoulders. "Any chance you can look for a heavy bottomed skillet with the longest handle you can find? There's not really a rush, I need to wait until these logs burn down into coals, anyway." Catra nodded her agreement and headed back inside. As an afterthought, Adora called out for her to also bring some salt and other seasonings, if Catra could find anything. Though she did not hear a reply, she was confident that her girlfriend had heard her.

Catra did indeed catch the request for flavor enhancers and as well as cookware, bringing everything Adora asked in short order.

The pair sat by the fire's glow as the night settled in earnest around them, watching the wood burn down to hearty embers. Adora seasoned the fish generously and positioned the pan against the coals, trying to ensure they covered the bottom evenly for the best cooking results.

The burning pine logs and baking fish masked the traces of the more unsavory aromas from earlier. The sensitive feline was well pleased, as she cuddled up tight against her love. They made small talk as dinner sizzled in the pan, Adora periodically checking for cooked-through flakiness.

Dinner was more than satisfactory and having no other side dishes to accompany it, the pair also opted to imbibe in the plum wine left from Glimmer's dinner basket. The sweet alcohol danced on the tip of Adora's tongue as she basked in the pleasure of knowing every frustrating, dull, and disgusting task had been well worth this ending. Especially after a number of long, slow kisses under the moonlight.

After the fire had been extinguished and tamped out, Catra made good on her promise to draw Adora a relaxing bath. As the blonde stripped her clothing off in their bedroom, Catra refreshed her love's glass of wine and made sure the water in the tub was hot, though not scalding.

She returned to the bedroom briefly, inquiring about which bath oil Adora wanted to use tonight. The blonde just shook her head, heading to her bag to fish out her choice and hand it to Catra to place in the bathroom for her. "Regular, plain soap tonight. I need to scrub more than soak. It's unscented too; your nose has been through enough this evening."

Catra smiled at the consideration, and after preparations for the bath were complete, settled herself in on the counter across from the tub to make good on her promise to keep Adora company as she cleansed the hell that was fishing from her body.

Adora entered the bathroom and sighed contentedly at the scene, the towel around her dropping instantly to the floor. Catra watched with feigned neutrality, though her tail lashed wildly behind her at the sight of her girlfriend's bare flesh in the moonlight. The blonde stepped into the water, sinking down slowly and moaning extravagantly as the hot water melted her tension.

Catra's claws lightly scraped against the marble counter. "What do I need to do to get you to sound like that for me?"

The blonde gave a half-smirk, not bothering to open her eyes or look towards her girlfriend as she gave her reply. "Your mouth sucking on my clit again is a good start."

Claws dug a little deeper into the countertop, punctuated by a sharp hissing inhale. "Rest up tonight, princess. I want you ready to go first thing in the morning, at your best."

"Funny. I was going to tell you the same thing." Adora raised a single brow and gave her signature smirk before submerging her head entirely to finish bathing before bed.

Competition

Chapter Notes

Hello, friends! It certainly has been a minute, huh? Here's a nice smut-filled chapter to show that I'm still here, still working, even if sometimes life (and depression! Woo!) get in the way.

Also, I must state quite plainly that this chapter would not exist without my very good friend itcanprobablysmellfear. Please, please if you have any love for yourself and great fics, read her work. She is a master in all she does (especially the amazing Knight Adora/Princess Catra AU she has going https://archiveofourown.org/works/27519097 or maybe indulge in the Top Dom She-Ra smut fic we did together https://archiveofourown.org/works/27690290).

As always, thank you for your comments, kudos and patience. Please enjoy!

"Yes, Catra! Oh, you make me feel so good…" As Adora panted her way through the results of her girlfriend's tongue exquisitely lavishing against her first thing in the morning, she resolved to make morning sex part of their schedule as frequently as possible. Granted, she really only had experienced morning sex thus far, but she was convinced it was something truly special. Was there really a better way to start the day than with a mind-bending orgasm?

Catra gave one final swirl of her tongue, intent on lapping up every last drop of sultry nectar from her girlfriend's perfect pink folds while delighting in the full body twitches and soft cries that came from her final inspection. Reluctantly, she pulled her mouth away and rested her chin atop the blonde's thigh. "Hmmm, not *quite* bathtub noises. It seems like I'll need to keep trying and do better."

Adora groaned in delight at the prospect, an arm slung over her face as she sought to reenter this plane of existence from the place of pure ecstasy her girlfriend had just delivered her to. After several moments of ungainly gasping, she managed to formulate a response. "I'm not sure that's possible, but please, please, *please* try."

The feline gave a satisfied grin, tail flicking behind her lazily. She idly traced the tip of her claw along the inside of her girlfriend's thighs, the faint touches bringing out more meek whimpers and breathy cries from the blonde. Incentivated by the sounds, Catra removed her head from the top of the muscular leg, admiring the view in front of her with absolutely no shame or hesitation. "Mmm, I see what you mean about begging now, princess. It's very hot." She licked her lips, wondering how much build up there would need to be before she could go back to fucking her girlfriend into insensibility.

Adora didn't necessarily mind that some rather needy noises were being drawn out from her *again* . The barest contact of claws all over her as Catra stared so lavaciously at her cunt was a major turn on, no question. But the fact of the matter was this morning wasn't going to be just about Adora getting off. She pushed past her achingly pleasant fatigue to sit upright, wanting to make certain the full weight of her words wasn't lost. "Don't get used to it. I'm way too hooked on turning you into a crumbling mess beneath me, begging me to fuck you."

"Mmmm… Hooked so quickly? No real complaints here." Catra purred, leaving her spot on the floor between Adora's legs to return to the bed and have easy, full access to her body. She settled in next to the blonde, Adora's arm immediately wrapping around her and pulling her close. Catra rested a hand against the woman's bare chest for a moment before dragging across the skin there as she had done to her thighs. Adora moaned at the contact, her hand digging into Catra's sharp hip bone, the other bracing herself as she enjoyed feeling the feline's hands across her tits. Catra snickered at a particularly sharp gasp, quickly bit off as to not show complete desperation, that had come when she

flicked her claw tip across one hardened nipple. “You know. We did say we were going to spend all day fucking in bed yesterday before someone got aspirations to be an angler.”

Adora bit her lip at the tart pleasure, but quickly rolled her eyes at the reminder of yesterday’s watery activities. “Only to make you happy. But still, ugh. I made a terrible choice. I hope the meal was good, at least.”

“Very, very delicious, love.” Catra nodded her affirmation, before turning her face into Adora’s neck and kissing along there slowly. She delighted in the way Adora shivered at the brush of her lips, was besotted by the goosebumps that decorated her skin. She could hear her love’s breath quicken, Adora’s hand leaving her side to squeeze her ass and encourage her to continue. She worked her way down the blonde’s neck to her collarbone, a trail of marks illustrating her journey. Catra’s hands slid from Adora’s breasts, coasting along the blonde’s well defined obliques. She halted a moment to appreciate the taut planes of her girlfriend’s abs. Really, had she not been so dead set on bringing Adora to close again, she might have pushed her backwards to rock savagely against those hard muscles and offer herself some relief. She did indulge in a few kisses and nips of the flat, hard stomach before continuing to move down Adora’s body, finally ending with her hand over the nest of blonde curls. She spoke, pressing lightly with a small circular motion at every word. “But I do think we owe each other that day of sex.”

Feeling sensitive from her release just moments ago, not to mention from the steady stream of kisses and caresses her very attentive girlfriend was bestowing on her body, Adora was already breathing heavily at the furtive brush of Catra’s hands against her. She thought of drawing attention to the fact that she was using her hand at all, but decided better of it at the last minute. It could still be a sensitive subject, though Adora did make a mental note to praise the woman thoroughly at how good it felt after they were finished. Instead she reached up and let one hand drag down her girlfriend’s furred torso, the other still cupping her ass. “Mmm, I think you’re right. Lay back.”

Catra gave her a half-smile, purring lightly at the feel of Adora's blunt fingernails along her. She pressed in a little harder against the blonde. "Why should *I* lay back? I'm definitely not stopping what I'm doing here." She flicked her middle finger back and forth against Adora's clit a few times, satisfied at the jerk the woman's hips gave.

Adora shut her eyes for a moment, letting the ripples of pleasure from Catra's staccato pulses wash over her. She certainly wasn't opposed to the idea of being worked again, but she could feel the slick heat radiating from her girlfriend's center. She *needed* to get her hands on her as well. "You won't. Lay down on the bed, Catra." Her tone left no room for disagreement, no matter how playful.

The feline purred harder in appreciation of her girlfriend's definitiveness, lowering herself backwards obediently. As soon as her back hit the mattress, Adora's lips were against her own. Catra gave a shuddering sigh as she yielded easily to the biting kiss. She felt so deliciously enveloped by the woman; the taste from taking Adora moments before was still so present in her mouth, joined now by her girlfriend's tongue as well. One of Adora's hands were moving across her breasts, playing and pinching as they sought to bring her fever even higher. As if eating her girlfriend out first thing in the morning and then running her hands all over her hadn't been enough as it were.

Adora continued to tease the brown peak, rolling it between her thumb and forefinger as she sucked on the brunette's lower lip. Catra's lower back was already arching off the bed as she moaned into the dual sensations her girlfriend was performing on her. Adora grinned into their kiss as she felt the feline woman bend towards her touch, before readjusting to lay on her side, still above the other woman. Once in the position she wanted, Adora stopped her ministrations against her girlfriend's chest to bring her fingers onto the heat in between her legs. She met the area with confident motions that made Catra's breath hitch and her hips twitch. Catra could not be more thankful that Adora was such a quick study, someone determined to excel at all she did. The

blonde's sure, perfectly positioned fingers would make quick work of her; in response, she slid her two fingers between Adora's clit, feeling the bundle throb all the more at the real contact.

Catra's legs were spread wide, giving Adora the most beautiful view to watch as she stroked through her folds while Catra glided through her own. The sight was just as incredible as the sensation of her girlfriend's skilled fingers; the view of her own digits as they rubbed Catra's dripping pussy coupled with every reaction across the beautiful face that each flick of her fingers coaxed out. Catra's eyes were closed, eyebrows knitted together, the rambunctious short curls delicately framed against her perfect cheekbones. Her mouth was parted slightly as a litany of short breaths escaped her kiss-swollen lips. After an intentional pull of her fingers to bring out the utmost pleasure Adora could offer to her love, the panting was replaced with a near reverent chanting of Adora's name. Two toned irises opened, seeking to be reminded of the steel blue ones above her, the ones belonging to the woman who was taking care of her so intimately and expertly.

Despite being so lost in her own pleasure, Catra's hand never faltered. Adora's hips rocked back and forth to the rhythm set against her swollen clit, every masterful swipe threatening to push her over the edge once more. With supreme effort, she held back her own climax, wanting nothing more than to finish with the woman she loved so desperately. Adora moved her head from resting against the other woman's to trailing a line of kisses down her jaw. "You feel so good, Catra. Your fingers are amazing; you're going to make me come again." Catra whined in response, rocking her hips into Adora's hand faster. She increased the speed at which her hand rubbed Adora's clit, eager to again hear the beautiful woman next to her cry out her pleasure. "Ah, ah! Yes, fuck… I want you to come with me. Tell me how to get you there."

"Mmm. Bite…!" The feline woman stretched her head back, her neck an offering to the woman who was bestowing such infinite pleasure on her. Adora wasted no time in following the order,

sinking her teeth in with zero abandon and sucking what she knew would turn into a gloriously dark bruise. She held nothing back, determined to mark up the woman's neck and collarbone, her fingers still unwavering against her. Catra's entire body seized the moment the blonde had latched on with her teeth, the spike of pain mixing with the ecstasy happening between her legs to create an intoxicating blend that nearly had her hurtling over the edge. "A-Adora!"

The white hot tendrils of Adora's release began to claw low in her stomach at hearing her name cried out so filthily. She refused to let it wash over her, needing to bring Catra to the edge first. She briefly removed her fingers from that aching bundle; the small whine of protest at their absence quickly turned into another sharp cry of her name as she slipped two fingers into Catra. The feline froze for a second at the entry, a cross between a sigh and deep rumbling purr emanating from her chest, before rocking her body down fiercely on the digits filling her up so completely. Adora pumped vigorously in response, letting the heel of her hand rub against her clit as she thrusted, her girlfriend quickly reduced to a mess of harsh, short breaths below her. "Catra... Catra you're so beautiful." And she really was, the sheen of sweat glistening on her fur setting off the rising suns and making the whole woman look like she was on fire. She moved her mouth to the other side of Catra's throat and with a moan bit into as-of-yet unblemished skin.

Adora's fingers curled into the perfect angle as her teeth devoured her neck, and Catra was undone. With a scream, her body abandoned her and she was overtaken by wave after wave of mind-numbing bliss. Her hips slammed upward into Adora's touch, chasing the siren call of her orgasm, following whatever path it would take her, so long as it would lead back to the woman she loved. She felt Adora shudder above her, the two syllables of her name spilling from the blonde's lips with so much devotion tears pricked at the corners of her mismatched eyes. The feel of her girlfriend's cunt slamming and spasming around her fingers just drove Catra deeper into her climax, the knowledge that they brought one another to ruin nigh-simultaneously ripping an

unbridled scream from her lungs. As it vibrated up her throat and echoed around the room, she hoped Adora could experience it through the bite, could not only hear, see, smell, and feel her come around her fingers, but also taste it off of her skin.

Adora dropped her head to the mattress, still panting heavily as she lay on her side. Her hand had settled on Catra's thigh; the fur there matted with slick and sweat. As soon as she was able to move, she would rise to fetch a damp cloth to clean her love off. Just a few minutes were needed to rest and recuperate. Catra lolled her head to the side to face her, crooking one side of her mouth upwards to show her weary bliss. Her mismatched orbs were mostly shut, but impossibly soft as they caught glimpses of Adora's own sleepy blue eyed gaze. Adora pulled their foreheads together, giving a shaky sigh as her body came down from its peak. Was it permissible to feel this absolutely, undeniably happy?

"How was that?" Adora asked the second she had enough breath to form words. "I know that was on the list of stuff we discussed and all but..." She looked a little sheepish, her brows furrowed with concern. "I didn't bite you too hard, right? Something just took over me and I… needed to mark you." She buried her head into the pillow, face inflamed with embarrassment.

Catra pulled back on Adora's shoulders, forcing her to look her girlfriend straight in her blue and gold eyes. It was a little difficult; her lungs hadn't caught up from her orgasm just yet. "Adora. I *asked* you to bite me. I wanted you to, and I *really* enjoyed it, okay?" Thoughtfully, she fingered the largest of the marks, shivering as the tiny wisps of pain gave way to the enthralling memory of how ferociously the blonde had adorned her flesh. Adora frowned when she saw Catra's fingers trace the outline of the bruise that had come from her mouth. She scanned her face intently for any sign of pain or discomfort, but found only a dreamy look of pure contentment. Catra gave a shuddering sigh paired with her widest smile. "Just more proof that I'm yours…"

Adora relaxed her jaw, returning with a beaming smile all her own. “Was it ever a question?”

Having caught her breath a little more, Catra laughed softly, kissing the corner of her girlfriend’s mouth. “No, but I like the reminders.” The pair lay face to face a few moments longer, breathing in each other’s air. The magicat broke the silence with an arch of her brow. ”So. That’s two for you, one for me. Looks like I’m winning.”

Shaking out of her post-sex haze, it took Adora a moment to realize what it was that had her love chortling in satisfaction. When it clicked, the sensible part of her mind reminded her that it didn’t matter how many orgasms they brought one another to, it was the act that was far more precious and important. A physical expression of their love, a chance to experience an intimacy like no other. The loud, competitive streak in her shoved all that gooey nonsense to the side and bristled at the comment. Adora tried for a balance between the two in her reply, as best as she could manage. “Maybe *today.* But overall? We’re even.” *For now at least…*

“Nope,” Catra popped the p in the word rather obnoxiously as she tucked an arm behind her head with a devilish grin, settling back against the mattress in pure comfort. “Fuck overall numbers. I’m going for daily records, babe. So, need a nap or a snack first before we go again and I pull ahead even more?”

In truth, a snack really didn’t sound like a half-bad idea; a quick break to refuel before they resumed the day's activities. Adora shifted onto her back, staring thoughtfully at the ceiling above her. On the other hand, food was part of what had gotten them off track yesterday and she had an absolutely delectable woman lying next to her already. “Hmmm, I am pretty hungry...” At the admission, Catra removed her arm from where it was crooked behind her head, content to pause things in the bedroom and meander down to the kitchen for breakfast. It certainly didn’t need to be a whole production like the pancakes; she’d find something light and quick to feed her Adora then get them right

back to bed. She could never begrudge her beloved for needing nourishment. Catra began to sit up, her tail coming around to tickle Adora's hip and tease her that it wouldn't be breakfast in bed every morning, post-orgasm or not, so it was time to get up. But before she could get even remotely upright, Adora rolled over and pulled the magicat on top of her easily. She slotted Catra so that her drenched folds would create a pool of want onto her stomach. Adora had been taking note of the way her girlfriend drooled over her abs ever since the bare swatch of midriff had been presented to her during their first time. She placed her hands on either side of the woman's waist, tensing the muscles of her stomach before pulling Catra across them. "But I definitely want you more."

Catra clenched her thighs at the first swipe of Adora's abs under her; her brain needing a half-second to adjust back to the idea that they'd be fucking rather than eating. Though, as she felt the results of her girlfriend's disciplined exercise regimen beneath her-- a warm, hard area that she knew she could grind into just as roughly as she needed, it was not difficult to accept.

Adora dragged the feline over her stomach again, flexing extra hard at the pitious moan the action inspired. Fresh slick shone in the wake of Catra's pussy, and the blonde felt her mouth water at the sight. Never in her wildest, dirtiest dreams did she ever think her muscles would be used to such an end. She didn't think her imagination possessed the ability to craft this blissful image: her lovely girlfriend, pupils blown and hair tempestuous, rolling her hips atop her body.

"Mmm, you're definitely enjoying yourself." She said silkily as Catra slipped over the panes of her stomach. Her girlfriend gave a reedy whine in reply, continuing to jerk her hips down at a measured pace. "Thought of something that might make it even better for you…" Catra gasped as Adora tugged her hips down, pinning her in place for a moment. She didn't want to risk Catra coming undone before she could make her suggestion. "What if She-Ra came out to play?"

The magicat tried to continue her rolling motion, but quickly found it was in vain. Adora was just too strong. *And she wants to bring in She-Ra?!* Catra would be lying if she said the thought had never occurred to her; was there a person out there in the entire universe that wouldn't cash in on the fact their girlfriend could turn into a ripped, golden warrior on command *at least* once? It wasn't really where she was expecting things to go, but if grinding on Adora's abs felt this amazing, She-Ra must be nirvana. "Y-yes, but only for this. Change back right after I'm done."

Adora smirked, a nimbus of golden light surrounding her as a cascade of dazzling hair billowed out behind her. "Just gonna use me, huh? Take advantage of me and all my rippling muscles? I gotta say, Catra, I like it. Maybe if I'd offered myself to you like this before, we could have been doing this for *years* , instead of days."

Catra shook her head, ignoring the cockiness that just seemed to come along with Adora's transformation in favor of continuing her carnal bliss. Of course she was curious about how different it would be with She-Ra, but there was some general uneasiness as she watched her girlfriend shift into the legendary warrior. The tinge of magic tickled Catra's nose, but as it mixed with the aroma of Adora's arousal that so permeated the air around her, she found that she wasn't quite as bothered by it as usual. More than anything it smelled like Adora and there wasn't a scent in the world better than her girlfriend. Catra soon felt warm steel ripple beneath her and gave a full body shudder. Maybe it would be too much to ride against the legendary warrior, perhaps she should… At that moment, Adora shifted her to compensate for her now longer torso and Catra nearly forgot how to breathe. *So good* , it felt so impossibly good against those chiseled planes. She dug her hands into either side of She-Ra's powerful biceps to brace herself as grinded down ruthlessly.

Adora couldn't help but preen at her own ingenuity, congratulating herself for suggesting something like this even before Catra did. If muscles were a thing for her girlfriend, her other form could *certainly* provide. The woman above her was rigorously slamming

her hips down, so overcome with pleasure that while Adora could see her throat contracting, no sound was released. Despite the forcefulness of her movements, against the might of She-Ra her weight was a featherlight caress. With great care Adora brought her large hands up to the slender waist writhing above her to guide her love to the throes of absolute pleasure. To be overzealous with her hold and bruise the woman would be a crime of the greatest severity, though as Catra's claws pricked into the marble of her arms before retracting instantly, it seemed the feline woman was exacting the same amount of care with own grip. Adora warmed at the thought, drinking in the sight of her partner, her equal in all things. It was a privilege to witness Catra like this, to be trusted with this part of the feline woman she was enraptured with . She knew that She-Ra wasn't always comfortable for the magicat to be around; she was a reminder of strife, conflict, and loneliness. But perhaps this was just another step along the way to working through the damages of the past. Everything Adora had to give was Catra's completely and that included an eight foot tall blonde goddess for her to enjoy.

As Catra finished rocking herself through the waves of her release, Adora let She-Ra melt away for the time being. She was still upright as she straddled Adora's stomach, though panting heavily with her head thrown back and her eyes shut tight. Adora gulped as she felt Catra drip onto her stomach. It made her mouth water; she *had* to get a taste. "Come on, Catra. You're not done, not yet. You can give me another…" The blonde drawled out before pulling Catra forward over her waiting mouth. The magicat whimpered in anticipation, the feeling of Adora's hot breath against her sensitive cunt overruling any objection at being repositioned. She knew all too well what the woman beneath her was capable of. Catra lowered herself, thighs bracketing either side of her girlfriend's head. Immediately Adora roughly sucked her clit into her mouth, creating a tight seal around it. The magicat *keened* at the action; it was almost too much too soon, but with the way Adora's hands were digging into her hips, practically pinning her core down onto the blonde's face as her tongue flicked back and forth, Catra surrendered readily to wherever she wanted to take her.

Catra rode Adora's mouth with reckless abandon, rocking her body to meet every long stroke of her girlfriend's tongue. She knew she would not last long against the onslaught, already feeling the release coil in the deepest pit of her stomach. Adora's hands moved from her waist to cup her ass, supporting the magicat as she slid and rolled atop her. Catra put one hand back against the blonde's chest to give herself better purchase, threading the other through her hair. Adora licked and sucked, swirling her tongue frantically, doing anything to make the woman above her come undone. The release was swift, a dazzling crescendo of untold ecstasy. Perhaps she cried out at the top of her lungs, perhaps it came with the barest whisper of Adora's name; so far lost in the sensation rippling through her, she could not say. Catra went limp as the waves of her release washed over her, saved from falling entirely only by the blonde's sure hands against her back. She felt herself be moved once more, the press of the mattress welcoming her as muscular, soft-skinned arms cradled her closely.

"You're so beautiful, Catra. I just… can't believe that you're mine." Adora hummed as she ran her fingers through the spent woman's hair, a purr kicking up in her chest at the gentle strokes.

"Only yours, Adora." The magicat murmured before drifting off to sleep, safely nestled in her lover's arms.

"I've been thinking." The blonde began, after noticing the first few stirs of her girlfriend awakening from her short nap. She hadn't been able to tear her eyes away from the sight; Catra curled so peacefully in her arms as she rested. Morning cuddles after copious amounts of morning sex, that was actually the best way to start a day.

"About?" She replied with a yawn that exposed her sharp canines entirely. Catra's blue eye flicked open, noticing with a purr that Adora hadn't even shifted once as she slept. Powerful arms still held her close to the woman she so loved.

Adora's bravado faded slightly at the entirely expected follow-up, but she pressed past the quake of her nerves. There was nothing

to be skittish over; she knew how Catra felt quite plainly and after much reflection how she felt as well. "You know our sex list? The ass slap and different places to do it?"

Catra nodded, uncertain if two items really constituted a list. *I can add to that easily, though.* "I'm familiar, having suggested both of them. What about it?"

"I think I want to try." There was a slight cast of shyness to the blonde's tone as she spoke, but the unmistakable buzz of zealous anticipation far outweighed it. The subject had been rattling around continuously in the back of her mind ever since they'd discussed it. And with as well as the bite had gone over, she felt confident that more exploration couldn't possibly be a bad thing. Whatever they decided to do together and wherever they did it, it would be *theirs* . Could it really be wrong or scary if it was something between them?

Catra sucked in a greedy breath, instantly awake. She raised up on one arm to see her love more clearly, tail lashing wildly behind her. Sure, they'd just had amazingly dirty, hot sex that would definitely continue for the rest of the day if she had any say in the matter, but she had not been expecting this check in from Adora on their burgeoning list any time soon. It was enthralling to know such dirty thoughts had been in the back of her girlfriend's mind, nevermind she also wanted to *act* on them. Catra licked her lips as her chest boisterously rumbled out her interest. Adora chuckled at the excited purring, pulling Catra back down to kiss the tip of her nose. Somewhat embarrassed by the display of slight frenzy, she pushed down her vibrancy, though her tail continued to sway back and forth. She gave a long slow blink in response to the gentle peck against her nose, heart rate not slowing in the slightest but her zeal becoming more manageable at the soft display of affection. "Which one?"

"You know what we say about two things… It can be both." Adora gave a self-effacing lift of her shoulder, eyes flashing as she watched Catra's fervid reaction. Anything that turned her girlfriend on this much was definitely worth looking into.

Spoil

Chapter Notes

Happy New Year, folks! Enjoy a rather short (transitional) chapter as we move to put 2020 behind us, some of you may already be there, lucky things.

Thank you so much for your continued support; when I wrote this, I swore I would be happy if one other person read it. This community and this chance to express myself and my love of our shared fandom has made the year for me. I am humbled.

You may notice that there is now a final chapter listed; I don't expect that this journey will last more than three more installments. I have it mostly worked out and while I am sad to say goodbye to my first fic... All good things must come to an end. And it will only be this rendition of them for Catradora has a permanent residence in my brain.

Thank you again, friends. See you in 2021!

Catra placed a lazy, indolent kiss on her girlfriend's lips. "Morning, Adora." The blonde snuggled deeper into the blankets, scrunching up her face slightly at the noise. Catra chuckled softly at the face she made, running her hands through the flaxen tresses of her beloved. "Aww. Still all tired out, baby?"

Adora gave a small nod, before rolling on her side to bury her face in Catra's chest. She sighed deeply, the downy fur tickling her nose, but even her groggy self knew it to be the happiest, safest place in all the world.

"I'm not surprised with just how good you fucked me all day yesterday." Catra felt absolutely wrung out, but in the best possible way. Her body was one pleasant ache; a reminder of how

she belonged entirely to the sleepy woman curled up on her chest. They'd both stopped counting after Adora had hit number seven, Catra nine, agreeing that their *very* friendly competition wasn't the point of the day. Though they no longer kept score, that did not bring an end to the activities themselves; taking sporadic breaks only for quick bites of food, large glasses of water, and a plethora of cuddles. "I'm not sure I can go as many times again today, but who knows what you and your perfect fingers will bring out of me." She brought Adora's longest finger into her mouth, nipping at the very tip, afterwards rolling her tongue around to soothe any sting.

Adora groaned at the sandpapery flicks of her girlfriend's tongue. She could feel the stirrings of desire building within her and she wanted nothing more than to spend another day providing and chasing release after blissful release. *But that's not why we're here entirely, right?* She felt conflicted at the thought; uncertain of Glimmer's true intentions with this vacation-mission (Vacassion? Misscation? The words really didn't combine easily) as she was. She knew Catra's take, but she just really doubted her best friend cared that much about her life in the bedroom. Adora hoped not at least, she certainly didn't want to picture what the Master Archer and the Queen got up to during their alone time. Shaking her head off that uncomfortable subject, she realized with a sigh that regardless of the intent behind their time away from the castle, she had utterly *destroyed* the dining room. That needed to be addressed and days of ignoring it wasn't helping anything. "I hate that I am even about to say this, but… Real mission or not, I really should finish up cataloguing the pantry and clean up the mess I made."

Catra removed the digit from her mouth, her lips quirking up in a grin that was half-amused, half-incredulous. Adora couldn't seriously still be on about the so-called mission…"You're joking, right?"

"No, 'fraid not." Adora's mouth was a thin line; she really hated her sense of responsibility sometimes. "It's an absolute mess down there; Glimmer is already going to kill us for what we did to

that poor bed in the other room... I really have a bad track record with mattresses." After her post-fishing bath two nights ago, they had moved across the hall to the room Catra had originally started in. The pair had taken one look at the bed they'd had their first time in, with its ripped sheets and claw-marked mattress and both agreed that it was not fit for sleeping in any longer. Fortunately, they had their pick of places to rest and would deal with the mangled bedding another time.

Catra shrugged, utterly unconcerned by any collateral damage that came from their exploits. *Glimmer is the one that sent us here and she knew exactly what we'd get up to. Really it's her own fault.* "Let's just burn the sheets you tore up and we'll have She-Ra toss the mattress I shredded into the pond. Sparkles doesn't have to know a damn thing, babe. We just need to tell her that there was only a bedframe in the room and then the treasury replaces it for whenever her Royal Glitteriness decides she needs to vacation here or host a party or whatever. Problem solved."

"I am not going to put litter into the pond!" Adora exclaimed as she chewed her lip thoughtfully. It was bad enough she had destroyed another person's property but there was no way she would then trash part of the local ecosystem to hide the evidence. Still, she really didn't want to explain how she had managed to explode another bed. "But I guess I could break it down. Bonfire again tonight, babe?"

Catra nodded, pleased that her girlfriend saw the sense of her plan. She gestured around the bed they were laying on. "And look- we controlled ourselves during a whole *marathon* of sex yesterday. No ripped sheets from you and I kept my claws under control."

Adora considered for a moment, before nodding her head resolutely, coming to a decision Catra didn't know she'd even been at odds with making. "Well. Sounds like we need to celebrate our achievements."

"Did you have something in mind, babe?"

"Yup, several somethings." Adora gave her girlfriend a short, but powerful kiss that simultaneously managed to tell Catra exactly what those 'somethings' on the blonde's mind were, while also leaving her guessing as to the dirty machinations of Adora's mind. "That will all have to wait until *after* I get some work done. For now, breakfast?"

Catra hated to shower, but it was far more preferable to bathing and the only remaining option when her own personal grooming wouldn't do. Adora had offered to join the magicat to "make it a more pleasurable experience" and while that was certainly hard to say no to, she knew a guest would prolong the time spent under the stream of water exponentially. She also felt incredibly grimy, even if part of her mourned to lose the tiniest iota of the blonde's scent all over her body. *We'll just have to put it back later, won't we?*

While her girlfriend got clean, Adora threw together some form of breakfast. Yesterday had been largely scavenging through the boxes scattered about the dining room, looking for anything that could be quickly chewed and swallowed before they ran back up to lick, grind against, and finger one another for a few more hours. She wanted to spend a little more time today to actually make something that could pass as a meal.

While Adora busied herself with a box of quick bread mix and a container of assorted nuts (for scones? Muffins? A loaf?), a silken rasp like no other interrupted her culinary experiments. "Hey, Adora."

"Uhhh…" Adora gulped, eyes traveling down the length of her girlfriend as she appeared in the entrance to the kitchen. "H-hey, Catra."

"What's wrong, babe?" The magicat asked innocently, tail lazily swishing behind her. 'Take what I want when I want it' Adora was hot… But 'Transfixed and openly ogling my girlfriend' was its own special delight. It made Catra feel powerful and in control, but in a

way that she would instantly surrender over to the blonde. She was Adora's completely; to have, to hold, and to leer at.

"I just wasn't expecting you to be downstairs. Naked." She blinked once, then cursed herself for giving into the action. Adora didn't want to miss even a fraction of a second of the magnificent spectacle before her. How could Catra be *that* sexy when she was just standing still?

The feline woman purred as she sidled up to the blonde. "And why's that, love? I do believe I set up right at the beginning that naked viewing privileges weren't going to be confined to only the bedrooms. Plus," She hopped up onto the kitchen counter, tail coming around to tickle under Adora's slack jaw. "just allowing for baby steps in that whole 'new locations' discussion. You could take me right on this counter, for example." Catra stretched back, propping herself on her elbows and allowing the other woman to get a nice, long look. As she suspected, though Adora had spent the entire previous day learning every inch of her body, somehow seeing her unclothed self in a new spot made the blonde's brain unravel. It was like a brand new experience for her and Catra certainly wasn't arguing about the way those steel blue eyes were worshipping her body.

Adora was gripping the box of bread mix so tightly, her short fingernails had worn crescent divots into the sides. She licked her lips once, mind working in overtime to assess this new situation. She had agreed to opening herself up to fun times in other areas of the world and it really shouldn't be surprising that Catra was holding up her end of their viewing deal. "But. Um, muffins?" She held the box out for her girlfriend for inspection, as if needing her to confirm.

Catra swung her legs around so that she was sprawled out along the counter on her side. She arched a brow as Adora looked down at the box in her hand then back up to drool over the sight of her. "You're lucky you're so cute when you're flustered if you're choosing a baked good over this." She gestured down to her naked form.

"I'm not!" Adora supplied quickly, placing the box down, then picking it back up to stare at it again for a moment. She took a breath to compose herself, wanting to come across as at least halfway functioning. "Well, I guess kind of am. Look, just… give me an hour or two to undo some of the damage I did and then maybe we can see about other things? Like we said upstairs?" The magicat sighed. Part of her really thought that even her responsible girlfriend might rethink her plans once she saw Catra sprawled out in front of her. No such luck; Adora was determined to be productive and not seductive. "In the meantime, muffins!"

Catra slid off the kitchen counter, her face set into a snarl that Adora couldn't quite tell if it was serious or not. "I need you to know right now that *muffins* will never be an acceptable replacement for sex."

Adora grimaced at the acid, then set her jaw. "And I need you to know that your attitude isn't okay. I love you whole-heartedly, but you have to respect that I'm asking for a break. Catra, I'd love to spend all day in bed with you again, but I also don't know if I can *physically* handle that." She shuffled her feet; it was an uncomfortable truth for her. Her head might be all in, but frankly some rather sensitive areas were rather sore. She could just turn into She-Ra and be entirely healed, but that felt like cheating herself of what they achieved yesterday. Catra was just going to have to deal with her need to recuperate for a couple hours.

She dropped her tail, though it flicked back and forth once or twice. She knew another marathon might be a little excessive, but what was the harm in a quick dally in the kitchen? Still, if that's what Adora needed then that's what she would get. With a decisive pout to her lips that she quickly stowed away, knowing she was being utterly childish over the whole matter (not now did not mean not ever, after all) Catra mumbled out. "Cuddles at least?" Her golden eye flicked to the side as if afraid of the possibility her girlfriend might deny her after her less than gracious behavior.

"As soon as I get these in the oven, I will hold you all morning." Adora immediately folded her arms around her naked girlfriend, wanting nothing more than to ensure her. As she felt Catra's uncovered chest come into contact with her clothed one, her leg unconsciously snaking itself just a *little* too close to Catra's revealed core, Adora instantly regretted that she'd told the woman that she needed a break. Catra was a magnet she couldn't pull away from; her body illumined at the barest point of contact with the woman she craved. She ran her fingers down Catra's back, outlining her stripes and kicking up a purr of appreciation. "Then I really do have to work a bit, but you know, it would go a lot faster if you helped…" As hard as it was to still her hands, the truth of the matter was that they really needed to do things other than one another.

"I don't see why we can't just shove all this shit back into the pantry and move on with our lives." The magicat tried to offer, rubbing her cheek against Adora's collarbone. She could feel the woman's scent encompassing her once more, but she couldn't take the chance that her own had faded from her love in the short time they'd been apart. *I am hers and she is mine.* "Does it really have to be organized?"

"Yup." Adora released her hold after one more tight squeeze, trying in vain to absorb enough of her girlfriend that it would carry her through the dull labor that needed done. The subject really wasn't up for debate any longer. Hopefully Catra would help her and they could get some real progress in just a couple hours or she'd go at it alone.

At the succinct affirmation of the exact opposite of what she wanted to hear, Catra decided a resolute, firm Adora wasn't always a turn on. Though a few minutes later, after breakfast had been placed into the oven, when the blonde scooped Catra up in her arms and carried her to the couch for morning snuggles, the magicat knew she'd just been kidding herself at suggesting that Adora wasn't the sexiest person on the face of the planet. Possibly the entire universe.

After nearly two hours of tedium, Adora rose from the dining room chair, back protesting at being hunched over for so long. She twisted her torso in a side-to-side sway and stretched her arms a bit; the movements brought welcomed relief to her tense muscles. She vowed to never accept a desk job in her life. It was terrible.

Catra wandered back into the dining room from the kitchen, box to sort through in hand. Adora smiled at the woman, who rolled her eyes in response. After they had finished their morning meal, Adora announced that she was going to go work. She did not invite Catra to join her again, but when the woman appeared near her work site, now clothed, she felt a large rush of affection for her surly mate.

The blonde begrudgingly returned to her chicken scratch. Most everything on the shelves was expired or just off, so while their garbage heap was growing, the work was at least going quickly. Enough that her attention could wander as they worked. What an amazing past few days it had been. Adora had no expectations going in this endeavor, other than wanting the chance to spend time with Catra, though she smiled fondly as she remembered her past self seated in her office at the Castle, just hoping for just another kiss. *Blew right past that one real quick.* She really wouldn't have had it any other way. Being with Catra was amazing, but being *with her* ? How she'd denied herself such salvation and joy for so long was a wonder.

But even beyond the sex (though admitedly, that was hard to look past, as incredible as it was) the level of comfort she felt with Catra was just indescribable. They'd both shown some of the deepest, most bruised and battered parts of one another these past few days and somehow came out stronger for it. It was an assuasive commitment towards their relationship; a firm foundation that they could build life on. Perhaps, she gleaned, more than Glimmer worrying about their time in the bedroom, this whole thing was a chance for them to reconnect as people. To think there was a time, weeks worth of time, where they barely spoke to one another (outside the years of war that caused such a rift in their childhood promises, of course)... She couldn't fathom

it. Adora wanted to spend the rest of her life making it up to Catra for that time. It was a crime she wasn't sure she'd ever be able to wash her hands of, but damn if she wouldn't try every day.

After long quiet moments between the pair as they did their individual tasks, Adora once again paused her work. "How is it even after I do something with the thought of you in mind, *I* still end up the one with the romantic moonlit baths and morning sexy times? I feel like I've barely done anything for you the past few days. Well, I guess some pretty okay orgasms, one paltry dinner, that came paired with an embarrassing show as I tried to fish."

Catra sputtered, nearly dropping the box she was emptying. "Are you kidding me? Maybe you're just looking for compliments here, because you seriously can't be questioning what you've given me. 'Okay' orgasms? If they were any better I might blackout!" A faraway look entered her eyes, wondering if in fact it could be any better. It didn't seem physically possible. She shook her head to clear it. "Besides, Princess, I like taking care of you. I was a piece of shit for so long; I have a lot to make up for."

"But I like taking care of you too! And don't say those kinds of things about yourself. You're mine and I like you." Adora considered for a moment, biting her lip. It really had felt like Catra had been going above and beyond for her lately. She liked to think she reciprocated well enough but… "I want to take care of you tonight."

Catra's ears perked up, a saucy grin spreading over her face. "Well, well, well. I like the sound of that."

"Not like that! Well, not entirely like that. I mean it. You're so good to me, Catra. Let me spoil you."

"Mmm, like I'm really going to say no to that. What did you have in mind, Princess?"

"Oh, don't you worry about that, love. I've got plans." She came around to the other side of the table, solely to place a kiss on top

of the women’s head. “Before you ask- it’s a surprise.”

“Can’t wait, babe.” Catra’s eyes closed as she felt the warm press of Adora’s lips against her. She hummed in contented bliss; Adora was crazy for thinking she might not ever be enough for her. But also, who was Catra to deny her the chance to express her affection? Whatever was rolling around in the blonde’s brain was sure to be wonderful.

Stars

Chapter Notes

> Hey folks, have a drink or a snack with this one, because the word count is just under 10,300. Oh, verbosity, thy name is... Amitola12.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Really whatever would end up happening tonight was truly a surprise, because Adora had no plans. She had half-baked ideas at best. She wandered outside the manor, hoping the fresh air would spark her to greatness. It didn't really seem to be helping much, but it certainly wasn't hurting either and at any rate, it felt good to stretch her legs. So good in fact, that she considered running, literally, back to the castle for a suitable meal to serve this evening. She was fairly certain that with a constant, accelerated pace that she could make it in just over an hour. A quick raid of the Bright Moon kitchens, followed by a well-placed plea for Glimmer to teleport her back, and they'd be golden.

She made it as far as the hexagon-shaped outbuilding that had yet to be explored by either herself or Catra before it dawned on her that food wasn't all that impressive to her girlfriend. Sure, there were things she liked to eat, but spending all that time and energy really wasn't going to get that wow factor that she was hoping for. Adora gave a hefty sigh as she slumped against the oddly shaped structure, not realizing she'd even approached it at first. With a speculative half-turn of her body, she examined it closer. There were no windows that she could see and the exterior walls were the same mottled off-white of the main house that bespoke its former opulence. There was a set of double doors to her left, but otherwise no other defining details could really be drawn from her current position outside the building.

Adora stood, then took a few tentative steps towards the doorway of the new location. What was the purpose of this place? If she went inside, would she find anything interesting? Her conundrum was still very much the top priority of Adora's mind, but curiosity got the better of her. She doubted the building would hold the answers of what she could do tonight to truly *spoil* the love of her life, but as she pushed the doors open she justified to herself that inspiration could come from the strangest sources.

Because there were no windows, Adora had been expecting for the interior of the building to be near-impossible to make out. However, she was shocked to find it was surprisingly well lit. The lighting conditions were all due to the fact that the ceiling was completely made of glass. She had noticed from the outside that the roof was flat, but with everything else strange about the structure hadn't really given it much more thought. She wandered in further, needing to get a better look at the top of the building.

As she walked forward, she also saw some furniture odds and ends pushed off towards the walls; chairs, tables and the like. Oddly there were a few long, very plush-looking almost chairs (dimly Adora recalled Glimmer using the word 'chaise' to describe similar seating at the castle) towards the middle of the room, forming a loose circle. The arrangement seemed purposeful; Adora suspected that whatever ancestor of Glimmer's that utilized this facility did so with the express purpose of looking up at something through the glass ceiling. Surprising given the time Etheria had spent in Despondos, but who was Adora to question the pastimes of those that came before her?

She sat on the edge of one of the chaises, pleased to see that whatever wards and spells that kept the main house clean seemed to also keep the dust from settling in out here too. Not really one to take a nap, though that was definitely amongst her girlfriend's likes, she still laid back along the couch to consider once more what she could do tonight to impress- and more importantly, really demonstrate through action how much she cared for Catra.

It was the question of the hour; the puzzle that Adora needed to figure out. Her girlfriend wasn't necessarily the easiest person out there, at least to the casual observer not readily pleased by much of anything. But there had to be *something* that Catra liked to do, other than the aforementioned naps (well, if yesterday taught her anything, there was a lot in the bedroom that Catra *really* enjoyed but she was looking for something outside of that- for now). It felt like such an obvious question, something anyone who was in love with a person should know. Guilt stirred in Adora's stomach when the answer was not immediately forthcoming, but was quickly replaced with a simple truth: for much of their life, they weren't allowed to do. They weren't allowed to develop interests and follow passions unless those things could be exploited by the Horde. It was a crushing realization to come to. Catra's life had belonged to the Horde and its mission, regardless of where her heart and her desires truly lie.

Sure they made the best of it when they were together and it was easier when they were kids. Though discipline was an early lesson for even the most junior of cadets, things weren't completely regimented. They weren't given playtime per se, but after lessons in basic reading comprehension, penmanship, and mathematics were through there was a decent block of time where they weren't instructed to perform any specific tasks. Technically they were under the supervision of an older cadet who was supposed to be drilling them on a lesson review (to both hone the more senior soldier's command skills and make certain the younger cadets had been paying attention), but everyone knew it was a joke. After hours of sitting still the younglings wanted to roughhouse and cavort, not recite times tables. It was also a time for the older cadets to unwind a little, even better if you could swing bringing a squadmate to "assist".

For Adora's part, she always tried to practice her lettering during the free period or maybe do something about that long division that bugged her so badly. Catra of course couldn't be bothered with that business, not when there was a chance to play. She would tug on her friend's arm, maybe even pull at her ponytail, or if she was feeling particularly devious, just stick out her lower lip

and widen her eyes. That 'boo-boo face' as Adora called it almost never failed to make the blonde set aside the books and get up to some mischief.

But sometimes Adora would remain firm, particularly if she knew her best friend might not have been super engaged in the day's lessons. Maybe the senior cadet watching over them didn't care, but if she and Catra were to be running things one day, all this stuff would be important to know. Her best friend was exceedingly clever, but she got bored very easily. She had no interest in reading ("It's a waste, Adora, I wanna learn how to *fight* !") and while truthfully it wasn't really on Adora's list of favorite things to do, sometimes it could be interesting. If she ran across a passage that contained hand to hand fighting techniques or maybe about some great battle in the past that the Horde had won, she might read the passage aloud for Catra's benefit.

Initially the magicat girl would hiss her displeasure. "I can read it myself, dummy." But if Adora pressed on, with a taunting "Why don't you then? I'll be able to kick your butt even easier since I'm gonna read about…" Catra usually would give in and sit still long enough for Adora to read it to her. Even long after Catra displayed that she was faster at comprehension and certainly had a much neater scrawl than Adora ever would, the magicat would usually find some excuse for Adora to read out loud to her. It was never anything that interesting; battle reports, tactics discussions, or proper taser care, but Catra still listened as Adora read. Sometimes she would curl up at Adora's feet or sprawl out across the barracks floor, tail just barely grazing Adora's ankle. They were seen as cadets sharpening their minds in addition to the drills that would train their bodies, but to Adora it was a few extra moments of closeness between them in which they did not have to hide their draw to be near one another with sparring or play-fighting. They could just be. Even back then, when she had no real understanding of what actually Catra meant to her, the moments were far too precious and few.

Adora paused in her recollections, dismayed that even as children everything revolved around being the perfect soldier. At least

when Adora left the Fright Zone for Bright Moon, she'd gotten a chance to experience something outside of battle techniques and appropriate weapon usage. There was a war going on, sure, but there was also laughter and friends. There was travel and a smorgasbord of new foods for Adora to try. She was allowed to be a person, not a tool, even if she recoiled from that freedom at first. Catra had no such luxury; grimly she even wondered if there was anything that had brought the magicat comfort during their time apart.

She needed to find out for herself. This foray into the building had helped; a night out here under the stars where they could be with one another was beginning to percolate in Adora's mind. The idea that maybe she could do more if she knew if anything had brought her girlfriend calm during an exceedingly difficult time wouldn't leave her be, however. She left the building for now to seek Catra out, while thinking of all the ways she had found some modicum of peace for herself to try and incorporate that as well.

Adora approached inside the house where her girlfriend lay stretched out in a sunbeam, her mismatched eyes closed serenely. She had told Catra to go rest while she prepared them for tonight's activities, something Catra was more than happy to agree to. It was wonderful being away at this house with Adora, but she did miss her afternoon naps. Adora could tell that Catra was only enjoying the warmth on her fur and was not truly asleep. She still hated to disturb her, especially with a question that she realized might be a little… jarring. But it was all to make the best night possible for her! "Say, um, Catra?"

"Yes, Adora?" The magicat murmured, not opening her eyes.

"What did you… uh, do when we were apart during the war?" Catra stilled at the question, not expecting this dagger through her heart as she tried to rest, per her love's instructions. What did she *do* ? It was the Horde. Adora knew exactly what she did during that time, none of it good. The blonde caught the change in Catra's body language, it was no longer at ease, basking in the afternoon sun. Her tail was abnormally still, ears drawn back

slightly. Adora rushed forward to try to explain herself, hoping not too much damage had been done. "Oh, stars, I'm sorry. That came out wrong… I guess what I really mean is did you ever do anything to relax? Anything for yourself? Maybe in your spare time."

"Why are you asking me this?" She wanted to understand, to give her girlfriend the benefit of the doubt. Catra had to believe that Adora wasn't trying to be cruel with her questioning; the love of her life just had the finesse of a spiked morningstar.

"It's for tonight... I just wanted to see if there was anything special that maybe I wouldn't know about that I could include for you. To help you relax."

It took Catra a long time to respond. There was no relaxation in the Horde. There was pain, there was sweat, there was blood under your nails while they demanded that you surrender more and more. And all her effort was for naught. It wasn't that she wanted to succeed; she really didn't even then, just felt as though she *must* rather than face herself at that time. But sometimes it tugged at her mind, knowing how much of herself she gave with nothing really to show for it in the end. Well, except for the gorgeous blonde staring back at her, who loved her so. Catra decided then that a hundred lifetimes in the Horde was worth just one kiss from Adora.

As for her girlfriend's question, there was only one thing she could think of, though it made her stomach toss with remorse. How the scorpion woman had tried so hard to take care of her, even when all Catra did was lash out and treat her so poorly. *Just add it to the list of things I need to make up for in my life…* She crossed a hand over her eyes with a sudden deep set exhaustion that no amount of sleep could fix. In a strangled whisper, she replied. "Scorpia used to make me tea." To admit the kindness of the inherently good woman was a trying endeavor, but to deny it ever happened would be far worse.

“Thank you for telling me.” She pressed a kiss to Catra’s forehead. Her girlfriend hummed at the brush and Adora loathed the idea of leaving her, especially after inflicting such pronounced discomfort. She spoke softly as she ran her fingers down Catra’s cheek, the other woman pressing into the gentle touch. “We’ll go see her when we decide to head back to the real world, okay? I’m sure there’s a couple things She-Ra could do to help out with the restoration efforts.”

Catra smiled a little wanly at the attempt to console her. There was so much work still to be done in dismantling the former Fright Zone to turn it into a safe haven, a territory Scorpia (and undoubtedly Perfuma) would care for and pass to her descendants. The muscular woman would lead the land to prosperity, of which Catra had no doubt. Scorpia loved too deeply, and her loyalty was too absolute, for any other outcome. Adora had the best intentions, but the real work that needed to take place was not in tearing down the foundries and ugly smokestacks that adorned the military base. It would be in Catra proving to Scorpia that her easy forgiveness for Catra’s misdeeds wasn’t misplaced. Showing the woman that Catra could be a good friend and making up for every word she had spewed in anger, every hiss and slash of her claws when her friend had only wanted to provide comfort during a hellacious period of their lives. Adora couldn’t help her with that one. That could only come from Catra and Catra alone.

Still, she appreciated the thought that Adora wanted to take time to visit and help their friends. In a way, she was also grateful for the reminder of Scorpia’s kindness, even if it was tinted with guilt. She could not and should not forget; she’d taken advantage of the woman then, but it was a small penance to sit with her discomfort and grow from it. “Thanks, baby. I’d like that. As difficult as it will be to go back *there* , even if it’s changed so much already.”

Adora was quiet, nodding thoughtfully. “Yeah, it will be. But we’ll do it together.”

"Always." Catra purred out, surprisingly at peace despite this unexpected interruption to her dozing. They had one another and that was enough. Life's trials and tribulations were just details that they would work out together along the way.

The couple sat in the sun together a little while longer, before Adora regrettably admitted she had loads more to do for the evening. As she stood to leave, Catra teased her about all the time she was spending preparing for this big night. Adora just smiled and told Catra she was worth it- and so much more. The appreciative purrs she was met with after that assertion were the best thank you that she could receive.

The rest of the afternoon flew by. Adora flitted from house to the observatory, pulling items together that she would need for the evening. She even made one more quick trip back to her fishing spot, both to gather her disappointing net (still no catches, though she was grateful that no creatures had been stuck within the rigging for the past couple days) and make one more underwater journey. Food didn't need to be the focal point of the night, but they would need to eat and Catra seemed to enjoy what she had made before.

Catra for her part did her best to appear unconcerned about her love's flurry of preparations, though she was burning with curiosity at what Adora had planned for their evening. In Catra's mind, a quick dinner together and then a long romp in the bed after would be more than enough to 'spoil' her. She was a simple person, with simple needs. At the same point, she also wasn't going to turn down any attempt on her girlfriend's part to shower her with time and affection.

She continued to doze in the sun, smirking at the gentle ruckus Adora was making throughout the house and even out in the yard. Actual sleep was out of the question or so she thought, but she woke as the sun was beginning its fiery descent to Adora's fingertips brushing her cheek. "Hey, baby. I think I'm all ready for you."

Catra blinked the rest from her eyes, her gaze immediately softening as she registered the sight before her. Her Adora, framed by the slowly setting sun behind her, putting She-Ra to shame with her natural resplendency. Everything about her appearance looked a little more intentional than usual, as if part of her preparations for the night also included cleaning herself up. There was one thing that was definitely on purpose and it made Catra beam with a soft joy. "Your hair is down."

"Yeah, I'm running out of ties for you to tear." She gave a small wink, smiling at her own quip. Adora glanced down at herself for a quick moment, looking slightly unsure. "I thought about putting on a new outfit too- you wouldn't believe how many clothes are upstairs in the bedroom closets. But, um, wasn't sure if that would be crossing any lines with Glimmer…"

"You do know how ridiculous you are, right?" Catra had to laugh; of course her girlfriend would be concerned about using other people's long-forgotten finery. She could picture the internal struggle as Adora thumbed through the clothes. Hemming and hawing with herself because of how little she cared about her outerwear to begin with, but then grappling with the desire to look a little special for their night. Wondering if it would be okay to put on items she hadn't asked for permission to wear beforehand. In Catra's eyes though, Adora was gorgeous no matter what. "Fortunately for you, I happen to find your everyday wear incredibly sexy, yes, even your dumb jacket. Though, remind me to peek through a closet or two before we leave. Maybe I'll help myself to some loot."

"Catra, you wouldn't seriously steal royal apparel, would you?" It was Adora's turn to giggle, already knowing the answer was a firm 'Hell yes I would'. An image of after they had returned to the castle came to her, Catra sauntering down to breakfast clad in a new outfit, and when asked where she got it from, smirking out, *"Gotta say Sparkles, your family has good taste. What happened to yours?"*

"Eh, if I looked good enough in it. Pretty sure Sparkles said the house and everything in it was for our use. But maybe I'll just look for some ideas to bring back to the tailor at Bright Moon. A tail hole is such a pain- might as well get a professional to do the work for me."

"Definitely get something like you wore to the Princess Prom." Adora murmured, casting an appreciative glance at her girlfriend's form. There were likely to be formal events the pair would attend once things around the kingdom were a little more stable, but honestly Adora had a much more selfish reason behind the request. Catra had looked hot that night, plain and simple. "But we can talk fashion later. Are you ready for your night to begin, beautiful?" She asked, bubbling excitement springing up in her chest, with only the barest hint of nerves. Still- would it be enough? Was she rushing things by only taking a single afternoon to try to throw together a night of romance for them? But Catra seemed just as excited, two-toned eyes bright as jewels as she sat up to move off her perch. Adora gave a small chuckle, explaining herself better, and gently pressing her to sit back down again. "Actually, it would start right here- if you're comfortable in that window seat." Catra raised an eyebrow, nodding that she was indeed cozy, though admittedly a bit perplexed. She had heard a lot of noise happening outside and just assumed they'd be headed out there. But this was Adora's show, she was just here for the (oh so pleasant) ride. "Okay, then in that case…" Adora sat next to her before swinging her legs over either side of her love, so she was positioned behind her. "You can take your top off, if you'd like."

A rumbling purr kicked up instantly at the words whispered in her sensitive ear. "I thought you said it wasn't going to like 'that' tonight. Not that I'm complaining in the least…" She gave a soft squeaky laugh as she shucked her top off, leaning back against Adora's chest after.

The blonde's arms immediately enveloped her, pressing several soft kisses along her jaw and the base of her ear. "I believe I said *entirely* like that. We'll see what the night brings; it's just so hard

to keep my hands off of you…" Catra hummed in appreciation of the words, the feeling entirely mutual. They sat together, enjoying one another's company immensely. Adora's steady heartbeat as she lounged against her love was one of the most soothing sounds she'd ever been privy to hear. Her girlfriend's short nails lightly traced up and down her arms; it tickled, but in a way that was so comforting. They climbed higher and higher, fingers starting to press a little more deeply as they reached her biceps. The moves were exploratory, as if Adora were giving Catra the space to tell her to stop if at any moment something didn't feel nice. "How's that?"

"Mmm, feels good." Catra toned out, closing her eyes as the blonde's hands continued to work against her arms. It was wonderful to be held, fantastic to be fucked, but to just have Adora's touch on her person, purposeful as if she were slowly making a map of her entire form, was near beyond words. The touch rose higher and Adora began to gently knead her hands into the woman's shoulders. Catra seized at first as it approached her scarring, but the other woman was careful to avoid the back of her neck. She was not all together familiar with the action that was taking place, but as Adora massaged out some deep set tension in her muscles, she quickly relaxed. Her hands were so sure and firm in the motions, rolling along each dip, working out any stiffness that resided along her arms and shoulders, all the while periodically pressing kisses along the side of her face.

"Catra?" Adora barely whispered her name, not wanting to overwhelm her girlfriend when they were seated this close.

"Mmm, yeah babe?"

"Do you remember the first night after our kiss at the Heart- how we laid in the grass and slept under the stars together?"

"Do I remember something that happened a little over two weeks ago? Yeah. Vaguely."

Adora chuckled softly at her girlfriend's sass, coming to appreciate her even more for the playfulness that inherently existed in her. "I thought it might be fun if we sort of… recreated that tonight. A little differently, but the idea's still the same." The blonde increased the pressure as she rolled her hands around her girlfriend's deltoids, still largely avoiding her neck. A flash of anger and sadness hit the pit of her stomach as she saw the scar Prime had left on Catra's skin. What hurt more was the fact she knew the scars she couldn't see were far worse. But as Adora continued to work at the knots of tension along Catra's shoulder blades, the rumbling purr kicked up even more. The sound was enough to bring her back to the far more important matter of taking care of her love tonight.

They were here together, he was gone. It was as it should be. But some guilt still lingered from the aftermath of Heart. Adora needed to get it off her chest and there didn't seem a better time than now as her girlfriend was near-liquid in her hands. "You're probably not going to want to hear this but… Catra, I really messed up right after everything at the Heart. Those couple weeks… I was so afraid. But being with you here at the house has really shown me how stupid I was. I can't bring that time back, but if you'll let me have one more do-over, I can at least try and make up for it."

Catra sighed at her Adora's tendencies. They were so past the point of that couple weeks of awkwardness mattering in the slightest. "You didn't mess anything up. We were both pretty stupid, in retrospect. But that's all in the past, plus we agreed to have real conversation sixty percent of the time. That should help some of our dumbassery."

"Well, consider this part of that sixty percent then. Except I'd rather give you one hundred percent, always."

"You're such a sap." Catra turned to place a small kiss to her girlfriend's cheeks who smiled brightly at the brush.

"Happens when you're in love with someone…" The blonde finished, the need for conversation naturally coming to an end at the words, each woman just content to exist with one another. Adora continued to massage along Catra's body, working the muscles loose and bringing such relief the magicat hadn't even known she had needed. When Catra was no more than jelly in Adora's arms, the blonde once again breathed into her ear. "Are you ready to see what comes next?"

"Does it require me putting my shirt back on? Because that could be a deal breaker for me."

Adora cocked her head to the side, considering. "I suppose not, but we are going outside. You might get cold."

"Isn't that what I have you for?" Catra complained, though there was no seriousness to it. She slipped her arms back through her top and allowed Adora to take her hand and lead the way.

It was the gloaming hour as the couple walked outside. Adora was glad she had managed to get everything set up before dusk creeped in, eying the scene with a sense of satisfaction she hoped Catra would share. They had the makings for another fire, with plenty of wood piled nearby to replenish it as the night went on. Adora had set up one of the tables that was stored in the outbuilding for them to dine at just a short distance from where the fire would be. Her pilferage of the manor had also yielded a candelabra and candlesticks, which she thought added a very classy touch to the tabletop. They may have already drunk the plum wine that Glimmer had left for them, but she'd run across several bottles during the clean-up of the pantry and brought them out to the table as well. Wine lasted a while, right? Vintage or something along those lines.

She had considered setting up a tent outside so they could enjoy the cool night air as they slumbered (or took part in any other fun nightly activities). But instead she opted to lay a large blanket on the ground for after dinner cuddles. She had hefted a mattress from one of the bedrooms down and set it up the hexagonal

observatory, turning it into their star-speckled bedroom for when the time came to retire for the night. But Catra would have to wait to see that, at least for a little while longer. "Dinner time?"

The magicat nodded, eyes soft as she took in the dining area. It was simple- but oh, so perfect. Adora led her to the table, even going so far as to pull her chair out for her. Catra rolled her eyes at the gesture, but sat all the same. "Such service." She remarked dryly, as her girlfriend filled her glass with a dark red wine.

"Just wait 'til later." The blonde said, waggling her eyebrows, to which Catra only quirked a smile. "Now is there anything else I can get for my lady before I run off and cook for you?"

Catra glanced around; she had a glass of wine (so unlike the sickeningly sweet stuff Sparkles had provided; this rolled around her tongue with a pleasant bite and just in general seemed richer and far, far tastier), would soon have a fire to warm her fur, and her top seemed intent on attending to her every need both out of the bedroom and in it. She was pretty sure life actually couldn't get any better than this. "Not at all, love."

Adora worked quickly and soon had a merry blaze going, even before Catra had finished her second glass (Adora's glass really; the blonde took one sip of the dry vino and blanched, much to Catra's amusement), well on her way with dinner preparations. They made a few comments here and there as Adora cooked, but largely let the night fill in any silence with its natural ambiance.

The dinner that Adora prepared (flaky fish and seasoned rice) turned out wonderfully. Between the massage and wine, Catra was feeling looser than perhaps she ever had in her life. Even Adora managed to choke down half a glass, but it was seeing her love just so unashamedly at peace befuddled her senses. After they finished eating, Adora pulled Catra to the quilt so they could admire the galaxies far above them while holding one another.

Catra stared up at the vast night sky, drinking in the needlepoints of light an unfathomable distance away. To think she'd once been

out amongst them; almost electing to stay there rather than face the consequences of her own actions back on Etheria. She was so thankful for the stubborn ass beside her, the woman who would never give up on her even when she had long abandoned herself.

"Hard to believe they haven't always been there, huh?" Adora asked, her smile soft in the light of their dwindling bonfire. She gestured up with her chin, one hand behind her head as they lay atop the blanket in the warm grass.

"Yeah, I was just thinking about how I tried to stay up there; the big wuss I am. I know I have so much to make up for… But thanks for not actually just dropping me off at the nearest planet so I could 'make my own way' or whatever." Catra rolled her eyes at her own previous self, nudging Adora slightly in thank you. The wine certainly was making it far easier to talk about her past, far easier to laugh a little at the asshole she was rather than berate herself for it.

"With the way you were acting on the ship, can't say it didn't cross my mind for a split second." Adora teased, turning on her side to gaze in wonder at her girlfriend. The starry expanse above paled in comparison. All day memories and reflections of their life together had been hitting her, but there was one thing she still couldn't pinpoint: exactly when she fell for Catra. Her girlfriend had been so unwavering in her assertion that Adora had always been it for her, ever since they were children, all but naming it as love at first sight. Catra was always Adora's, even when they were trying to outdo one another in drills, even when things were at their bleakest in the war… The draw between them could not be denied or mistaken. But still, she wished more than anything to know exactly when her feelings became irrevocable truth, when they shifted to allow her to return Catra's confession at the Heart with her own. It bothered her immensely that she did not know for certain *when.* Adora's eyes were troubled as she vocalized her upset. "I knew I was in love with you then, when we were on the ship. Long before that, really. I know you said the other day that you've always loved me and I just wish…" She trailed off, searching the night sky for the answer that so eluded her.

“Hey, stop.” Catra pulled Adora in close, the blonde tucked safely under her arm. Adora didn’t have to finish that sentence for the magicat to know exactly what her girlfriend was tearing herself up about. “We didn’t always have the words to describe how we felt for one another. It’s okay if there wasn’t a big moment or whatever for you. That’s not really important, not now. Not when we have this, finally.” Catra clasped their hands together, lacing fingers. She stared deep into her love’s eyes, willing Adora to really *feel* what existed between them.

Adora didn’t shy away from the contact; it felt as though her very soul was warmed through. Having Catra look at her like that… It was everything. She was everything. The joy that Adora was feeling in this moment was absolute, her comfort boundless. She slipped under Catra’s arms, tucked tightly against her chest. Despite the sincerity of her feelings in this moment, or maybe because they allowed for such ease, Adora teased lightly. “So how come you’ve always had those words, since apparently I charmed you when we were six years old.”

Catra snickered at her girlfriend, Adora able to feel the vibrations of her amusement as she snuggled against her love’s chest. She only wished they could be closer. With a crafty, almost challenging edge to her tone, Catra explained. “Because I'm the smart one. Always have been, always will be.”

Cautiously, Adora cupped her girlfriend’s face in her hand, gently bringing it down so they were now laying face to face. Perhaps it was the effects of the wine, deepening her curiosity, or maybe it was just because so many of her thoughts had been centered around it. She asked softly, “Would you tell me the story?”

“What story?” Catra breathed out, a little awed by the moment.

“Of when you knew you loved me.”

“You were there, y’know.” Catra pointed out, furrowing her brow slightly. It was a dangerous topic she knew; so many unprocessed and raw feelings resided within it. But it was also the beginning of

their story… Adora was the only one who would ever get to hear it, the only one who deserved to...

"Please?" Her girlfriend rested their foreheads together, each of them breathing in each other's air for a few cycles.

As if Catra could ever say no to her.

On the good days, Catra liked to believe it was some great act of mercy that she was brought to the Horde. That she was saved from some permanent fate; thrown over a cliff or a nap at the bottom of the ocean. Maybe starving for a couple weeks as she waited for them to return. They had told her to hide and back then she actually listened. Every damn time it played in her mind she listened to what the nameless, faceless figures told her to do. Every damn time she wanted to sob endlessly when they left her, watching her small self tuck into a corner of the pantry behind the box fort she played in.

Realistically, she knew it was just soldiers following orders. There was no mercy in the Horde.

"What do we do with it?"

"Shadow said to bring all kids back to base, directly to her."

She tried desperately to claw, bite, do anything to get the thing that was holding her by the scruff of her neck to let go. It hurt. She hissed for the first time in her life as her claws harmlessly ricocheted off the armor.

"Is it even a kid? Little mongrel keeps trying to scratch."

"Let her decide. Tase it if you can't manage the furball."

"Ah, geez. If it's a kid, I can't do that."

"Throw it in a box or something then, idiot. We gotta get back to the Zone."

After that Catra just remembers feeling trapped, almost suffocated. She'd tried to resist, tried to fight what was happening. But she couldn't. As the walls closed in on her, her will vanished. She didn't understand. Where did they go? Why did they leave her?

The scent of rust was everywhere, though mixed with something foreign; fetid and sharp. It ruthlessly assaulted her nose, making the fur along her back stand on edge. The primal part of her that called for survival screamed 'Danger!' at the smell. She thought about running, but was paralyzed with fear. It wasn't natural, whatever the source was.

"What is the meaning of this interruption?"

"Sorry to disturb, ma'am, but we found a youngling during the raid. A hybrid."

"Another beast…" A disgusted sigh. *"I will deal with it later. Leave me."*

The malodorous scent faded away, Catra locked into place under the crushing weight of her circumstances. They said she needed to be a good girl and listen, she needed to stay hidden. She tried, but they found her. She always tried to be good.

Tiny, rushed footsteps and another new scent. It was sweet, almost cloying, and it made her fur stand on end again. Completely opposite of the way the other smell made her feel. The flaps above her head were thrown open wide. A pale light accosted her eyes; she hissed for the second time as it stabbed at her corneas. The shrill cry of *"Kitty!"* as chubby arms latched around her neck. She panicked, scrambling away, back claws

tearing into the cardboard below her. Her tail stuck straight out, poofed to five times its normal volume. She pressed herself into the corner, chest heaving, eyes trying to adjust to the strange light.

That smell, the one that was good but almost too much, was everywhere. The giggles had stopped, hands let go of her. Bright blue eyes peered over the edge of the box. They were all Catra could look at. *"I'm sorry, I shoulda asked to give you a hug…"*

Catra gave no reaction, utterly petrified. It didn't feel dangerous anymore, but it was still unknown. Too much was unknown.

"My name is Adora. Maybe if you come out, we could be friends?" The voice was soft, a welcoming suggestion.

Catra did not blink, did not sever her stare on the being above her. Pudgy fingers reached out, possibly to soothe, possibly to hurt. She could not take the risk. She swiped at them, missing, and they retreated.

"It's okay. You're just scared." The sky in her eyes grew overcast. *"I get scared too."*

"Can I…?" The tiny fingers reached out once more, stopping for a second to see how the other girl would react. This time she connected with downy fur. Catra flinched, but the touch on her ear was so gentle. " *We won't be so scared if we're together."*

"I didn't know what the hell was going on," Catra said, her voice thick. She felt distant, almost as if she were living the memory of someone else. Bitterly it occurred to her that she was; that child had no idea who she would grow to be, the things she'd accomplish, nor the crimes she'd commit. "Everything was just so… new and terrifying." She quieted for a moment, then laughed, though the sound was hollow. "And it stunk; hijacked magic and

stale wine. Good thing Weaver was such a lush, if the old bitch hadn't needed a bottle before actually dealing with her job, I probably would have been toast." She could just picture it; one zap and maybe the Horde would be short one for their quota of child soldiers, but at least Shadow Weaver wouldn't have yet another wretched beast amongst her ranks.

Adora reversed their positions to cling the smaller woman to her chest, as if Catra were in danger of being taken from her in that very moment. "Don't even say things like that."

"Get a grip, Adora. She's dead. The only thing left of her are memories." *And the scars* . But Catra didn't dare to say that last part out loud. Adora didn't need to hear that right now. "That's the story, boils down to *someone* here never being any good with boundaries." She teased lightly, her tail wrapping around Adora's thigh as the blonde held her tightly. She considered for a moment, then spoke again. "I guess that's one part I really don't understand. Why *did* Weaver even keep me…?"

Adora bit her lip, suddenly feeling more than a little shy. Catra had told her half, perhaps she needed to fill in some blanks too. "Well, um, I didn't really give her much of an option, did I? Like you said, not real great with boundaries…"

So soft. How could anyone or anything be *that soft* ? Adora's small fingers gently rolled between the downy tuft, trying not to scratch too hard. She knew it wasn't fun when someone was too rough with her hair, like when a Horde Mother would yank a brush through it, pulling it up into a ponytail. She tried to take it back down every time, not liking the weight on top of her head, but her hand was always smacked away with a gruff, *"Leave it be."*

She learned to just accept it; if the grownups wanted her hair like that, there must be a reason. The headache always faded after a while anyway.

The girl made a curious ‘ *prbbt’* sound as Adora’s fingers reached the base of her ear. It made her giggle, especially when she stopped doing it and the girl turned to face her with a hard glint to her eye, accusing her. Adora asked, *“What’s your name?”* The boxed girl just continued to look at her, cocking her head to the side. *“Do you have one?”*

A slow blink as Adora returned to scritching the spot that had made the kitty-girl produce that sound. She wished she could make a fun noise like that or really that there was anything special about her. Shadow Weaver told her there was, but never explained any further. Just told Adora that they would do great things together one day. She didn’t know what that meant, but it seemed to make Shadow Weaver happy, so Adora was happy too.

Just when she thought her new almost-friend wouldn’t answer or maybe couldn’t, she heard a teeny, tiny squeak. *“...Catra.”*

Adora was so excited by that small voice. She jumped to her feet, dancing a little. She usually got in trouble for being fidgety like this, but she couldn’t help it. Sometimes her feet just needed to show how happy they were. *“Cat-RA! You’re like me! Ado-RA and Cat-RA!”*

Catra slunk back, a little overwhelmed by the sudden excitement and movement. At seeing her new friend huddled again, Adora knelt by the box once more, forcing herself to be calm and not scary. *“Do you live here now?”* No reply, just a small shrug. *“Can I show you our room?”* She held out her hand, just hoping the other girl would take it.

When she did, Adora felt like her heart would burst. A friend. Her friend. Her Catra.

The pair sprinted down the hallway, all giggles and tiny footsteps. They were oblivious to their surroundings; unaware that even the shadows had eyes in the Fright Zone. Adora had gone looking for Shadow Weaver for… something, she couldn’t even remember why she’d approached her guardian’s work area in the first place.

There was too much excitement at finding Catra. But now she had a new goal: showing Catra everything about her new home.

" *Adora,"* The oily word slipped out from a ways behind them, causing the small blonde to freeze in her tracks. *"Come over here this instance."*

Adora was compelled to obey, knowing no good would come otherwise. She turned to her new friend. *"I'll be right back, k?"* She didn't wait for a response or notice how Catra's fur was sticking up.

The magicat girl just looked on, wide-eyed that her friend would willingly walk towards danger. So brave, braver than she'd ever be. Catra wanted to run, but she wanted Adora to come back even more. *"... Ok. Hurry."*

She dutifully walked to her guardian's side, flinching slightly when the woman pointed towards an open room. Adora hated getting a talking to by Shadow Weaver. She wasn't even sure what she'd done this time; nothing was broken and she hadn't even slowed down once during the running this morning!

When they got into the room, Adora focused on the floor, just waiting for Shadow Weaver to speak. The woman's voice finally came out, slippery yet sharp. *"What are you doing with that thing, Adora?"*

Thing? What thing? She was with her new friend and she sure wasn't a *thing* . She was a girl, just like Adora. *"With Catra? Oh, I'm gonna show her where we sleep!"*

"Catra." Adora didn't like the way the name came out of her mouth. She sounded angry; why? Maybe Catra had broken something, Adora knew all too well that accidents happened. Could be why she'd been in the box; sometimes the older cadets tried to hide when they did something bad. It usually didn't work so Adora faced up to it when it was her. The punishments weren't so bad then.

"Yeah, she's my new friend!" Maybe if she showed how happy she was, Shadow Weaver would understand better. And Adora really was excited. There were always people around the base, but no one really like her. Catra would be, though. Adora was sure of it.

Shadow Weaver stayed still. Adora wanted to convince her what a great idea this was. *"Or at least she could be, if she stayed with us! That would be so much fun. We can run and train and then I'd have a friend!"*

"A friend." Adora nodded eagerly. *"... Very well, Adora. But she is your responsibility. Do not let that beast become a distraction. We have work to do."*

Adora continued to worry at her lip, until Catra gently lay a finger against it to ease her. She smiled at her girlfriend, thankful for the reminders to not let her anxiety get the best of her. "I asked her if you could say. I… told her how badly I wanted a friend. I promised her that I would be so good and always take care of you." Shame flickered on her cheeks, rising and roiling under her skin. As if Catra were some sort of pet and not her own person. "Why she agreed to that, who knows…"

"Even had to be the hero back then, huh?" The words were spoken with no malice, only a fond understanding of her girlfriend's character. Catra knew that Adora's younger self hadn't been looking to 'save' anyone; she was a lonely little girl in a most unforgiving place.

"Aww, am I your hero, baby?" Adora parried back, kissing the tip of Catra's nose. She was relieved at how her girlfriend had taken this latest recollection. "Thank you for telling me all this. I just… really wanted to know."

"You're fine, babe. But, uh, wouldn't mind if we switched gears for a while." Recalling all this stuff with Adora hadn't been *that* difficult, at least not to the level she had been anticipating, but

Catra wasn't gonna object to the idea of coming back to the present. Things were a bit happier here.

"Oh, yeah, of course!" Adora glanced over to the fire; it was down to just coals so they really were at a crossroads for their night. They could easily stay out here, where she would stoke the fire to life again, or move inside. She didn't think either of them were the least bit sleepy, but she was excited for Catra to see the observatory. "I don't really have an itinerary anymore, but there is something more I'd like to show you…"

"Adora the great strategist *doesn't* have a plan? I'm shocked, babe, really." Catra gave her a light kiss before they sat up.

Adora led them to the building that would be their room for the night, assuming Catra agreed to her plan. She made sure to grab one of the lit candles from the dining table, knowing that they would need it. Before she opened the door, she turned to face her girlfriend, a smidge of guilt clear on her face. "Okay, confession time, and nothing to do with the Horde or our childhood this time. I came out here earlier in the day because I had no idea what to do for you tonight. I just really want to wow you, make sure you know how much I love you…"

"You absolute goof. You know just spending time with you is more than enough for me, right?" Catra was touched at the sentiment, but Adora really just needed to accept that being together in the simple moments almost carried more weight than the sweeping, grand ones. She was looking forward to a lifetime of small moments, interspersed with a collage of big ones, all with her Adora.

"Well, maybe." Adora conceded, shrugging slightly. "But you deserve so much more, Catra! I just wanna give you everything." Before Catra could argue with her- or gag, either was equally possible, Adora continued explaining. "So yeah, I came out here and I don't really know what this place is exactly, some sort of observatory or something, but I thought it was really beautiful and we could sleep here tonight. I brought down a bed, well, just a

mattress really but it should be okay. Of course, if you don't want to, that's totally okay and we can go back inside. I won't be upset or anything, just want to make sure you're comfortable..."

"Adora." Catra cut her girlfriend off, grabbing her hand to steady her. "Why are you nervous and rambling?"

"I… have no idea." She laughed, snorting a little at the end. Adora really had no idea where this bout of nerves had sprung up from; maybe it was just that she really wasn't the interior decorator type. But she had tried really hard and just wanted it to be perfect. "Bad habit or something, I guess?"

"Yeah, or something. Chill, babe. Whatever you did in there, I love it already because *you* did it and did it for us. So, show me?"

"Okay." Adora nodded, feeling utterly reassured by her girlfriend's affirmations. She went to open the door and paused, hand on the doorknob. "Actually, can you wait out here? I just need like, two minutes."

"Sure thing, 'Dor." Catra chuckled, waving her on. "Whatever you need."

Adora gave her a quick peck on the cheek with a large smile before slipping inside. She worked quickly, trying to make sure all was set and perfect. Or at least as much as it could be with what she had to work with. As she gave the room one last glance, adjusting the pillows so they lay perfectly symmetrical at the head of the bed, she realized her only regret was not having any flowers to place on the bedside table. She really wasn't sure if her girlfriend had a favorite flower, but made a mental note to find out one day.

She peeked her head out from the doorway, making sure to block Catra's view. Her girlfriend laughed at her wiggling, so charmed by this goof she called the love of her life. "So, just remember. Recreating the night under the stars we had before. Just differently."

“Got it, Adora. You’re getting anxious again; better let me inside before you lose your nerve completely.” Catra teased with a warm smile, her voice gentle and encouraging. She opened the door wider, holding her breath as her girlfriend peered in. Her multicolored eyes narrowed, then grew wide, before settling to amused softness. “Oh, Adora…”

“Mmm?” The blonde made a curious noise, not quite able to get a read on her girlfriend’s reaction.

“It’s beautiful, baby.” And it was; Adora had taken great care to place the bed she’d brought down for them in the middle of the room, right under where she’d predicted the light from their planet’s moons would cascade down. Along the floor she’d sporadically placed pillar-shaped candles she’d found in a closet of the manor; lighting them had been the reason for the short break before she let Catra in. There weren’t many, Adora hadn’t wanted to take away from the splendor of the clear night sky visible through the ceiling above them. The bed itself was adorned with the finest blankets and softest pillows she could find, a whole mountain to make up for the lack of a headboard or bed frame. She was sure neither one would want to sleep with all of them, but it seemed that it would make snuggling before slumber a little easier. At the far end of the room Adora had placed another table, intending for it to be a breakfast nook in the morning. Catra’s eyes swept over the low-lit room, tail wrapping around Adora’s wrist as she drank it in. As she leaned back against her girlfriend’s chest, both of them still standing in the doorway, she purred out, “I love you.”

Adora’s returned ‘I love you, too’ carried the same softness and cadence of when she’d first spoken the words; already that fateful night was on its way to being replicated, though reborn into something stronger, more assured. Just like their relationship as a whole. She delicately moved Catra from her position against her, wrapping an arm around her girlfriend’s slender waist as she led them further inside and towards the bed to lay down.

Catra continued to take in the atmosphere of the room. Who knew what it's original purpose was, though she clearly noticed that where Adora had set up the table and chairs the floor was different; smooth and hard, perfect for dancing. With as much stray furniture as she saw spread around the room, she began to suspect it was a ballroom for small events the royal family held while away at their vacation home. Catra even noticed a short raised platform tucked back, likely for a live band to perform from. Glancing up again at the wondrous ceiling, she couldn't help but think that even if then they did not have the stars above, the view of the moons that ellipsed Etheria would have been rather breathtaking for the party-goers. It certainly was now.

Adora gestured to the side of the bed and a night stand, clearly proud of herself for her foresight. "I brought the biggest pitcher I could find, for water if we need. I might have to run inside to refill once or twice, but it won't take but a minute… Oh! And for tea, I found tea in the pantry."

Catra placed a fond hand on her girlfriend's cheek, grateful to have such a person in her life. She looked at the end table in question and cocked her head, pleasantly bemused. "And those?"

"Oh. Well, I was thinking that maybe I could read to you?" She gestured towards a small stack of books she'd picked from the shelves in the manor. Adora hadn't intended on that activity as part of their night until she found the library, but it just felt right. Deciding which ones might be of interest to Catra was a challenge; she'd leafed through those with the most exciting covers, trying to make sure they weren't focused on war, but also not too gooey with romance. "You know, since I used to…"

"I remember." Catra breathed out; any excuse to procrastinate her own work, just knowing the blonde would then take special pains to make sure she stayed caught up. Pretending she had no interest in reading for herself (she supposed that really wasn't *that* far of a stretch; Catra always preferred to be a little more kinetic as a half-grown rascal) just to hear Adora's voice and to have a little bit of extra time together. As they grew, the

opportunities to partake in such a quiet, non-destructive activity dwindled and disappeared. Part of her marveled that Adora remembered those sessions, but realized that her girlfriend probably held them just as dear to her heart as she did. "You know, I can read it myself, dummy…"

Adora understood the callback for what it was, giggling softly. "Yeah, I know you can. But I think I picked out some good ones, so maybe let me? Just for old time's sake." She gestured towards the bed, motioning for Catra to lay down. Her girlfriend complied, Adora scooching in next to her, arm fumbling slightly to grab a volume from the stand next to them and not stop holding her Catra for even a second. She cracked the spine open as Catra lay in the nook between her chest and shoulder, a contented sigh mixing with her heavy purrs as Adora read aloud by the light of the many stars above them and the low glow of the candles below.

When Adora had reached a natural stopping point in the story, she paused in her recitations. "Well, what do you think so far?"

The magicat wrinkled her brow. She'd been only half-listening at first, not really caring much about the plot of whatever book Adora was reading to her. Just hearing her love speak was enough, all the better when she was given the opportunity to laugh at her for giving each character his or her own specific (and usually goofy) voice or over-enunciating certain words, and adding syllables that really did not belong. All that didn't start to happen until Adora was further in, obviously growing more comfortable and wanting to perform a little. She really was a terrible actress, but damn if it didn't make Catra smile at her attempts. But as things picked up a little in the storyline, she did grow somewhat intrigued, but definitely had a major problem. "It's been fine, babe. I just gotta ask one thing, are they saying her science-obsessed parents like, experimented on her before she was even born? And that's how she got her animal powers or whatever?"

"I think so."

"That's pretty messed up, if you think about it. Parents probably shouldn't experiment on their unborn child even if they wanna save the world. Was this really the best you can find, Princess? I'm a little scared of the other options we have if that's the case."

"Hey, be nice! I worked really hard to find something you'd like to listen to. This is exciting; I know magic isn't really your thing… But It's at least a lot better than the battle tactics overviews I used to read to you."

"Eh, okay. You have a point there. But I could make up a way better story."

"Do it then." Adora challenged, ticking up the corner of her mouth and sticking out her tongue.

Catra gave a small smile, ideas of how she'd improve this book by way more than 400 percent lazily flitting in the back of her mind. She wondered what her younger self would say if she could see this scene; her and Adora in the moonlight, wrapped up, as the blonde that had so ensnared her affections doing something as simple as reading a dumb story to her. And all of it happening with no Fright Zone to the backdrop, no Horde insignias branded over everything, and the cruel gaze of their second-in-command mother figure nothing more than a fading nightmare. Catra didn't think her past self would believe such peace was possible, nor that she was deserving of it. She certainly would be stunned by how closely their Adora was holding her; like she was a precious thing, worthy of love. Her heart ached a little for that child, bled for that scraggly, angry teen. But as she looked up at the love of her life, she vowed to make the absolute best of the rest of her life by living it as she truly wanted, and as far from how she had while under the punishing tyranny of the Horde. "You know what? Maybe I will someday…"

Adora's gaze softened at the words, not expecting them. Before she could ruminate further, Catra tipped her head down. "But not right now."

The blonde kissed the tip of her girlfriend’s knuckle as lightly grasped her chin. “Got something else in mind?”

“Just set the book down and be with me for a little, okay?”

As if Adora could ever tell her no.

Chapter End Notes

(If any one cares, Adora is reading the Etherian version of Kipo and the Wonder Beasts. Haven't watched myself, but my partner does. She loves it, but does have some... ethical concerns over the plot. I had to tease in my fic as she was quite vocal about it the other day.)

I foresee some smut on the horizon, then an epilogue wrap up. I've enjoyed this ride so much and hope you all have to. As always, thank you for everything. I love hearing from you and it's such a wonderful community to write for. Until next time!

Beginnings

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They spent the rest of their night locked in each other's arms, gazing up at the speckled night sky, whispering and giggling. A few kisses were exchanged, serious and inviting, but more than anything they luxuriated in the attention being solely lavished upon one another. Catra fell asleep draped across Adora's body, the blonde idly carding through her short curls. She dreamt of a home, which was little more than a single open room with a metal stairway that led up to their platform high above the Fright Zone. Her dream self gazed up at the rickety landing, forgoing the ascent up the rusty stairs in favor of peering out the large bay window only to see a mess of kits and kids scurrying about the yard. Adora was chasing the younglings around while reciting stories, her acting and voice work somehow even worse in the reflections of Catra's subconscious.

She saw her love scoop up two of the children, placing them on either shoulder after transforming into She-Ra, much to the giggling delight of the brood around her. She jumped high into the air, almost a perfect vertical leap, achieving an impressive height from the might of her legendary form. The kids on her shoulders squealed at the sudden weightless in their free fall back to the ground, though a somewhat cross looking Queen Sparkles zapped onto the scene to snatch a small glittery girl with bright brown eyes from where she was standing on Adora's shoulder mid-fall. The rapscallion blonde just laughed as she and the remaining kit plummeted back towards the earth. Dream or not, Catra's heart seized as she saw the magicat child press a kiss to Adora's cheek after landing, her partner snuggling the little one close to her. The other children scrambled around her, pulling and pushing to grab her attention- arms, tails, and pincers all a flurry as they begged for the chance to be the next ones launched into the air.

With a seamless transition, they were back at Bright Moon, in the grand ballroom of the Castle and surrounded by a sea of faceless partygoers. Adora, clad in a white and gold suit, twirled Catra around the dance floor, lifting her off the ground before sweeping her low. The blonde's arms cradled her close as Catra was brought parallel to the floor, her leg drawn upwards to settle in a rather intimate spot for how not alone they were. Adora just raised an eyebrow as they stayed in that familiar, though reversed, position before she leaned forward, placing a chaste kiss to her bride's lips.

Her dreams continued in this manner all night, the threads of possibility weaving into the tapestry of memories. Catra stirred awake slowly, a hazy thought of *"That's a problem for future Catra and Adora…"* surfacing briefly before sinking back down to the deepest depths of her mind. Within moments of wakefulness, the dreams and words were forgotten, replaced by the tangible reality of waking up in her lover's arms. Adora was still out cold, a soft snore accompanying a barely open mouth to illustrate just how deep in her rest cycle she was. Catra gazed with unfathomable fondness at the sight before tucking herself back under her girlfriend's chin. Shutting her eyes again she whispered, "Better not drool on me, dummy…"

After breakfast that morning, they trudged back into the house, surveying what needed done. The pantry cataloguing still had a ways to go, but both Catra and Adora wanted to drag out the job for as long as possible. It would just be so difficult to transition back to life at the Castle… Still, they grudgingly agreed it was time to buckle down, at least *try* to get things put back together. But not overexert themselves on it either.

And so a pattern was set- sleep in as late as Adora could manage, lounge before and after breakfast, then tackle the mountain of expired foodstuffs. Adora had gotten a fairly good look at the rest of the house during her scavenge for date night and everything

else seemed in order. She still wasn't certain if her best friend *actually* needed them to inspect the house or not, but she had a plethora of mental notes prepared just in case. She tried to jot down the most salient points during her free time, hoping the details would buy her and Catra a few extra days at the house. The notes would it seem like they'd done a thorough inspection on the property rather than just a meticulous inspection of one another.

The work itself would seldom last much into the afternoon, but even those several hours they were sorting and organizing were pretty enjoyable. Catra could make anything fun. The evenings were theirs entirely and it didn't take someone with Farsight to guess how they were spent. If Adora didn't fall asleep with the taste of Catra still lingering on her tongue, it simply was not a good night's rest.

Less than a week after the night spent in the observatory, the couple was going about the tedium of organizing and sorting. It was nearing their unspoken quitting time and Adora was feeling particularly restless. The pile was shrinking far quicker than she'd prefer and it almost looked like a normal room again. Scrawling out a few more items on the inventory, she idly wondered if her girlfriend would kill her if she were to purposely make a mess in some other room of the house. It was probably disrespectful, but honestly Adora would trash the whole place if it bought her this continued alone time with Catra. Sure they'd still be together back at the Castle, Adora wasn't going to make that mistake again in this lifetime, but there'd be other people there. People that wanted things from her, expected things of them both. All Adora wanted was...

She glanced up from her writing, fully prepared to shoot her girlfriend a moon-eyed grin, more than ready to let her cognitive abilities fall by the wayside as she drank in Catra's natural allure. Maybe she'd get lost in those pools of sunlight and clear sky, become utterly bewitched by that squeaky laugh. Her breath caught in her throat, however, when Adora was presented with the sight of her girlfriend bent over, the delectable curves of her

ass on full display for her viewing pleasure. She licked her lips and rose from the table, trying to be as surreptitious as possible.

Catra's ear flicked at the sound of Adora rising from the table, but she paid it no mind. She was ready to be done with this pantry project, not necessarily thrilled at the idea of returning to Bright Moon, but as far as she was concerned, she and Adora would leave once Queen Sparkles herself came to drag them from the house. Adora had earned herself as long of a vacation as she wanted and Catra would already have to spend the rest of her life making up for all the shit she pulled in the past three years, so what was another few weeks (or months), really?

The magicat remained focused on peering at the contents of the box, tail swishing contentedly as she worked. Mostly canned goods, a few dry mixes, and one substance that she couldn't even begin to guess what it originally was. At least it didn't stink; they'd run across one fetid jar that had broken open at some point. It left Catra gasping for air, unable to return to the house for several hours without feeling nauseous. But it led to an amazing nap in the sunlight, Adora dealing with the offending sustenance. Her girlfriend was such a nice girl.

As Catra was bent over, Adora couldn't help herself. She crept up, closer and closer, putting every lesson in stealth and avoiding detection from her youth into practice. It wasn't going to fool her quarry, Catra was far too disciplined and her senses far too keen, but she had a feeling that her girlfriend wouldn't be expecting what she had in mind…

With the most careful foot placements, she found herself right behind where Catra was working. Before the magicat could reposition herself, turn to face her with a cocky eyebrow raise and a "What are you doing, dummy?" Adora made her move. She brought her finger and thumb together, then gave Catra's fine display a little pinch.

Catra had been fully aware of Adora's presence behind her, but couldn't help her trill of surprise as her fingers squeezed her ass.

She'd been expecting to be pulled into a hug, have a few sweet nothings whispered in her ear as Adora kissed along her jaw, making her way towards her lips. They'd make out for a while, her girlfriend's hands steadily pulling off clothes before hoisting her up. Likely the pair wouldn't even make it upstairs to a bedroom or even to a couch, Adora just fucking her against the wall. That had been the flow of things recently, more often than not how they capped off their work day. But she supposed her girlfriend couldn't risk them falling into predictability. That suited Catra just fine.

The magicat's eyes narrowed for a moment before her lips curled into a most satisfied smirk. "Thinking about taking a break, babe?"

Adora shrugged, rocking back and forth on her heels, trying to project an aura of innocence. It was an absolute act, no question how this afternoon would end for them, but playing was just so fun. "We really should get some more of this put away…"

"Mmm, definitely getting mixed signals here, love. Not very nice to tease." She ran a single finger down Adora's chest, only stopping when she reached the top of her pants. Her finger lingered there, just waiting to see if her girlfriend would take any action to move her hand a little lower. She loved being taken by the blonde, but Adora being direct enough with her own wants was really fucking hot. "Pretty sure that's my job…"

"And you do it so well. But y'know, it was just there, looking so good, I couldn't help but…" Adora reached a hand back, intent on repeating the goose but Catra twisted away so the blonde's fingers just barely ended up brushing her girlfriend's ass. She gave a mock pout, but really any chance to see how dexterous Catra could be was a win in her book.

"Nice try, but you'll have to do much better than that." Catra grinned, tail waving behind her in a taunt, just daring the woman to try again. Within minutes, Adora was reliving her past, thundering up the steps after Catra as the woman led her exactly

where she wanted Adora to go. The wall could probably use a break, anyway.

Adora lightly laid her hand against Catra's ass, the touch so delicate and hesitant it could barely count as a tap.

"... What the hell was that?" Catra had been preparing herself for far more than what was being offered. She knew such a reaction was rude, but her disbelief was a knee-jerk response, the words tumbling out of their own accord.

"Um... I'm trying, okay?!" Adora's face burned with embarrassment as she waffled with herself. *I just don't want to hurt her!* Mere minutes ago, it had seemed like such a great idea; their playfulness downstairs quickly burned into unmistakably amorous intent. The chase ended in kisses, the kisses became more insistent, hands more demanding as they pulled off clothes. Spurred on by the raw emotion of all their time spent together, coaxed by the feel of Catra's naked, lithe form above her, an emboldened Adora had suggested that it was time they cross another item off the sex list, laying her hand suggestively on Catra's ass, giving it a firm squeeze. "Since you liked when I pinched it so much, just imagine…" The magicat was only all too happy to take up the offer when it was given. But now that it was happening, Adora was in her head a bit over the whole thing.

"Adora, you've slugged me across the face before. I *know* you can hit harder than that." Catra meant it as a joke, off color for sure, but to ignore the reality of parts of their past would provide no justice to their future. Things had been ugly between them at times, but it all led to the beauty of what they had together now.

Adora winced slightly with an uneasy smile, but understood her love's attempt at levity. That was Catra, not exactly one to stay her tongue (in any situation). "Fair enough. I know I suggested

this, agreed that it was something I wanted to try, but I just can't help but worry. What if I hurt you?"

Kinda the point, love. She kept her comments to herself, not needing the inevitable spiral that would come from it. "Then I'll tell you, baby, and we'd never do it again." Catra cupped Adora's face with her hand, stroking her cheek with her thumb. Adora leaned into the touch, kissing Catra's palm, closing her eyes as she soaked in the soothing warmth of her girlfriend's hand against her. The magicat's gaze softened at the scene as she spoke gently. "Though just because you agreed the other day and even suggested it now doesn't mean we have to follow through. Your comfort is as important as anything in all this kind of stuff. But, Adora?" The blonde gave a small questioning noise, acknowledging the use of her name. "I know you wouldn't really hurt me if we did."

"How can you be so sure…" Adora meant it rhetorically, but Catra was all too happy to explain.

"For starters, I don't think that you and I feel things the exact same way. Things that might hurt you, feel *really* nice to me, at least if what we've done so far is any clue. That bite the other day, the one I *begged* you for..." She trailed off for a moment, lost in the memory of being so thoroughly claimed by the woman below her, pleased beyond measure that she still had the marks to prove it. It was sweet that Adora was so concerned, completely in character for the love of her life, but Catra sort of was ready for some of it to dissipate. She wanted nothing more than to surrender herself completely to her Adora. Catra would never try to change who her girlfriend intrinsically was, but if they could grow together, explore new things as a couple that might turn out to be mutually beneficial…

"You wouldn't have to put all your force into it, because we both know how fucking strong you are." Catra slowly moved down Adora's torso, angling her head so she could rest across the blonde's chest. She gazed over at the sculpted perfection of Adora's arms, following the dips and bulges of the beautiful

muscles she wanted to spend every day of her life wrapped in. "So strong and sexy; just makes me so wet to think of being pinned under these brutally powerful arms… I want those arms all around me, holding me down and fucking me so hard… " Adora shifted below her, a small moan sounding in her back of her throat as she shifted her thigh between Catra's legs. Her arms flexed as she moved her hands to wrap around Catra's waist, pulling the woman as tight against her as she could. Unable to resist the allure of their corded definition, Catra began to place open-mouthed kisses on the blonde's bicep. She fluttered her tongue lightly against the soft skin, indulging herself completely in the desire Adora's muscles awoke in her. She moaned greedily as she covered the whole of her bicep, only persuaded to remove her mouth to help make Adora understand how badly she wanted this for herself, for them. "But first, I want to feel exactly what those arms and that hand can do, because I trust you and know how good you'll make me feel."

Adora groaned at the sensation of Catra's tongue running across the taut muscle of her arm. The words just enhanced the sensation, making her feel as if she could lift mountains should Catra request it of her. All without the use of her warrior avatar. She was almost there, almost convinced, but the thought of misunderstanding her girlfriend's wants, even though they were being uttered so blatantly, was still too high. "Y-you're really sure about liking it? That it's what you want from me?"

Catra had had enough. She lifted her head and stared deep into her love's eyes, her own multihued ones a little flinty. She wasn't trying to pressure Adora into an act that might make her uncomfortable, but she also was through with Adora questioning her on it. She was being clear and the blonde needed to *listen.* "Adora, I need you to trust that I know what I'm asking for, that I'm aware of myself and my body. Please stop doubting me. Let me say it to you completely plain: I want you to slap my ass so hard it hurts to sit for the next day." A part of Catra could not believe she was actually saying these words out loud. Sure, this was a new discovery for her, a new facet of her fetishes she'd never really considered before. But she was also certain by the

flush of arousal deep within her it was one she wanted to follow. And she wasn't just placating the blonde earlier by saying she felt things different; just as with how she needed less regular meals, her hybrid status afforded her a ridiculously high pain tolerance. How else would she have survived her childhood otherwise?

Childhood reared its head again… Perhaps that was the root of all of this, what was truly making Adora so hesitant to use that force she knew the blonde *could* display. They were worlds apart from what she had endured in her past, because what Adora wasn't considering was how safe she had always felt under the blonde's protection. She knew without a doubt that Adora would continue to learn her body, cherish it, and do anything in her power to make sure Catra felt as good and secure as she always had. Seeing the raw power Adora had always displayed, even without She-Ra, caused a thrill to run through her body. She had so much potential for true hurt, for absolute pain… But she was a gentle soul with a guardian's heart. That innate goodness combined with fundamental strength… It did it for Catra. Adora chose to be good, chose to be just, and somehow despite all the blackness of Catra's past, chose *her* . She would take whatever the blonde gave her and beg for more, knowing in the deepest part of her heart that since Adora knew her better that anyone in the world, it would never be more than she could handle.

Nervous anticipation shot through Adora at the words, but what her girlfriend had said made her doubt disappear. Whether intentional or not, by questioning it so continually, Adora was making the decision for Catra, taking away her choice entirely under the guise of protection and care. Ultimately, she realized what Catra was asking her to do placed the responsibility for her physical well-being into Adora's attentive care.

Adora was never one to shirk from responsibility.

She raised her hand and brought the palm of it solidly against the bare, furred cheek on top of her. The resounding smack reverberated throughout the room; instantly Adora felt a high like no other, further enchanted by the deep, guttural moan that

emanated from her partner as her tail shot straight out behind her and her clawed toes curled sharply into the mattress. She knew by the reaction that, while they were relatively new to this whole sex thing, they were definitely on to something here.

"Mmm, yes, baby! Harder."

Adora blinked for a second, hesitating. *She wants it again? Harder?* She couldn't deny that she wanted to, especially after the reaction it had gotten, but she really hadn't been expecting the request so soon after. But if that's what Catra really wanted…

She obliged her love's request, getting the same enthusiastic response as before.

On an impulse, she raised her thigh after the last spank, letting Catra's wet heat roll against her leg. Adora was astounded to literally feel the throbs of her girlfriend's desire beat against her. It enthralled her to receive this physical indicator of exactly what this act was doing for her. "You like that, don't you?" Catra gave a shuddering nod of her head, pressing her face into Adora's chest, fisting up the blankets on either side of them. "Fuck, Catra, I can feel how turned on you are…"

Catra's appreciation only fueled Adora's own, she shifted once more, intent on drawing the magicat closer to her. It might not be possible, but she *needed* Catra to be closer, she craved it with every fiber of her being. As she pushed her girlfriend's body down, she rolled her hips up, grabbing into Catra's ass and firmly sliding her bare wetness against the inside of Adora's thigh just inches from her own. Catra repositioned herself, both women gasping as they came into contact with one another.

" *Oh* , mmm…" Adora moaned out as Catra panted above her, churning her slickness against Adora's. She loved how easily their bodies fit together, with every push she gave, Catra ground down on her. They moved in tandem, Adora grabbing onto Catra's ass to pull them closer together with each gliding slide of their cores. "You feel so *good* !"

“Fuck, A-adora!” Catra moaned, sitting upright to better grind herself down on her girlfriend’s pussy. “I’m fucking throbbing, baby. I want you to take me, make me yours…!”

Adora growled and with one fluid motion, flipped them, driving her thigh in Catra’s wet heat. The magicat gasped at how easily she was repositioned, her love’s muscular thigh so expertly rubbing against her need. Her hands reached up and ran down Adora’s back, claw tips lightly dragging across her skin. The blonde shivered and dipped her face down to whisper into Catra’s ear. “You’re so sexy, Catra… Come for me, baby, I want to hear you scream my name.”

Catra whimpered, the sound thin and reedy. She grinded herself into Adora’s thigh, panting heavily with every hard thrust. She bit her lip with a high pitched wail as one of Adora’s hands came up to pinch and play with her nipples, her steel-blue eyes drinking in the sight of the mouthwatering woman below her. “A-Adora!” She stuttered out, back arching as her girlfriend’s hand encompassed her entire breast, the other moving down to replace the thigh she’d been rocking against. The transition was smooth, Adora’s fingers rolling over her clit, giving her the exact right amount of pressure.

“You make such pretty noises…” Adora’s voice was like silk. “You’re so beautiful when you let me take care of you.”

The magicat gasped as her girlfriend’s middle and ring fingers entered her. Adora was able to glide in with no resistance, Catra’s hips working down to take Adora’s fingers deeper into her. “More!” She cried out, eyes squeezed shut. The blonde quickly repositioned, driving three fingers into a point into her girlfriend, slick coating them so thoroughly that she was easily able to thrust in and out. It was absolute rapture; Catra’s breath came in panting gasps, her body rigid, begging for release, but unwilling to let go of this absolute pleasure. It felt so good that she never wanted it to end.

“Come for me, baby, I want to hear you…” Adora’s teeth slide one swollen nipple, biting and rolling it around with her tongue. She could feel how close her girlfriend was, hanging on to the edge, clinging. “Hear what’s *mine…”*

Unable to hold back any longer, Catra broke with Adora’s name pouring from her lips. A second wave of pleasure quickly followed, overtaking her so that she screamed, bucking wildly against Adora’s hand, clenching and spasming. Adora gasped from the exertion of fucking her girlfriend so roughly, but did not falter in her ministrations, letting Catra enjoy every last second, absolutely everything she had to give to the beautiful, wrecked woman beneath her. The burn between her own thighs was palpable, but pleasuring Catra was first and foremost on her mind.

Catra came down from her high with a slump, body twitching as she greedily sucked in air. Even the tiniest brush electrified her, making her shudder and groan as overstimulated as she was. Adora was careful with her, but as she whimpered Catra held out her arms, begging for the blonde to cuddle her. Adora was more than happy to oblige; she tucked her love close to her as they lay on their sides facing one another, a solid presence Catra could latch on to as she returned to this plane. She let Catra cling as tightly as she needed, keeping her own breaths soothing and even. Adora kissed her forehead, whispering soft praises of how well she’d taken her, how beautiful she was, how loved, as her hands carded up and down her arms, back, anywhere she could touch.

It was so much, but so, so good. Every muscle in Catra’s body was liquid as she lay in her lover’s arms, a rumbling purr replacing the heady moans from minutes before. She let Adora’s hands trace her form, roaming where they pleased, all with the express purpose of maintaining the physical connection between them. Adora needed to feel Catra, exalt in her. She carded down her back, following the dip of each shoulder blade, tracing along her spine. Catra shivered at the attention, but the tender strokes were grounding more than overpowering. Adora reached the base of her tail, purposely forgoing the area for the time being, certain

that might be too much in the wake of her girlfriend's release. Inches lower and she cupped the firmness of Catra's ass, delicately massaging the area, being mindful of the spots her palm had struck earlier in the night. There was no wince, no shying away from her touch, but still Adora asked, "It doesn't hurt, right? Not sore?"

Catra tucked her head against Adora's chest, burying herself in between her breasts to breathe in the scent of the magnificent person she had the privilege to call hers. Concern shone through her girlfriend's voice, but it wasn't necessary. There was no ache, no redness, only a phantom buzzing of the taste of Adora's prodigious strength. Idly Catra had the thought that they'd just need to try a little harder next time- her request that it hurt to sit for the next day had been an exaggeration, but the sharp thwack of Adora's hand before the immense pleasure of being fucked? That was a juxtaposition worth exploring more in the future. Nothing to concern themselves with for the moment however. The magicat shook her head with a resolute no.

Satisfied by that answer, Adora rubbed the area for a few minutes more, before moving back up her girlfriend's body. When she landed on her shoulders once more, she massaged out some non-existent tension there, pleased that the action still resulted in some deep set rumbles of appreciation from her girlfriend's chest. Her hands trickled down Catra's upturned arm, following the flow of the light fur that resided there. As they reached her wrists, Adora's larger hand intertwined between her fingers, squeezing slightly. Her lips danced around her neck and shoulders, making small lusty noises of approval as she went. Catra purred harder into each touch, giggling slightly as Adora's breath tickled her so.

"What's so funny, kitten…" Adora cooed, giving a small nibble at the base of her girlfriend's ear.

"Mmm…" Catra's body tensed at the brush of Adora's teeth against one of her most sensitive areas. She reached a hand up, curling her fingers through flaxen locks, pushing Adora's head forward slightly. With one lean, she placed a small kiss on her girlfriend's

cheek, enchanted at being able to feel the smile spread wide across her face as she did so. "Absolutely nothing, just tickled for a second."

"Tickled, hmmm?" The smile turned a touch pointed and Catra could feel the mischievous intent rolling off Adora in waves. She started to give a warning protest, but the blonde cut her off with a swift kiss.

Catra did not relax under the guidance of the mouths lips, teeth and tongue, sensing the trap for what it was. All traces of fatigue from her release were gone, wicked away by the caress of her lover. She didn't think she could take it again like *that* any time soon, however. Adora's fingers were a blessing. She gave one small flick of her tongue against the blonde's, who groaned in vast appreciation of the action before Catra pulled away to glower at her girlfriend. "Don't even *think* about it, Adora."

"About what?" She blinked back with far too much innocence.

"About doing this!" Catra rolled and pounced, straddling the other woman. With great care to make sure her claws were completely sheathed, she began to tickle her girlfriend's sides, the woman instantly squirming and giggling below her. Adora was strong, certainly, but Catra's powerful thighs locked her in place, hand currently not wiggling against her girlfriend's ribcage reaching up to grab Adora's dominant hand and pin it to the bed, grinning at the breathless laughter below her. "Hmmm. And to think I could have just subdued the mighty She-Ra through a few ticklish spots… My younger self really was a dumbass. Always making things much harder for herself."

"Hmmm…" The pair was enshrouded in a bright light, the piercing azure eyes of the legendary warrior regarding the magicat. Where Catra's hand had just managed to secure Adora's wrist to the bed, suddenly her long fingers barely managed to come halfway around the thick forearm of She-Ra. The ethereal blonde gave one crook of her mouth, the barest flash of dazzling smile, before slotting her hands on her girlfriend's hips, lifting her straight into

the air and depositing her down on the bed. Catra shrieked in protest, tail coming to wrap around Adora's corded bicep, laughing a little as she came to rest on the mattress safely. "You think the mighty She-Ra would have let you get that close?" Adora challenged, eyes roving over her love's body, sprawled out for her. She licked her lips, quirking into a lopsided grin of utter appreciation for what she saw. She drew the magicat close to her, arms locking around Catra in a grip that would be just short of impossible to wrest free from.

"Oh, *Adora* ." Catra grinned up at her, the most willing captive in the universe. The very tip of her incisor came peeking out as she reveled in being so admired by her girlfriend. The magic of her transformation still made her fur stand on end, but the feeling was welcomed at the solid press of her Adora against her, no matter her current form. "We all know how badly you wanted me to be close to you, even then. She-Ra, Adora, didn't matter. You couldn't resist me."

Adora gave a mocking huff, superficially outraged by the absolutely truthful slander. *Duh* , of course she couldn't resist Catra, then or now. All the magicat had to do was show up and Adora would chase her to the ends of the Etheria. She wanted to defend herself, point out how it was definitely a two-way street. But as she saw the rascally glint to her love's eye, tail lashing lazily behind her, her naked form silhouetted perfection in the setting sunlight, Adora instead reached her free hand up to cup Catra's cheek, affectionately running her fingers against the woman's jaw. "Still can't. I'm weak for you."

Catra's grip loosened, eyes stuttering at the tenderness in Adora's touch, the softness of her gaze as she beheld Catra as if she were some precious and most coveted treasure. For as much as they'd been through, now, then, so much of her couldn't believe Adora would look at her like that. She couldn't even reply, too overwhelmed by the feeling of unconditional love radiating from the blonde. She lay herself down, the assuasive *thud* of Adora's heartbeat filling her ears. Catra screwed her eyes shut, trying to commit every detail of this feeling of belonging and warmth and

love to long term memory, a well she could call upon like a shield for her darkest days. She gave a shuddering exhale, tail resting against Adora's leg as strong arms encircled her.

The pair lay cuddled and close well into the evening, content to be with one another, though had switched so Catra was on top of Adora once more. Adora remained as She-Ra the entire time, not even fully conscious of the fact she hadn't resumed her much smaller form. Catra found that she really didn't care- the iron press and glowing warmth of the woman below her as they lay cuddled up was all she cared about. In fact, the longer they lay together, the more *aware* of Adora she became. The golden glow of her love's natural luminescence in this body was warm and comforting, but the muscles upon muscles through her legs, arms, and abs were scintillating to say the least, particularly since Catra was draped across her incredible body.

Slowly the tip of her tail came to tickle the inside of her girlfriend's thigh, just above the knee. Adora peeked one blazing azure eye open, corner of her mouth ticking up, but she remained wordless, just letting Catra tease her so. The magicat mirrored her love's smirk, giving an exaggerated stretch, her ass rising high into the air and pausing there as Adora sucked in a small breath. "See something you like?" The magicat grinned, her tone low and gravely. "I'd be more than happy to repay you for the *excellent* service earlier…" She licked her lips, bending to begin pressing open-mouth kisses along her love's collarbone.

Adora groaned at her girlfriend's rough tongue and the graze of her fangs against her skin. She shifted slightly, Catra giving a throaty chuckle as the muscular thigh brushed against her quickly warming center. "Ah, ah, ah. Later, love. I'm much more interested in tasting *every* inch of you…" The magicat began to map her chest with her mouth, working across and down her slowly. She ran her tongue over every chiseled pane and tantalizing bulge of muscle, taking extra care to suck and bite each swollen nipple, rolling the other between her fingers. She released one from her mouth with a loud pop, a bedeviled smirk scrawling across her lips at the guttural groan the sound elicited from the base of her

girlfriend's throat. Adora's fists were threaded into the bedding, gripping and pulling at the material as Catra moved down her torso. It was agony to be built up in such a dilatory manner, but she embraced the torture, reveling in the feel of her girlfriend's mouth. It was different as She-Ra, almost more muted, but still more than enough to bring a throbbing fever pitch between her thighs.

Eventually Catra reached the apex, pausing for a moment to drink in the sight. Her one-time enemy, her greatest nemesis... and the unquestionable love of her life, sprawled out before her, chest heaving, silently begging for Catra to eat her out. She languished in the scene, the scent of her girlfriend's arousal and magic mixing to create a heady perfume that intoxicated the senses. *"I'm weak for you."* Adora's words from earlier ran a chorus in her mind, stuttering her heart with their weight. The simple, sure truth was they were weak for one another, which only made them stronger.

She hooked her arms one under each thigh to get a better angle to dive into the bare wetness before her. Catra lowered her head down and licked a long stripe up those glistening folds, looking upwards at her beloved as she did so, locking eyes with her Adora. The startlingly blue eyes were hazy, perceptibly dimmer than normal, and overcome with desire. But as Catra focused on her clit the light that resided in them blazed becoming near blinding for just flash. Thick fingers buried themselves through her hair, urging Catra forward, demanding more. Catra groaned at the push, dying to give Adora her all. She met her with relish, the flat of her tongue lavishing the area, alternating with staccato flicks that left the mighty warrior gasping. Adora watched as her girlfriend pleasured her, strangled cries escaping as Catra's rough tongue swirled around her, honing in on that needy clit. She held Catra's head in place, tentatively grinding herself down on the mouth working her so, mindful of her strength to not let go completely. Catra groaned heavily straight into her cunt as she began to fuck her face, tonguing her with greater voracity, wordlessly encouraging her girlfriend to use her however Adora wanted.

Adora's thighs tightened around her ears as Catra's lips formed a tight seal around the blonde's clit, welcoming it into her mouth and sucking hard. A stream of profanity and praise launched themselves from her Adora's mouth, an arm draped now over her face as she wailed into the crook of her elbow. It only fueled the magicat on more, the sight of her love so ruined for her. Soon the blonde was not able to produce a single noise, so overwhelmed with the pleasure radiating from her girlfriend's expert attention.

Adora came with a choked whimper, a wholly satisfied whine of "Catra…" buzzing through her lips. This orgasm rattled her to her very bones, shaking from her core before shooting out to the ends of all her extremities. Catra could scarcely breathe from how the blonde's thighs were nearly crushing her, locking her in place as wave after wave racked through her body, but like hell she was stopping at the finish line. She let Adora hold her in place for as long as she needed, until she slackened legs thudding against the ground.

Catra, panting herself, came up to curl next to her beautifully large girlfriend. Adora was whining with every labored breath, but welcomed the soft, small thing into the nook of where her shoulder and chest met, whole body tingling with the aftershocks of one colossal orgasm. Catra purred her content, satisfied at the results of her efforts. She-Ra was wrecked for her and by her.

She might have dozed off as some point, but awoke to the feeling of supremely large hands trailing down her back, just barely grazing the base of her tail. Catra trilled at the brush, shivering and arching so she was pressed against Adora even more. The blonde chuckled at the position, two fingers tiptoeing around her hips, before slotting her palm against the upturned waist. She paused there, the picture of innocence, but Catra wasn't fooled. She smirked into her elbow, just waiting for when that hand would move lower.

Adora took her time, thumbing light circles into her hip bone, draping fingertips down her abs. The fur leading to her core was so soft, she twisted her fingers into it, then moved to trace the

stripes along her love's side. She couldn't get enough of just touching Catra in any capacity, the magicat purring her approval of the caress. Her breasts felt spectacular in her hands, mindful of the pressure she was exerting as she massaged and indulged in them. Small moans were echoing from the base of Catra's throat, she turned her girlfriends head to kiss and swallow them all for herself. Slowly her fingers trailed down, the pad of one thick digit coming to gently work against the swollen need between her love's legs. Her movements were careful, but certain.

Catra did not buck her hips wildly this time, only swayed slightly in time with the motions against her. She let the blonde's fingers glide over her folds, working her and intrinsically hitting all the right spots. Adora could do what she pleased with her body; she was hers entirely. Catra lay back to accept the touches, closing her eyes and trusting herself to the other woman. She broke softly, a small cry as she ducked her head towards her chin, tensing as the pulses racked through her. As they faded, she turned to face her love, kissing her deeply, licking into her mouth, reveling in the love and connectedness she felt for this person in this moment and always. Adora met her readily, smiling into every kiss.

"Stars above, Adora. That was…" Catra curled up on Adora's chest, legs draped over her bottom half. "What are the chances I can convince you to just stay here with me forever?"

It had been a joke, Adora was pretty sure, but not necessarily something that hadn't been fluttering in the back of her mind. The thought of returning to the Castle, of taking up the mantle of responsibility once more, and giving up all this time with Catra was so utterly unappealing. "Trust me, if I could… Catra, this time with you has been so incredible. I won't get into everything again, but just know how grateful I am that we've had this time together. I just… love you so much."

"I love you too." Her reply was cracked with the edges of tears. Dammit, Catra hated to cry. But she loved this big blonde idiot more than words could say. Adora as She-Ra continued to hold

her close. Catra was certain that even when they were out of this house, settled into whatever their new normal at the Castle would be, every night she would get to curl up against the love of her life. It would take time to transition; life among the Bright Moon citizens, her once enemies, was bound to be different (and wonderful and irritating) compared to her lonely existence in the Fright Zone. Catra had so much to atone for, so much more she wanted to accomplish with her life, but with Adora by her side for always there was no question of her success. She would walk with Adora to the ends of the universe if she had to, keep her heroine for all from overdoing it, and they would craft the life they could have never dreamed of having as scraggly rascals of the Horde.

Going back to Bright Moon Castle meant a new step towards the life they would build together, full of pit stops and uncertainties as they adjusted and grew. It wouldn't be easy, but it would be worth it. "Kinda sucks that we'll be done here soon. Guess the damage you did to the dining room wasn't completely irreversible." Catra smirked, bumping her nose against Adora's before placing a light peck on the very tip of it. "I gotta admit, I wasn't completely sure it was possible when I first got here. I thought cleaning up after your mess was going to be my life's punishment for my part in the war."

Adora grinned at the nose bump and tender kiss, but it settled into a slight frown at her girlfriend's words. "You know you don't need to be punished… I mean. That's not going to happen, not while I'm around at least. We all did things we're not proud of during that time, but it's over now."

"No, Adora. I do have things to make up for- and that's okay." Catra looked away, face expressionless. Maybe punishment wasn't the right word… Penance? Reconciliation? It was all semantics in her head. Bottom line was, she fucked shit up before and now she needed to help un-fuck it. She didn't know how or if it would ever be enough- but she owed it to the people of Etheria and herself to try. "Like you won't go back to doing the same, helping anyone with a pulse, once we're home."

Home. The word resonated with Adora; they would be going *home* . Whether that would be life in the Castle or a place of their own one day, wherever she and Catra were, that was home. She had room in her heart for everyone, all her loved ones in the Alliance, but never again would she willingly go so long without being with her Catra. “Well, not the same, same. I like to think I learned something over the past week or so…”

Catra hummed her agreement, absently pondering the course for their future, all the possibilities it held, and the work needed to get there. It was a little daunting, but a heartening thought occurred to her.

“You know, babe,” Catra said, a sly glint to her eye. “Queen Sparkles did say there were a number of royal properties out there…”

Adora nodded, putting on her most serious front. “It would pretty much be our responsibility to view them all, over time. Never know when the next intergalactic crisis will arise.”

“Absolutely. Hope you’re okay with a few more sleepovers...” Catra whispered, her tail curling around her love’s wrist.

“Every day, for the rest of my life.” Adora promised, sealing it with a soft kiss.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey, everyone. So, I know I promised you two more chapters... But it all came together pretty well with one more. Plus, isn't 15 such a lovely, round number?
>
> I am feeling so many, many things as I post this. I am beyond grateful for finding this community of readers and dare say, friends. This story would not have happened without the influence of so many people- RaptorRed for this chapter specifically, itcanprobablysmellfear, rokumonshi, and bluefeathergirl... Plus anyone who left a comment or kudos or even just read this darn thing! I thank you all from the

bottom of my heart. You cannot understand the positive effect this has had one my life, writing and creating and sharing with you all. I just hope that I gave you something that made you smile, at least once.

My first fic is finished; I can't believe it. If I can be vulnerable, when I wrote the first chapter waaaaay back when, I was so scared no one would ever read it. So much that my partner who doesn't really get fics made an AO3 account to just to make sure I'd have at least one kudos. Hah. I was new to this world, new to the fandom... Thank you for proving my insecurities dead wrong. I only hope to continue to provide you all with stories. It is a gift to share with one another.

I could go on and on about all the turns this story took- how originally it was going to be a look at how Adora and Catra couldn't stop the patterns in their lives, leading to conflict and eventual comfort. Then it became all the ways they slowly fell more and more in love with one another, ending in one passionate first time (and someone's face getting fucked so hard they walked away with a fat lip- but that will be another story, another time). Even after that blonde tugged on my arm and said "I want her" around chapter 6, it was going to be them steadily destroying the house, just like they did with that first bed and growing more and more kinky.

But instead it took its own turns, developed itself along the way. I am secure enough to say that hands down I think this contains some of my best writing, some really raw feelings, and some pretty darn good smut. Thank you for letting me share it with you.

You'll see me around plenty, with all my various AUs. I hope I continue to entertain, provide you with something worth reading... Thank you for your time, your words, and your support. You are all wonderful.

Until next time, folks.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!